Married for Life

Life-giving principles that make a marriage last

Coaching Couple's Manual

Official Curriculum of 

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PREFACE

Welcome to Married for Life!*

Ever since God healed our "impossible" marriage many years ago, it has been the desire of our hearts to share with other couples the healing and restorative power of God's Word. The Bible not only contains the prescription for the healing of broken marriages, it is also the source of God's vision and blueprint for all marriages. Married for Life is enabling couples across our nation and around the world to be reached with this exciting news concerning marriage.

Marriage was intended by God to be a vibrant, dynamic state of ever-deepening love and growth. With God's direction we can truly go from "glory to glory" in our life together as husband and wife. Married for Life is recapturing God's heart for His people in an area in which the world has totally lost the vision - marriage. An army of couples is emerging around the world—couples with God's vision in their hearts and His weapons in their hands—couples who know victory in Jesus and are prepared to share it with others. Marriages have been under attack for long enough. Now they are becoming a powerful offensive force. Come, discover the power!

With grateful hearts to Jesus,



Mike and Marilyn Phillipps
Founding Directors
2=1

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*The couples' home group course of ***2=1***.

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Acknowledgments:

We would like to take this opportunity to gratefully acknowledge all those who have helped in the formation of Married for Life. They have helped us preserve the vision of God for marriages with unwavering faith and have been instrumental in seeing that vision come to pass. Their encouragement has been invaluable.

We would like to thank all the Coaching Couples who have shared their insights and revelations with us to expand and deepen these teachings. Their feedback has provided a very special dimension that would not have been possible without them.

And finally, we would like to thank each and every couple who has gone or is now going through a Married for Life class. Each of you are vital to the team. Your growth and transformation in Jesus is our greatest reward. It is your contribution of yourselves—your time, your enthusiasm, your love, and your financial resources—that enables us to bring to pass the vision that God gave. We love you all!

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It Is Time to Rebuild The Wall



So they said, "Let us rise up and build."
Then they set their hands to do this good work."
Nehemiah 2:18b

When you read the book of Nehemiah in the Bible, you see a story of a man called to rebuild the city walls of Jerusalem - walls that had been torn down and burned by their enemies. The task was an awesome one—almost an impossible one. There were many who opposed the work, many who ridiculed Nehemiah and those he rallied to rebuild.

The people were placed along the wall in families, each to rebuild their own section so that the city might once again be safe and protected. The families faced the constant threat of enemy attack. In fact, when the wall was halfway up, they began holding a weapon in one hand and working with the other. Not only were they totally devoted to the work of rebuilding but they also were fully committed to fighting off the enemy should it become necessary.

Today the wall of protection afforded by strong families in each of our cities has been destroyed by enemy attack. The disintegration of marriage and family through the past generations has left us vulnerable. Now each family must fight its own battles without the corporate protection afforded by a strong wall.

The time has come to rebuild that wall! Just as in the day of Nehemiah, God is appointing and anointing families to rally and restore the safety and security of the homes of our land.

Families Are Key

In Nehemiah's day families stood side by side to rebuild, each at their appointed post, doing their portion of the work. Today it is also true that strong marriages and families bring strength to a city. Strong families provide corporate protection for our churches and our cities. Homes that are broken and in ruin leave our cities and the churches within them open and vulnerable to enemy attack.

The wall composed of strong families provides protection. It is the Word of God, the Bible, that provides the blueprint for rebuilding that strong wall of protection. When we use God's plan, His Word, as our blueprint and His tools, scriptural principles, we build a strong, healthy hedge of protection around our marriage and our home. Our children have a safe place in which to dwell.

The Word of God also provides boundaries, though, and as the standard that provides protection is raised, the boundaries it provides are also put in place. Many today want the protection but shun the boundaries. It is truly a time of each one doing what seems right in his own eyes.

When we do our own thing, through either ignorance or self-will, we refuse the boundaries of God's Word and consequently also lose its protection. Our cities now reflect that rejection of God's plan in the destruction of homes and families. Just as Nehemiah observed in **Nehemiah 2:14**, the destruction is so great that in some places there is nothing but rubble.

Begin Where You Are Today

Perhaps your own marriage is in rubble at this moment. Perhaps you feel like one of the burned stones that Sanballat said could never be used to build a strong wall. **[Nehemiah 4:2]** Nehemiah didn't listen to the voice of his enemy and neither should you. Jesus has great plans for you and wants to rebuild you in strength and might. As you submit to the blueprint of God's Word, accepting both His boundaries and His protection, your marriage and your home can be transformed by His power.

Or perhaps you only have a few cracks in your wall, small areas of erosion that are beginning to wear away. You recognize the need to strengthen your wall and fortify it using God's blueprint as your guide. There is no better time to begin rebuilding than when problems are first recognized. Your stones are not yet burned, your portion of the wall is not yet crumbled. Minor adjustments here and there will firmly establish your marriage on the Rock and solidify the protection of your wall.

If you now have a strong marriage, established and grounded in the Word, you have much to offer others. The strength and stability of your portion of the wall is vital to others. Many times it is hard to help others build or rebuild with any success, though, if you are not sure exactly how your portion of the wall became so strong. You need to know the blueprint you have followed so that you might share it with others. Knowing which tools from God's Word have established and strengthened your marriage will enable you to help others rebuild and strengthen their own homes and marriages.

Discover the Power

Whatever the situation of your marriage and home today, you can be blessed and grow in the Lord through an understanding and application of His blueprint for your marriage and home. Nehemiah encouraged the people, *"Do not be afraid of them. Remember the Lord, great and awesome, and fight for your brethren, your sons, your daughters, your wives, and your homes"* **[Nehemiah 4:14]**. Perhaps not since then has the call to battle been more needed than today. The sound of the trumpet can be heard in the land **[Nehemiah 4:20]** and the Lord is saying, "Rebuild!"

Welcome to Married for Life! We recognize that we are part of the army that the Lord is raising up in this hour to rebuild and strengthen the home. Our constant prayer for you is that your home might become an oasis of peace to the hurting and a lighthouse to those lost in darkness. Make the most of these next twelve weeks—for yourselves and for others who need encouragement as they take their places along the wall. One by one, as we link strong and fortified homes together in Christ, the protection and the boundaries of God will be evidenced in our cities and our churches. Whether your stones are burned and crumbled today or whether your walls are only slightly eroded, or whether you have a strong, fortified portion of the wall, we all need you. Be blessed and be a blessing!



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THE VISION

We welcome you to your Married for Life class. We know you are going to be blessed here and that your marriage will never again be the same!

When God first gave the mission for this ministry, He expressed it in a vision of millions of twinkling lights around the world. There was one on every block, around every corner. God said that each one of those twinkling lights was a powerhouse Christian home where the peace and the power of the Lord so radiated that each one was an oasis to the thirsty world around them. God promised that He would raise them up around the world. These homes would be the product of godly couples seeking the Lord's will for their own one-flesh relationship and desiring to minister to others. They would be free of strife and endowed with power to tear down enemy strongholds, setting others free in Jesus' name.

Powerful one-flesh teams have now begun to cover the earth. Today is your day to begin transforming your home into a peaceful oasis for your neighborhood. During the next twelve weeks you are going to be led of the Spirit into exciting new concepts for your marriage. You will learn what a true "one-flesh" relationship is and how to realize the fulfillment of that in your lives. You will acquire knowledge and wisdom that, when applied, will enable your home to be free from strife. Sowing and reaping peace, contentment and harmony will become a routine part of your married life. You will learn to effectively fight spiritual warfare on behalf of your spouse and your children. You will see lives drastically changed by the Word of God. And you will learn how to reproduce these miracles of God in the lives of others.

ORGANIZATION

Each Married for Life home class is composed of a maximum of seven couples. The leadership team may consist of a Coaching Couple and another couple in training to be a Coaching Couple or two Coaching Couples working together. The class meets weekly and couples are asked to commit to attending each week. When the class is finished, they may opt to continue again through the basic course, branch out into ministry, and/or continue on in deeper one-flesh teachings. The last week of class you will be provided with information regarding available one-flesh ministry opportunities.

When the class is finished, a Graduation Night will be held. This is your time to celebrate and you are encouraged to invite family and friends. This is also an information night regarding all the resources of ***2=1***, so invite any and all couples you know who are interested in being in a Married for Life class. They will be given an opportunity to sign up and become part of the new classes that will be forming.

THE CORE VALUES OF *2=1*

These are the principles upon which this ministry is based.

- Are unchangeable
- Determine the form and the flow of ministry
- Determine what is negotiable and what is not
- Help people identify their call
- Are the basis for reproducibility

2=1's CORE VALUES

1. Everything we do must point people to the Lordship of Jesus.
   Jesus is the only way to the Father and to eternal life.
2. Powerhouse homes flow in the power of the Holy Spirit.
   The power of the Holy Spirit changes the believer from within and then flows outward to others.
3. Marriage is a covenant relationship.
   Marriage relationship and commitment is to reflect the Lord's covenant relationship with His Church.
4. Marriage between a man and a woman is the basis for God's plan for family.
   God established marriage in the Garden of Eden with a man and a woman and gave us His blueprint.
5. We are to make disciples of all nations.
   Discipling is based in relationship and includes training, modeling, and accountability.
6. We are to produce fruit with the seed of reproducibility.
   Our goal is not to make others dependent on us but rather teach them to develop a deepening relationship with the Lord and reach out to others in His name.
7. When a couple marries, their individual call and destiny are blended together.
   The synergism of one-flesh enables a couple to accomplish far more than they ever could alone.
8. Homes are points of outreach to a lost world.
   ***2=1** classes meet in homes to remind us that God desires to reach our neighborhoods from our homes, lighthouses shining in the darkness.*
9. God views families generationally.
   The decisions we make today affect the families of tomorrow.
10. We are an army.
    We need to flow together as a one in obedience to the commands and direction of our Head, Jesus Christ.

WHAT YOU CAN EXPECT

Guidelines to maximize your time during this course:

1. We will meet once a week for approximately two to two-and-one-half hours. Please be on time and plan to stay the entire time.
2. If you have any questions during the teaching or miss a word, please make a note and bring them up during the clarification period at the end of the teaching. Please do not interrupt the teaching.
3. The Question and Answer period after the teaching is to clarify any point that may not have been clear or a word that you missed. It is not a time to debate what has been taught or to offer your opinion. If you disagree with the teaching, we ask that you do your Life Application and see if it makes more sense to you then. If after you do this you still disagree, contact your Coaching Couple and ask to meet with them.
4. What is said in the group, stays in the group. Please honor others by maintaining confidentiality.
5. No new couples may visit or join the group once the class has begun.
6. All materials used or recommended here must first be approved by ***2=1*** International Headquarters in Colorado. This includes tapes and books. This group is not to be used by group members as a distribution area for handouts or any other materials or for multi-level marketing recruitment.
7. There are to be no children at Married for Life meetings. This includes babies.
8. Meetings **are not to be taped** under any circumstances.

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YOUR WORKBOOK

As couples listen to the lesson, they will need to fill in the blanks in their notebook with the words from the teaching. Make sure you use the words that are bolded and underlined in each lesson as they are the ones that are used to fill in the blanks.

We recommend that couples use their Bibles when looking up scriptures rather than have the verses printed out for them. Scriptures are bolded in each lesson to make the reference easy to see. This will help couples become more familiar with their Bibles.

PERMISSION TO SHARE WITH PASTOR

Sometimes pastors ask how couples who are members of their church are doing in the Married for Life course. Encourage the couples to share with their pastor how they are doing. We prefer that they are the ones who communicate with their pastor.

COMMITMENT

The first step in any change is a determined commitment to that purpose. If you are serious about making changes in your marriage, we ask you to commit to attending each week for the duration of this Married for Life class.

We ask you to discuss this together as a couple and if this is where you believe God is calling you, please signify your commitment to God and each other by signing the following agreement. This is not a promise to us - but to each other and to our Father of your determination to seek His best. He is faithful! You are going to be amazed at what you see Him do.

Father,

We acknowledge that You recognize us as one. We want to know in a greater measure what this means - to discover the power. We want to live in peace and harmony using Your scriptural principles to accomplish this. We want our home to be an oasis of peace to Your glory. We commit today to acquiring Your best for our marriage and home.

We lay aside all preconceived ideas, notions, and philosophies that we have regarding marriage, good or bad. We give you permission to work in our hearts whatever we need to grow in our relationship with You and with each other.

We agree also to respect the rights of the other couples who are in our class. We will keep confidential all that is shared here and will expect the same of others. We support others in their growth as one-flesh couples and desire to do nothing that would hinder that growth. We also agree to pray for the other couples in our group weekly.

_____

Husband Wife

_____

Date

"***2=1*** is a teaching ministry and offers no professional or clinical counseling. ***2=1*** does not present its staff or field leadership as medical or psychological experts capable of dealing with severe emotional or psychological disorders. ***2=1*** courses or materials are not intended as a substitute for professional or pastoral counseling."

WHERE IT'S AT

THE VISION.....7
ORGANIZATION 7
2=1 CORE VALUES 8
WHAT YOU CAN EXPECT.....8
YOUR WORKBOOK 9
PERMISSION TO SHARE WITH PASTORS.....9
COMMITMENT 9

LESSONS

1 - THE POWER OF COVENANT.....11
2 - THE POWER OF 2=1.....27
3 - THE POWER OF SYNERGISM 45
4 - THE POWER OF SOWING AND REAPING 67
5 - THE POWER OF FORGIVENESS.....85
6 - THE POWER OF FAITH.....97
7 - THE POWER OF SPIRITUAL INTIMACY.....115
8 - THE POWER OF AGREEMENT.....133
9 - THE POWER OF PHYSICAL INTIMACY.....147
10 -THE POWER OF SPIRITUAL WARFARE 163
11- THE POWER OF TRANSFORMATION.....181
12- THE POWER OF ONE.....199
EXIT EVALUATIONS 219

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Week 1

The Power of Covenant

WEEKLY PRAYER FOCUS

When the Coaching Team Meets to Pray

WEEK 1 - THE POWER OF COVENANT

GOAL: To give couples a deeper understanding of the meaning and power of covenant, the blessings contained in covenant relationship with God, and the benefits of marriage covenant available to those in Christ.

INSTRUCTION: Give opportunity to those who need to receive Jesus as their Lord and Savior. This may be done after the lesson is taught, during the Life Application, or during the discussion next week.

PRAYER FOCUS: Intercede for all members of your group who are not saved. Pray for couples to grasp the depth of their covenant relationship. Pray for wisdom concerning specific needs of your couples. Begin now praying for each week's financial giving, for an understanding in each couple of blessing as they are being blessed.

Coaching Team:

Personal Prayer Needs _____

_____

_____

_____

_____

Ministry Prayer Needs _____

_____

_____

_____

_____

Notes from Prayer Time:

Praise Reports:

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WEEKLY COACHING TIPS

WHAT TO DO

Welcome the couples to your home. Have each one share a bit about themselves; how long married, how many children, etc. Ice-breakers can be a big help to put couples at ease. You are setting the tone for the rest of the time you will be together. Help create a warm, friendly environment.

GIFT PACKET

Give each couple their welcome gift packet. Tell them about our website www.2equal1.com

CERTIFICATES

Have the couples **PRINT** their names, address, and phone number on the Week 1 Impact Report (See Forms Section in back of this manual). ***The way their names are written on this form is how they will appear on their graduation certificate*** so please make sure they are easy to read and are the names they want used on their certificate.

WELCOMING PRAYER

Open with a short prayer thanking the Lord for what He is going to do in each couple's marriage.

CLASS ORIENTATION

Go over the Vision, Organization, and Commitment sections on pages 7 and 9 and What You Can Expect on page 8. Talk about sharing with their pastor (page 9). Have couples read and sign the commitment on page 9.

The Core Values of the ministry are listed on page 8 of the Couples' manual. Couples can read these on their own time, but let them know you are open to talking about anything they question or don't understand.

GIVING OPPORTUNITIES

This first week it would be good to share how the class will run. It is also a good time to explain why they will have an opportunity to give financially and how the funds are used, why there are no questions during the teaching, what questions of clarification are, etc. It is also the time to set the stage for couples leaving right after the class so that the Holy Spirit can begin working with them individually.

TEACH THE LESSON

Follow guidelines on page 29 for teaching and class wrap up.

A Second Interactive

We have given you one interactive with each lesson. Many Coaching Couples have asked for a **second** one each week.

If you would like to do a **second** interactive, you may choose the topic and the question. Time the interactive for three minutes.

Along with the interactive provided, this should give you the opportunity to provide a second one and the flexibility to change the topic each time you teach if you would like.

* Don't forget to make sure the underlined words are used in the teaching. These are the words couples will be looking for to complete their notes.

See the Forms Section in the back of this manual for help with completing weekly Impact Forms.

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A. What Is a Covenant?

1. Covenant is the **foundation** upon which marriage between a man and a woman is built.
2. Contracts are based on performance.
   a. When one partner fails to live up to the terms of the contract, the contract is broken.
   b. The other partner is freed from the agreement.
3. A covenant is based on what the partners promise at the time the covenant is made.
   a. A covenant is a solemn agreement to join together as one for the mutual benefit of the partners.
   b. Their promise of fidelity is not based on what the other partner does.
   c. It is based on word pledged at the time the covenant is made.
4. A covenant partner does not look to the other partner to determine the **strength** of the covenant.
   a. His or her own words are what determine the strength of the bond.
5. In a contract the deciding factor is the performance of the other partner.
6. In a covenant the deciding factor is what was promised when the covenant was made.
7. Every covenant contains specific promises and terms.
   a. The promises express the commitment of the covenant partners to each other.
      (1) They are the pledge of their fidelity to keep the covenant.
      (2) Promises always specify what they agree to do as covenant partners.
   b. The terms specify the conditions under which the partners will fulfill their agreement.
      (1) Terms also indicate the duration of the covenant, that is, how long the partners expect to honor it.
      (2) The terms of a covenant may or may not include an oath or vow.
8. The covenant God made with Abraham is an example of God's heart in covenant.
   a. God said, *"As for me, behold, My covenant is with you and you shall be a father of many nations"* **[Genesis 17:4]**.
   b. God's promise to Abraham was that he would become the father of many nations through Isaac.
9. Abraham and Sarah became impatient and so took matters into their own hands.
   a. Abraham fathered a child by Sarah's maid, Haggar.
   b. God's covenant partner, Abraham, made a big mistake.
      1) It did not change God's covenant **faithfulness**.
      2) God continued to walk with Abraham and gave him the child.
      3) God fulfilled His covenant promise not because Abraham performed as expected but because God had said what He would do when the covenant was made.

Interactive

When you married, did you think you were making a covenant or a contract? Take three minutes right now and discuss as a husband and wife what your expectations were when you were married.

(Time three minutes and then continue teaching)

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What Is a Covenant?

Covenant is the **foundation** upon which marriage between a man and a woman is built. So in our journey to discover God's plan for marriage, we begin with the foundation.

There is a great difference between a covenant and a contract. Contracts are based on performance. When one partner fails to live up to the terms of the contract, the contract is broken and the other partner is freed from the agreement.

A covenant, on the other hand, is based on what the covenant partners promise at the time the covenant is made. A covenant is a solemn agreement to join together as one for the mutual benefit of the partners. Their promise of fidelity is not based on what the other partner does, but on word pledged at the time the covenant is made. A covenant partner does not look to the other partner to determine the **strength** of the covenant, but knows that his or her own words are what determine the strength of the bond. In a contract the deciding factor is the performance of the other partner. In a covenant the deciding factor is what was promised when the covenant was made.

Every covenant contains specific promises and terms. The promises express the commitment of the covenant partners to each other. They are the pledge of their fidelity to keep the covenant. Promises always specify what they agree to do as covenant partners. The terms specify the conditions under which the partners will fulfill their agreement. Terms also indicate the duration of the covenant, that is, how long the partners expect to honor it. The terms of a covenant may or may not include an oath or vow.

An example of God's heart in covenant can be found in the covenant God made with Abraham. God said, *"As for me, behold, My covenant is with you and you shall be a father of many nations"* **[Genesis 17:4].** God's promise to Abraham was that he would become the father of many nations through the child God promised they were to have, Isaac.

Abraham and his wife Sarah became impatient that no child had come and so took matters into their own hands and Abraham fathered a child by Sarah's maid, Haggar. God's covenant partner, Abraham, made a big mistake, but it did not change God's covenant **faithfulness**. God continued to walk with Abraham and gave him the child He had promised. He made Abraham the father of many nations, not because he performed as expected but because God had said what He would do when the covenant was made.

Interactive

When you married, did you think you were making a covenant or a contract? Take three minutes right now and discuss as a husband and wife what your expectations were when you were married.

(Time three minutes and then continue)

PERSONAL EXAMPLES

B. Two Types of Covenant; God to humanity and person to person.

1. There are eight covenants recorded in the Bible between **God and humanity**.
   a. Each covenant reveals God's perfect will and purpose for humanity **[Psalm 111]** and reflects His love, grace, and mercy.
   b. Through His covenants with people, God reveals Himself as a covenant-**keeping** God as well as a covenant-making God **[Isaiah 54:10, Psalm 89:34]**.
   c. In His covenant partner role, God proves that He is faithful to His covenant even when His human partner is not.
   d. It is evident that it is God who enables and strengthens people to keep the covenant **[Psalm 89:28-29;2 Timothy 1:12; 2 Corinthians 3:4 6]**.

2. Person to person covenants are made between two people to provide a binding commitment between them and those they represent.
   a. All their possessions, goods, wealth and power are exchanged.
   b. In **1 Samuel 18:1-4**, Jonathan and David made a man to man covenant.
      1) The things which Jonathan gave David are representative of all of the things which are exchanged in a man-man covenant:
      2) the cloak, a symbol of wealth
      3) the garments, a symbol of possessions
      4) the sword, a symbol of strength
      5) the belt, a symbol of protection

3. Entering into covenant relationship means death to **independent** living.
   a. Covenant partners agree to lay down their lives for each other.
   b. They place the needs of the other partner ahead of their own.
   c. Through this death to self
      1) Their strengths are pooled and used as mutual protection.
      2) One goes to battle for the other as readily as if he himself had been attacked.

C. Marriage Is a Covenant

1, The Bible makes it clear that marriage is a covenant between a man and a woman.
   a. **Malachi 2:14 (NIV)**, (to the man) *"... It is because the Lord is acting as the witness between you and the wife of your youth, because you have broken faith with her, though she is your partner, the wife of your marriage covenant."*
   b. **Proverbs 2:17 (NIV)**, (to the woman) *"...who has left the partner of her youth and ignored the covenant she made before God."*

2. God established the **pattern** for all creation in the Garden of Eden.
   a. "*Then God said, 'Let Us make man in Our image, according to Our likeness'... So God created man in His own image; in the image of God He created him; male and female He created them."*
   b. *Then God blessed them, and God said to them, 'Be fruitful and multiply; fill the earth and subdue it...'* " **[Genesis 1:26-28]**.
   c. *"Then the rib which the Lord God had taken from man He made into a woman, and He brought her to the man... Therefore a man shall leave his father and mother and be joined to his wife, and they shall become one flesh"* **[Genesis 2:22 and 24]**.
   d. It is clear that the pattern He established for marriage from the beginning is one man and one woman united as one in a covenant relationship designed to create offspring.
   e. God created marriage and He **defined** it.

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Two Types of Covenant; God to humanity and person to person.

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- Each covenant reveals God's perfect will and purpose for humanity **[Psalm 111]** and reflects His love, grace, and mercy.
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Marriage Is a Covenant

The Bible makes it clear that marriage is a covenant between a man and a woman. **Malachi 2:14 (NIV)**, (to the man) *"... It is because the Lord is acting as the witness between you and the wife of your youth, because you have broken faith with her, though she is your partner, the wife of your marriage* ***covenant****."* **Proverbs 2:17 (NIV)**, (to the woman) *"...who has left the partner of her youth and ignored the* ***covenant*** *she made before God."*

God established the **pattern** for all creation in the Garden of Eden. "Then God said, *'Let Us make man in Our image, according to Our likeness'... So God created man in His own image; in the image of God He created him; male and female He created them. Then God blessed them, and God said to them, 'Be fruitful and multiply; fill the earth and subdue it...'* **Genesis 1 26-28**.

"Then the rib which the Lord God had taken from man He made into a woman, and He brought her to the man... Therefore a man shall leave his father and mother and be joined to his wife, and they shall become one flesh" **[Genesis 2:22 and 24].** It is clear that the pattern He established for marriage is one man and one woman united as one in a covenant relationship designed to create offspring. God created marriage and He **defined** it.

PERSONAL EXAMPLES

3. The components of a marriage covenant are
   a. promises “to love, honor, cherish, and obey”.
   b. terms “for better or for worse, for richer or poorer, and until death do us part”.
   c. and vows “I do” or “I will”.
4. Marriage vows are important.
   a. **Ecclesiastes 5:4,5** tells us it is better not to vow at all than to vow and not keep our word.
   b. As covenant partners we can hold each other **accountable** to the covenant promises we made **[Jeremiah 3:14; Numbers 30:2]**.
5. Marriage covenant brings death to independent living.
   a. When we entered into God’s plan for marriage, it was no longer just “me” but now “we.”
   b. As covenant partners, we also exchanged all that we previously held separately.
      1) According to **1 Corinthians 7:4**, even our bodies were given to each other.
      2) All our goods, our wealth, belong to each other jointly.
      3) Two become one **[Ephesians 5:31]** and in covenant everything belongs to the one.
6. If couples do not understand this exchange and mutual sharing of everything, problems can arise in a marriage.
   a. Financial disagreements often center around “my” salary or “your” debt.
   b. Gifts or inheritances given to one can be viewed as belonging exclusively to that one and not to the covenant relationship.
   c. When death to self is not understood, strife and division often result.
7. Children are also **included** in covenant exchange.
   a. Stepchildren belong as much to the stepparent as they do to the natural parent.
      1) If stepchildren are considered to belong exclusively to their natural parent, it sets the family up for strife and rebellion.
      2) It gives children power to separate the husband and wife.
   b. Jesus was a stepchild and He is the example of stepchildren in all such homes.
   c, **Luke 2:51** says Jesus submitted Himself in obedience to (was subject to) ***them***; both His natural parent, Mary, and His stepparent, Joseph.

D. God’s Plan For Marriage

1. God created marriage in the Garden of Eden as the first man to woman covenant. **[Genesis 2:24]**.
   a. He also had a God to humanity covenant with that first couple **[Genesis 1:27,28]**.
   b. When a couple entering into a marriage covenant also has a covenant with God, they have both a God to humanity **and** a man to woman covenant.
   c. Marriage as God designed it is then theirs to enjoy **[Jeremiah 32:38-41]**.
2. In the Garden of Eden, Adam and Eve broke covenant with God for all mankind.
   a. For mankind to reenter into covenant with God, someone who was still in covenant with God had to die in their place so that a new covenant could be made.
   b. There was no one left on earth who was still in eternal covenant with God.
   c. **Jesus** came to earth as God and walked as man **[Philippians 2:5-7]**.
3. Jesus went to the cross to pay the price for our sins and to die in our place.
   a. When He rose from the dead, He established the New Covenant with God.
   b. All who receive Him as Lord and Savior are freed to enter into this New Covenant.

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The components of a marriage covenant are promises "to love, honor, cherish, and obey", **terms** "for better or for worse, for richer or poorer, and until death do us part", and **vows** "I do" or "I will".

Marriage vows are important. **Ecclesiastes 5:4,5** tells us it is better not to vow at all than to vow and not keep our word. As covenant partners we can hold each other **accountable** to the covenant promises we made **[Jeremiah 3:14; Numbers 30:2]**.

Marriage covenant brings death to independent living. When we entered into God's plan for marriage, we agreed that it was no longer just "me" but it had become "we." As covenant partners, we also exchanged all that we previously held separately. According to **1 Corinthians 7:4**, even our bodies were given to each other. All our goods, our wealth, belong to each other jointly. God says that the two become one **[Ephesians 5:31]** and in covenant everything belongs to the one.

If couples do not understand this complete exchange and mutual sharing of everything, certain problems can arise in a marriage. Financial disagreements often center around "my" salary or "your" debt. Gifts or inheritances given to one or the other can be viewed as belonging exclusively to that one and not to the covenant relationship. When death to self is not understood and the good of the covenant relationship is not the prime concern of both partners, strife and division often result.

Children are also **included** in covenant exchange. Stepchildren belong as much to the stepparent as they do to the natural parent. If stepchildren are considered to belong exclusively to their natural parent, it sets the family up for strife and rebellion and gives the children power to separate the husband and wife. Jesus was a stepchild and He is the example of stepchildren in all such homes. **Luke 2:51** says that Jesus submitted Himself in obedience to (was subject to) ***them;*** both His natural parent, Mary, and His stepparent, Joseph.

God's Plan For Marriage

When God created marriage in the Garden of Eden as the first man to woman covenant **[Genesis 2:24]**, He also had a God to humanity covenant with that first couple. **[Genesis 1:27,28]** When a couple entering into a marriage covenant also has a covenant with God, they have both a God to humanity and a man to woman covenant. Marriage as God designed it is then theirs to enjoy **[Jeremiah 32:38-41]**.

So how do we enter into covenant with God? In the Garden of Eden, Adam and Eve broke covenant with God for all mankind. For mankind to reenter into covenant with God, someone who was still in covenant with God had to die in their place so that a new covenant could be made. There was no one left on earth who was still in eternal covenant with God. So **Jesus** came to earth as God and walked as man **[Philippians 2:5-7]**.

Jesus went to the cross to pay the price for our sins and to die in our place. When He rose from the dead, He established the New Covenant with God and all who receive Him as Lord and Savior are freed to enter into this New Covenant. As covenant partners with God, all that He has is now ours.

Jesus is now the **only** way to relationship with God **[John 14:6; 1 John 2:23; John 15:23]**. We cannot work our way to God or win His approval by a good life. *"All*

PERSONAL EXAMPLES

c. As covenant partners with God, all that He has is now ours.

4. Jesus is now the **only** way to relationship with God **[John 14:6; 1 John 2:23; John 15:23]**.
   b. We cannot work our way to God or win His approval by a good life. *"All our righteous acts are like filthy rags"* **[Isaiah 64:6]**. Jesus is the only one who paid the price and established the covenant.
   b. **Ephesians 2:12 and 13 (Amplified)**, describes life without Jesus. *"Remember that you were at that time separated (living apart) from Christ - excluded from all part in Him; utterly estranged and outlawed from the rights of Israel as a nation, and strangers with no share in the sacred compacts of the [Messianic] promise - with no knowledge of or right in God's agreements, His covenants. And you had no hope - no promise; you were in the world without God. But now in Christ Jesus, you who once were [so] far away, through (by, in) the blood of Christ have been brought near."*
5. God is a **witness** to our marriage on the day we are married **[Malachi 2:14]**.
   a. If neither partner is in covenant with God, God cannot be an active part of the marriage.
   b. God becomes a covenant partner as soon as one spouse enters into covenant with God through Jesus Christ.
   c. **1 Corinthians 7:14 in the Amplified Version** says, *"For the unbelieving husband is set apart (separated, withdrawn from heathen contamination and affiliated with the Christian people) by union with his consecrated (set-apart) wife; and the unbelieving wife is set apart and separated through union with her consecrated husband..."* The spouse who is not in covenant with God is sanctified or set apart for the sake of their children. However, to be in covenant with God, each person has to enter into covenant through Jesus Christ **[Romans. 3:22-24]**.
6. When a marriage begins with both spouses knowing Jesus as their Lord and Savior, or just as soon as both of them have entered into relationship with Him after their marriage, the couple is ready to move into the fullness of the covenant relationship that God intended for marriage to be from the beginning.
   a. When God is in covenant with each partner through the New Covenant of Jesus Christ and the couple is covenanted together in marriage according to the plan of God, through Jesus they are **redeemed** back to all that God intended marriage to be when He first created it in the Garden of Eden.
   b. They now have the potential for the oneness **[Ecclesiastes 4:9-12]** and power **[Acts 1:8]** that God planned for them.
   c. They are ready to discover the power!

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our righteous acts are like filthy rags" **[Isaiah 64:6]**. Jesus is the only one who paid the price and established the covenant.

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God is a **witness** to our marriage on the day we are married **[Malachi 2:14]**, but if neither partner is in covenant with God, God cannot be an active part of the marriage. God becomes a covenant partner as soon as one spouse enters into covenant with God through Jesus Christ. **1 Corinthians 7:14 in the Amplified Version** says, *"For the unbelieving husband is set apart (separated, withdrawn from heathen contamination and affiliated with the Christian people) by union with his consecrated (set-apart) wife; and the unbelieving wife is set apart and separated through union with her consecrated husband..."* The spouse who is not in covenant with God is sanctified or set apart for the sake of their children. However, to be in covenant with God, each person has to enter into covenant through Jesus Christ **[Romans. 3:22-24]**.

When a marriage begins with both spouses knowing Jesus as their Lord and Savior, or just as soon as both of them have entered into relationship with Him after their marriage, the couple is ready to move into the fullness of the covenant relationship that God intended for marriage to be from the beginning. When God is in covenant with each partner through the New Covenant of Jesus Christ and the couple is covenanted together in marriage according to the plan of God, through Jesus they are **redeemed** back to all that God intended marriage to be when He first created it in the Garden of Eden. They now have the potential for the oneness **[Ecclesiastes 4:9-12]** and power **[Acts 1:8]** that God planned for them. They are ready to discover the power!

PERSONAL EXAMPLES

Life Application - Let's make it real

1. Describe in your own words what covenant relationship means to the two of you.

2. What were the words of your covenant agreement on your wedding day?

3. According to what you spoke, what are the promises of your marriage covenant?

What are the terms?

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Did you vow before God?

"Whatever your lips utter you must be sure to do, because you made your vow freely to the Lord your God with your own mouth" [Deuteronomy 23:23].

Sometimes couples feel that it was not God's will for them to marry and, therefore, the marriage should not continue. Maybe they just failed to ask Him or maybe they actually went against His will by marrying. For example, a believer may have married an unbeliever.

It is evident from scripture that God intends for man to man covenants to be honored even when they are not of His choosing. When the Israelites entered the Promised Land they were instructed to annihilate the inhabitants and to possess the land. They were not to make covenant with any of the people. **Joshua 9** recounts the story of the Gibeonites who were inhabitants of the Promised Land. Fearing the Israelites, they pretended to come from a far off land by dressing in old clothes and carrying dry, moldy provisions. The Israelites failed to ask God regarding this people and, believing they were not local inhabitants, made a covenant with them. This covenant was not of God's choosing. In fact, it was in direct violation of His command.

Yet, God told them they had to honor the covenant they had made. In **Joshua 10**, to honor their covenant they were even forced to go to war to protect the Gibeonites. Hundreds of years later, when David inquired of the Lord regarding a three-year famine in the land of Israel, the Lord informed him it was because Saul and his household had killed Gibeonites **[2 Sam. 21:1-6]**. When the Gibeonites were allowed to take revenge on Saul's household because they had violated the covenant, the famine ended. God honors covenants—even ones that are not of His own choosing—and He expects the covenant makers to do the same.

A Brief Study of God to Man Covenants

THE COVENANT IN EDEN

God made His first God-man covenant in the Garden of Eden with Adam and Eve. When Adam and Eve fell into sin and that covenant was broken, God immediately set into motion a series of covenants, seven more in all, geared to bring about the redemption of man back into relationship with Him. The connecting thread that runs throughout them demonstrates the faithfulness and undying love of our covenant-keeping God. In order to fully understand our covenant relationship with our Lord and our marriage covenant with each other, we need to briefly follow the covenant line through the Bible.

THE COVENANT WITH ADAM

Read **Genesis 3:15**.

What promise did God make as His part of the covenant?

THE COVENANT WITH NOAH

Read **Genesis 6:5-9**.

One man found favor with God to continue the line of planned salvation for mankind. When He destroyed all life upon the earth, God spared Noah and his family and made a covenant with them.

Read **Genesis 9:11-17**. What promise did God make to mankind in this covenant?

THE COVENANT WITH ABRAHAM Read **Genesis 15:4-18**.

God now chose a specific group of people through which the Redeemer of man would come. Everything God possessed became available to Abraham when the covenant was cut and everything that Abraham possessed become available to God.

What was the sign (seal) of the covenant? **[Genesis 17:10]**.

In **Genesis 22:2**, God demanded something of Abraham as His covenant partner. What was it?

In covenant relationship, when one partner demands something of the other, the one demanding must be willing to give the same thing in return. When God demanded Abraham's only son, He was free by covenant agreement to sacrifice _____.

THE COVENANT WITH MOSES Read **Exodus 19:5,6**.

There is much to the Mosaic covenant, but for now we will concentrate on the giving of the law to the Jewish people. In **Exodus 20** the Ten Commandments were given to Moses on the stone tablets. Throughout the books of Exodus, Leviticus, and Numbers more and more laws were given. Yet the law only served to show that none could be made clean (righteous) by observing the law. Read **Romans 7:7-25**. This passage makes it clear that the Mosaic Law only made man's need for a Savior more evident.

THE COVENANT IN THE WILDERNESS Read **Deuteronomy 8**.

Again, when man failed to keep covenant with God, He made yet another covenant in His continuing desire to restore mankind. The first generation of Jews wandering in the desert had failed to keep both the Abrahamic and the Mosaic covenants, so God gave another covenant to the second generation. This covenant pertained to their possession of the Promised Land and contains the word "land" approximately 180 times. It reaffirmed and amplified the previous covenants. It was clearly a covenant delineating conditions for daily living.

The key word in the terms of this covenant was _____ [Read **Deuteronomy 8:20; 11:13; 28:1,2; 28:15 and 30:8]**.

THE COVENANT WITH DAVID Read **2 Samuel 7:11-16 and 1 Chronicles 17:10-14**.

Now that God had provided and protected the plan for the redemption of man throughout history, He laid the final foundation for Jesus' coming in His covenant with David.

What does God promise in **2 Samuel 7:13**?

What does God promise in **2 Samuel 7:16**?

Through this covenant the throne and kingdom of David were established, pointing ultimately to the eternal kingdom and throne of David's seed. **Revelation 3:7** reveals the fulfillment of the Davidic covenant to be _____ .

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THE NEW COVENANT Read **Romans 5:12-14** and **1 Corinthians 15:45-49**.

When Adam fell, all men were excluded from an eternal relationship with God. Jesus paid the price for that reunion to take place, and there is no way we can be in relationship with God the Father apart from receiving Jesus personally. God does not recognize religious traditions or honor membership in a certain church or group as a ticket to heaven. Spiritual death came upon mankind when Adam and Eve sinned in the Garden. A spiritually dead person cannot enter into the kingdom of the living God. A spiritually dead person can have no fellowship with God. There is no way that we can earn our way into a relationship with Him. There is no religious ritual that can cleanse us of our sins. Jesus paid the price for our entrance into God's kingdom. His blood is the only thing that can wash sin away. It is only through receiving Him personally as Lord and Savior that our spirits can come alive. Initially we were born physically. When we receive Jesus, our spirit is reborn, thus, we are born again. Jesus explained it clearly in **John 3**.

Since covenant relationship is reserved for those who have a personal relationship with the living God, had either one or both of you entered into a personal relationship with Jesus before you were married?

Describe your experience of receiving Jesus as Lord and Savior.

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If this occurred after the marriage had taken place, God was given access to your marriage at that point. If this was your case, when did this occur in your marriage?

Perhaps you cannot remember a specific time that you asked Jesus to be Lord of your life. Or perhaps you have gone to church all your life and have known about Jesus, but do not know Him personally. He is real! He wants a personal relationship with you. If you would like to make that a reality today, say the following prayer out loud to Him. **Romans 10:9** says, *"If you confess with your mouth, 'Jesus is Lord', and believe in your heart that God raised Him from the dead, you will be saved."*

Jesus, I recognize that there is no way that I can earn forgiveness for my sins. I receive what You did for me on the cross of Calvary. I ask You to forgive all my sins and I receive You as my Lord and my Savior today. Take over my life, Lord, and I will follow You as You lead. I renounce my old way of life and any sinful hold it had on me. I love You, Jesus, and I believe that I am now legally a member of Your family and a resident in Your kingdom. Jesus, You are my Lord!

If you have prayed this prayer, you are now born again. Your spirit has come to life in Jesus and every covenant promise is now yours. As a final step to seal this agreement before God and man, sign your name below and put today's date. If doubt ever surfaces again, look back to this date and remember it is accomplished.

_____
DATE

_____
Husband

_____
Wife

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Week 2

The Power of 2=1

WEEKLY PRAYER FOCUS

When the Coaching Team Meets to Pray

WEEK 2 - THE POWER OF 2=1

GOAL: To gain an understanding of what happens when 2 equal 1 and what it was created to be, how the original plan of God was interrupted at the fall of man, and that Jesus has redeemed couples back to the original plan for marriage.

INSTRUCTION: Remember that the focus of this lesson is the power of marriage as God created it, not divorce and remarriage. That is only one aspect of the lesson. Do not let it become your focus. Help couples to see the potential of their relationship together and the power of God working on their behalf. During the discussion time have each couple share their salvation experience and what it has meant to them. Minister after the meeting to any couple who needs help.

PRAYER FOCUS: Continue intercession for anyone in the group who has not given their life to Christ. Keep in prayer those couples that have repented and been set free in Jesus from condemnation. Pray specifically as the Holy Spirit directs. Pray for faithful financial giving.

Coaching Team:

Personal Prayer Needs _____

_____

_____

_____

_____

Ministry Prayer Needs _____

_____

_____

_____

_____

Notes from Prayer Time:

Praise Reports:

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WEEKLY COACHING TIPS

GUIDELINES FOR WEEKLY MARRIED FOR LIFE MEETING FOR WEEKS 2 - 12

- **Fellowship time. 10-15 minutes**

  Encourage the couples to arrive 10 to 15 minutes before the group begins so that they will have time to visit. Couples arrive, get coffee or tea, etc., and visit with each other.

  This is the couple's special time together, so please no children in Married for Life classes.

- **MEETING BEGINS promptly at the time designated.**

  Do not wait for those who are late to arrive. If a couple should arrive late, they should quietly join the group with as little interruption as possible.

- **Praise and worship. 10-15 minutes (Financial Giving Opportunity can take place here if you wish to make it part of praise and worship.)**

  Be sensitive to your couples' backgrounds and gear your music to what the Holy Spirit shows you is appropriate. This is not a time of deep praise and worship.

- . **Sharing of last week's lesson and Life Application. 30-45 minutes**

  Set the pace with your own transparency. Share what the Lord has been working in your own lives and marriage during the past week. Share your difficulties as well as your victories.

  This is the interactive time in the group. There are suggested questions in the back of your manual.

  Encourage couples to interact as a group. Specifically work to include those who may not be as verbal as others.

- **Financial giving opportunity. 2-5 minutes (Unless you have taken it directly following praise and worship.)**

  Registration fees are kept to a minimum so that couples might have an opportunity to give freely. Ask them to pray about what they should contribute weekly.

  Ask a couple to pray over the contributions. Then PASS the basket from couple to couple. Couples giving cash must use the giving envelopes for IRS record keeping. If they do not fill out the envelope, they will not receive tax credit for their giving.

  $12 may be taken from the first week's giving for stamps for the 24 weekly report mailings if you are not using electronic forms.

- **Short break for refreshments and/or bathroom break. 5-10 minutes**

  Decide how you would like to handle the refreshments for your class. Some Coaching Couples just provide refreshments as their gift of hospitality. Others ask couples to each bring something to share with the group. Encourage couples to get their refreshments, use the bathroom, call the sitter, etc. Call the class back to order at the end of the designated time and begin the teaching.

- **Teaching presented. 45-60 minutes**

- **Wrap-up time. 1-2 minutes (Questions for Clarification, Missed Words, etc.)**

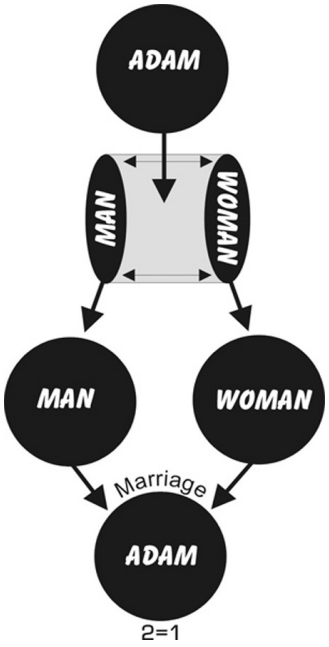
- **MEETING ENDS** Take time after class with those who request it or you feel need some extra help.

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A. What Is Marriage?

1. An understanding of one-flesh is found in **Genesis 1 and 2**.
   a. Adam was made in the **image** of God **[Genesis 1:27]**.
   b. Adam was complete and whole, containing within one person all the attributes we now know as male and female **[Genesis 1:27; Genesis 5:2]**.
   c. God removed a rib ("chamber" in Hebrew, indicating capacity) from Adam and formed woman that Adam named Eve **[Genesis 2:21,22]**.
   d. God referred to the two who became one as "**Adam**" **[Genesis 5:2; Genesis 3:20]**.
2. Adam and Eve were created to be complementary and completing to each other.
   a. Each was created to fulfill and complete the other in the oneness of marriage.
      1) **Genesis 2:18** said Eve was to be an aid or helper suitable to Adam.
         a) King James uses the word meet for suitable.
         b) Hebrew word for helper comes from the root that means to "surround."
      2) Because they had the nature of God, it was their nature to love and to give **[Genesis 1:26]**.

B. Unity and Power



1. Covenant relationship begins as a man and a woman leave all others and are joined (or cleave) to each other in marriage.
   a. *"Therefore shall a **man** leave his father and his mother, and shall cleave unto his **wife**: and they shall be one flesh"* **[Genesis 2:24 KJV]**.
   b. (Cleaving is an active, purposeful positioning and it means "to adhere, be joined together, to catch by pursuit.")
2. Two becoming one creates a relationship with **synergism**.
   a. Synergism means the whole is greater than the sum of the parts **[Genesis 23-25]**.
   b. They are stronger together than either of them was individually.
3. Adam and Eve each had unique qualities and attributes that enhanced their oneness.
4. They combined the same qualities as Adam had alone, but by God's design their combined power and ability were greater **[Leviticus 26:8]**.
   a. When the two become one in covenant, their unity and power are greater than just two people side by side.
   b. Alone: God had Adam just cultivate and keep the Garden **[Genesis 2:15]**.
   c. Together: Adam and Eve, were *"...to fill the earth, subdue it, and rule over...every living thing"* **[Genesis 1:28 NIV]**.

C. Unity of Body, Soul, and Spirit

1. Oneness of one-flesh **[Genesis 2:23-25]**.
   a. We are a 3-part being **[1 Thessalonians 5:23]**.

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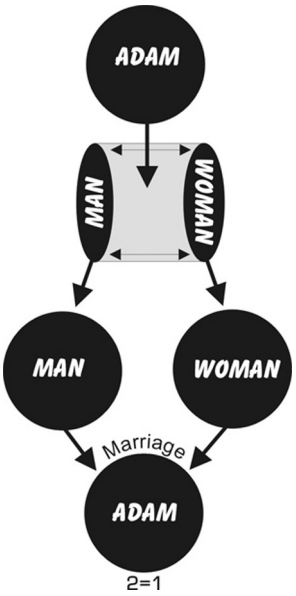
What Is Marriage?

In order for us to understand the meaning of one-flesh in our own marriages, we need to understand the original plan for marriage that God established in the Garden of Eden. The picture of marriage as God originally intended it is found in Genesis, chapters 1 and 2. God created Adam in His own **image** and likeness **[Genesis 1:27]**. Adam was complete and whole, containing within one person all the attributes we now know as male and female **[Genesis 1:27, Genesis 5:2]**.

Then God placed Adam in a deep sleep and removed from him a rib, or "chamber" in Hebrew. This term indicates a capacity or container **[Genesis 2:21,22]**. From this capacity God fashioned a woman and presented the two to each other. Although they now were TWO people, together they became the ONE that God continued to call **Adam [Genesis 5:2]**. It was Adam who named his wife Eve **[Genesis 3:20]**.

Adam and his wife were created to be complementary and completing to each other in the oneness of marriage. **Genesis 2:18** says that the woman was created to be a helper suitable to her husband. (King James uses the word meet for suitable, thus Eve was a help meet for Adam.) The Hebrew word meaning "an aid or help" is derived from a root word meaning "to surround." Adam and Eve strengthened each other and were stronger together than either of them was individually, much the same as metals combine to form a stronger alloy.

They had the very nature of God so it was natural for them to be loving and giving toward each other, preferring, honoring and serving one another **[Genesis 1:26]**. The result of two people giving actively to each other, preferring each other totally is the wholeness and unity of one-flesh.



Unity and Power

Covenant relationship begins as a man and a woman leave all others and are joined (or cleave) to each other in marriage. *"Therefore shall a **man** leave his father and his mother, and shall cleave unto his **wife**: and they shall be one flesh"* **[Genesis 2:24 KJV]**. They are stronger together than either of them was individually. Cleaving is an active, purposeful positioning and it means to "adhere, be joined (together), to catch by pursuit." Two becoming one creates a relationship with **synergism** (the whole is greater than the sum of its parts) **[Genesis 23-25]**.

Adam and Eve had unique qualities and attributes which enhanced their oneness. Together they combined the same qualities that Adam previously contained within himself alone, but by God's design their combined power and ability were greater **[Leviticus 26:8]**. When the two become one in covenant, their unity and power are greater than just two people side by side.

When Adam was alone, God assigned him the job of cultivating and tending the Garden **[Genesis 2:15]**. When Adam and Eve were together, though, God did not just assign them two gardens to tend and cultivate. Instead He gave them the job of filling the earth, to subdue it, and rule over it **[Genesis 1:28]**.

PERSONAL EXAMPLES

b. Adam and Eve had total oneness of their three-part beings: Spirit, Soul, and Body.

c. Body.

1) Physical one-flesh oneness is easiest for us to understand.

a) *"And they shall be one flesh"* **[Genesis 2:24 NKJV]**.

b) *"Be fruitful and multiply"* **[Genesis 1:28 NKJV]**.

d. Oneness of Soul (intellect, emotions, will).

1) This is hardest to achieve.

2) They *"...were not ashamed"* **[Genesis 2:25]**. (Hebrew word for "ashamed" is translated in other parts of Old Testament as "**confused**".)

3) For there to have been no confusion between them, they must have had total agreement in the soul realm.

e. Spirit.

1) Both Adam and Eve were created in the image of God and therefore had the oneness of His Spirit.

2) *"Did He not create a single being that has flesh and breath of life (spirit) ...Be careful of your own life, therefore, and do not break faith with the wife of your youth"* **[Malachi 2:15 Jerusalem Bible]**.

3) *"Has not the Lord made them one? In flesh and spirit they are His"* **[Malachi 2:15 NIV]**.

4) As members of the Body of Christ, are automatically one in Spirit.

f. At the time of marriage, a one-flesh relationship comes into being.

1) It must be nurtured and nourished to mature.

2) We need to honor and esteem the needs of our covenant partner above our own.

3) **Philippians 2:3-4 NKJV**, *"Let each of you look out not only for his own interests…"* As we place the needs of our spouse above our own, we nurture our one-flesh relationship and are blessed.

g. **Genesis 2:25** contains revelation concerning God's plan and potential for our one-flesh lives as husband and wife.

1) They were married, man and wife. (**Genesis 2:24** is the covenant verse--leaving in order to cleave.)

2) *"Both"* indicates they were **equal** before God. (also **Galatians 3:28**)

3) No shame or darkness [sin] between them. Imagine being totally naked, in all ways—physically, emotionally, and spiritually, with your spouse with no shame—no confusion!

4) *"Transparent"* in spirit, soul and body; free to be themselves, openly and honestly.

5) This is God's plan for your marriage also.

D. Sin Changed Everything [Genesis 3]

1. Satan recognized the oneness and power in their relationship.

a. He devised plan to use a quality placed within them by God to pit them against God and each other **[vs. 6]**.

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Unity of Body, Soul, and Spirit

The oneness of a one-flesh relationship is reflected in **Genesis 2:23-25**. Mankind is created by God as a three-part being—spirit, soul, and body **[1 Thessalonians 5:23]**. Because there was no sin yet in their lives, Adam and Eve had total oneness in all three parts of their being. Perhaps the physical oneness of their bodies, or flesh, is the easiest for us to understand. *"And they shall be one flesh"* **[Genesis 2:24 NKJV]**. and *"Be fruitful and multiply"* **[Genesis 1:28 NKJV]**. The oneness of their souls is also made apparent in scripture. **Genesis 2:25** says, *"...they were not ashamed."* The word translated *"ashamed"* in this verse is translated *"**confused**"* in other places in the Old Testament. For there to be no confusion between Adam and Eve they must have understood each other completely, not just speaking the same language. How many of you know that you can speak the same language and still be confused when you talk to each other?

They also must have had oneness of purpose and direction because their wills were completely in line with the will of God and, therefore, were in agreement with each other. Some of this may not be apparent to you right away. Please read and meditate on these scriptures and allow the Holy Spirit to reveal to you the depth of that first one-flesh relationship.

Lastly, Adam and Eve had oneness of their spirits. **Malachi 2:15** in the Jerusalem Bible says, *"Did He not create a single being that has flesh and breath of life (spirit)...Be careful of your own life, therefore, and do not break faith with the wife of your youth."* This same verse in the NIV says, *"Has not the Lord made them one? In flesh and spirit they are His. And why one?"* We know that Adam and Eve were created in the image and likeness of God. They were in total spiritual oneness with Him and, therefore, with each other. As members of the Body of Christ, we are automatically one in the Spirit.

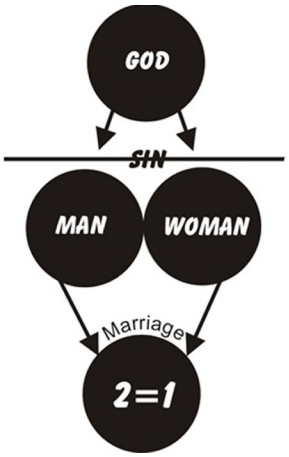
When we marry, our one-flesh relationship comes into being. It is as an infant when it is first created, though, and we must nurture and nourish our unity in order for it to grow and mature. Covenant living means death to self and, in order for a one-flesh relationship to grow, we must honor and esteem the needs of our covenant partner above our own. **Philippians 2:3,4 (NKJV)** says *"Let nothing be done through selfish ambition or conceit, but in lowliness of mind let each esteem others better than himself. Let each of you look out not only for his own interests, but also for the interests of others"* When we place the needs of our spouse above our own, we help to nourish the one-flesh relationship God has given us. In turn, we ourselves are blessed.

Genesis 2:25 gives further revelation concerning that first one-flesh relationship. First of all, scripture indicates that Adam and Eve were married, *"the man and his wife"*. (We have already discussed that **Genesis 2:24** is the covenant verse that established their marriage.) **Genesis 2:25** then states that they were both naked and were not ashamed. The word *"both"* is intriguing. It indicates an equality between man and woman in the eyes of God. Although God has assigned different roles and responsibilities to men and to women, He holds them both **equal** in importance before Him **[Galatians 3:28]**. There is no preferred gender in the eyes of God. He loves women and men equally. Both are created in His image and reflect aspects of His nature. Adam and Eve were naked before each other, physically, emotionally and spiritually and they had no shame or confusion between them. There was no sin or darkness in their relationship. They were transparent in spirit, soul, and body and free to be themselves openly and honestly. Can you imagine your one-flesh relationship in that way? That is God's plan for you, too!

PERSONAL EXAMPLES

b. Convinced Eve to fulfill herself **[vs. 6]**.

c. Adam followed and fulfilled his flesh despite what God had told him **[Genesis 2:17]**.



2. They no longer had the nature of God and each began to fulfill **self** at the expense of the other.

a. They covered themselves from each other **[Genesis 3:7]**.

1) *"Self"* is mentioned the first time in scripture after the fall.

2) Were no longer transparent.

3) This pattern continues today as couples protect themselves and hide from each other.

b. They hid from God **[Genesis 3:8]**.

1) Feared God and no longer saw Him as part of their marriage.

2) Couples today fail to recognize that God must be the center and foundation of their marriage.

c. They became confused as to whom their **enemy** was **[Genesis 3:12]**.

1) They failed to recognize Satan as their enemy and instead he blamed her and she blamed the serpent.

2) Couples today are also tricked by the enemy into thinking that their spouse is the problem.

d. They justified their sin and perpetuated the problem **[Genesis 3:12]**.

1) Failed to admit their fault in the sin.

2) Couples today also justify sin instead of calling it sin and repenting.

Interactive **(Take three minutes and then resume the lesson)**

Discuss one way you have been affected by each of these consequences of the fall.

1. **Not being totally open with each other**
2. **Meeting your own needs first**
3. **Turning away from God**
4. **Blaming each other instead of recognizing your common enemy**

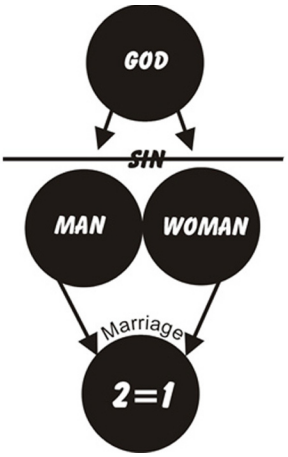
3. Marriage deteriorated more as time passed.

a. Of spirit, soul, and body, only physical unity was left **[Genesis 4:1]**.

b. Polygamy, multiple concubines, division, and divorce increased throughout the Old Testament.

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Sin Changed Everything [Genesis 3]



The original plan of God for marriage was interrupted, though, by the fall of man. Satan recognized the power and oneness of the relationship of man and woman to each other and to God and devised a plan to pit them against God and each other. He convinced Eve to go against the nature of God within her and fulfill herself **[Genesis 3:6]**. Adam followed her and fulfilled himself also, listening to Eve without regard for what God had told him **[Genesis 2:17]**.

Because of their sin, Adam and Eve covered themselves from each other **[Genesis 3:7]**. It is interesting to note that the word *"self"* is used for the first time in scripture after Adam and Eve had sinned. Before that, self was unimportant in the Garden. Adam and Eve's sin broke their covenant relationship with God. They no longer had His nature and now their hearts were turned inward. Fulfillment of **self** became more important than ministering to each other. They were no longer transparent. Couples today continue to hide and protect their true selves from each other.

Adam and Eve hid from God **[Genesis 3:8]**. Couples today still fail to recognize that God must be the very foundation and center of their relationship with each other. Adam and Eve became confused as to who their **enemy** was. Adam blamed Eve for his sin and the subsequent consequences, and she blamed the serpent **[Genesis 3:12]**. Couples today are still tricked by the enemy, Satan, into thinking that the problem is their spouse. Adam and Eve justified their sin and perpetuated the problem **[Genesis 3:12]** and couples today are also failing to admit their own fault, calling it sin, and repenting.

Interactive **(Take three minutes and then resume the lesson)**

Discuss one way you have been affected by each of these consequences of the fall.

1. **Not being totally open with each other**
2. **Meeting your own needs first**
3. **Turning Away from God**
4. **Blaming each other instead of recognizing your common enemy**

After the fall only physical unity was left in a marriage **[Genesis 4:1]**. Throughout the Old Testament marriage deteriorated greatly from the original plan of God. As time passed the Bible records polygamy, multiple concubines, division and divorce.

PERSONAL EXAMPLES

E. Redemption in Jesus.

1. Jesus came to redeem mankind back to original relationship with God that Adam had lost **[Romans 5:18; 2 Corinthians 5:15]**.
2. Jesus also redeemed for marriage what had been lost at the fall. **[Galatians 3:13a** says Christ redeemed us from the **curse** of the law. Curses about marriage and family are listed in **Deuteronomy 28:30-32]**.
3. He renewed the original standards for marriage **[Matthew 19:3-9; Mark 10:2-12; Luke 16:18]**.
   a. Those who have entered into the New Covenant through Jesus have been redeemed from the curse of division and destruction in their marriages.
   b. Divorce is one of those curses.
4. Pharisees tried to trap Jesus regarding the Mosaic Law **[Matthew 19:7]**.
   a. Jesus did not clarify Mosaic Law.
   b. He used God's original plan for His point of reference.
   c. Divorce was permitted when hearts were hard.
      1) Hard hearts are a pre-redemption condition.
      2) Jesus came to change **hardened** hearts **[Jeremiah 32:39; Ezekiel 11:19,20]**.
      3) The original plan of God did not include separation or divorce; *"...but from the beginning it was not so"* **[Matthew 19:8 KJV]**.
   d. Jesus gave no excuse for divorce when He was talking privately to His disciples in **Mark 10:10-12** and said that remarriage is adultery.
   e. Divorce is not an option for Christians.
   f. *"...except for sexual immorality..."* **[Matthew 19:9]** referred to the Jewish betrothal period and was clarification of Jewish law regarding sexual sin before marriage.)
   g. **1 Corinthians 7:11** gives us clear direction (remain single or be reconciled).
   h. Our marriage covenant is the representation of Christ's covenant relationship to the Church **[Ephesians 5:32]**.
      1) We are to be faithful until **death** ends our relationship.
      2) Our marriage reflects to all around us how Christ relates to those in covenant with Him.
      3) That is why scripture says that remarriage while our spouse is still alive is adultery **[Romans 7:2,3; Luke 16:18; Mark 10:11,12]**.

F. No Condemnation [Romans 8:1-2]

1. If you have experienced divorce and remarriage as a Christian:
   a. Regardless of how you came to these decisions, you need to search the Scriptures regarding God's standard for covenant.
   b. This teaching is not meant to put you under condemnation!
   c. When we discover that we have gone against God's will in any area of our life, we need to repent, receive forgiveness, and go on with God **[1 John 1:9]**.
   d. It is better to recognize sin and repent than to defend our actions.
2. Repenting.
   a. It is the act of remarriage, not the ongoing sexual union, that is adultery.
   b. When remarriage is adultery, the marriage is established on a sinful foundation; Jesus cannot enter into a sinful union.

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Redemption in Jesus

When Jesus, the Messiah, came it was His mission to redeem mankind back to the original relationship with God that Adam and Eve had lost **[Romans 5:18; 2 Corinthians 5:15]**. **Galatians 3:13a** says that Christ redeemed us from the **curse** of the law. The curses for marriages and families are listed in **Deuteronomy 28:30-32**.

Included in that redemption was the reestablishing of marriage to the standards set forth in the Garden of Eden **[Matthew 19:3-9; Mark 10:2-12; Luke 16:18]**. Those who have entered into the New Covenant through Jesus have been redeemed from the curse of division and destruction in their marriages. Divorce is one of those curses.

The Pharisees, who refused to recognize who Jesus was and the reason He had come, tried to trap Jesus regarding points of Mosaic Law. In **Matthew 19** and **Mark 10** the Pharisees questioned Him regarding marriage and divorce. Jesus did not fall into their trap, though. Instead He used God's original plan for marriage as His point of reference. Jesus declared that divorce was the result of a **hardened** heart. Jesus had come to change hardened hearts and bring salvation **[Jeremiah 32:39; Ezekiel 11:19,20]**. He reminded the people that God's original plan for marriage did not include separation or divorce, *"...but from the beginning it was not so"* **[Matthew 19:8 KJV]**.

In fact, when Jesus was speaking privately about this matter to His disciples in **Mark 10:10-12**, He gave no excuse for divorce for those who follow Him. Scripture makes it very clear, Divorce is not an option for Christians. **Matthew 19:9**, *"...except for sexual immorality..."* is not an excuse for Christians. It refers to the Jewish betrothal period and was a clarification of Jewish law regarding sexual sin before marriage. A Christian's options if he/she does separate (or divorce) are clearly stated in **1 Corinthians 7:11**, *"But if she does (separate), she must remain unmarried or else be reconciled to her husband. And a husband must not divorce his wife."*

Because our marriage covenant is the representation of Christ's covenant relationship to the Church **[Ephesians 5:32]** we are to be faithful until **death** ends our relationship. Our marriage reflects to all around us how Christ relates to those in covenant with Him. That is why scripture says that remarriage while our spouse is still alive is adultery **[Romans 7:2,3; Luke 16:18; Mark 10:11,12]**.

No Condemnation

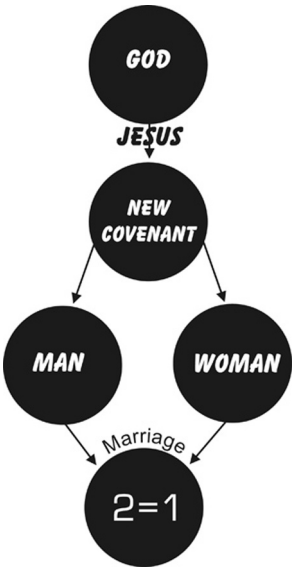
Perhaps you have experienced divorce and remarriage as a Christian. You may have even been counseled to do so. Regardless of how you came to these decisions, you need to search the Scriptures regarding God's standard for covenant. This teaching is by no means meant to put you under condemnation **[Romans 8:1-2]**. When we discover that we have gone against God's will in any area of our lives, the clear path to follow is to repent, receive forgiveness, and go on with God **[1 John 1:9]**. It is better to recognize sin and repent than to defend our actions and justify our mistakes.

It is the act of remarriage that is adulterous, not the ongoing sexual union. Couples sometimes ask, "If we repent of the act of adultery, how can we continue to have sex and not sin again?" Repentance is for the act of marrying, not the ongoing sexual union. When the act of marrying is adultery, the marriage is established on a sinful foundation. Jesus cannot enter into a sinful union. Repenting of the basis of that

c. Repentance of the sinful basis of the marriage establishes it on Jesus as the foundation and opens the door for Him to be a vital part of the marriage.
d. Please search the scriptures to determine their true meaning. Confusion arises when people's opinions are valued equally with the scriptures.
e. The purpose of this teaching is to bring **freedom** and to end the harassment and condemnation that sin brings.

3. Once you have repented and received God's forgiveness, do not allow the enemy to harass and condemn you anymore.
4. As your testimony lines up with the Word of God, you can help others avoid the pain and turmoil you have experienced.
5. Proceed from this point today and let the past go.

G. Real Marriage



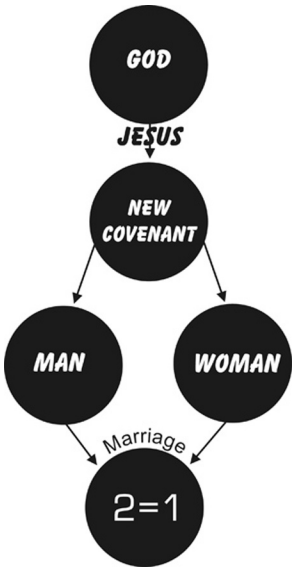
1. Only in Jesus can we receive all God has for marriage because He is the only one who has purchased back that which was lost through Adam and Eve.
2. Without Jesus, marriage can only be a counterfeit of what God intends.
3. We are born with selfish, inward-turned natures.
   a. This is why we must be born **again** (a second time) **[John 3:3]**.
   b. When we enter into covenant with Jesus, God's nature becomes our nature.
      1) Without Jesus, we can only try to better ourselves with techniques, methods and systems.
      2) None of them can change our hearts.
4. Our marriage doesn't have to be plagued by those things which are destroying marriages all around us.
   a. God has provided powerful tools for those in covenant with Him so we can build our marriage on His blueprint.
   b. In addition He has given us His **power** to bring about changes in our lives and relationship.
5. Not a case of only hoping things will improve, but of actually knowing that the power of God is *accomplishing* those things He has promised.
6. When we have God's vision for marriage and know how to appropriate the tools He has given us, we have discovered His power!

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sin, though, establishes the foundation of the marriage in Jesus and opens the door for Him to be a vital part of that marriage. If this is not clear to you, please search the scriptures and see for yourself what they really say. There is great confusion in the Church today because many opinions regarding divorce and remarriage are being heard. The clear trumpet sound has been muffled. It is critical that we come to understand what scripture says regarding this subject.

The purpose of this teaching is to bring **freedom** and to end the constant harassment and condemnation that sin brings into our lives.

Once sin is confessed and you have received forgiveness, do not allow the enemy to harass you anymore regarding this issue. From this time forth, your testimony will line up with the Word of God. It will not be a stumbling block to others but will be a clear trumpet sound regarding God's heart for marriage. You will be able to help others avoid the pain and turmoil you have known by sharing with them the healing victory of Jesus. Proceed today from this point of knowledge and let the past go.



Real Marriage

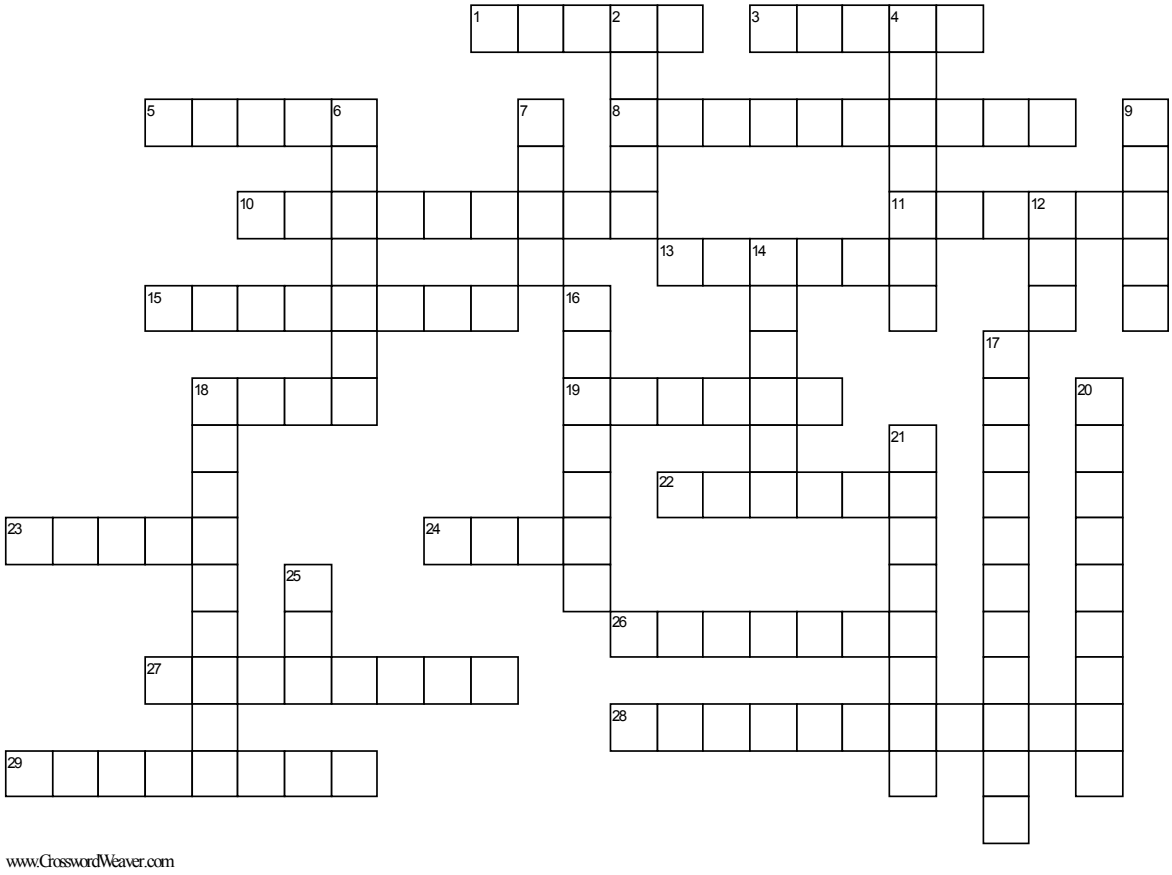
Only in Jesus can we receive all that God has planned for marriage because Jesus is the only one who has purchased back for us that which Adam and Eve lost. A marriage apart from Jesus Christ can, at best, be a counterfeit of what God intends. There can be no complete unity of the three-part being apart from Jesus' redemption.

We are born with selfish, inward-turned natures. It is our desire from birth to fulfill ourselves. This is why Jesus said we must *"...be born **again**"* **[John 3:3]**. In our second birth, our spirit is born anew.

When we enter into covenant with Jesus, God's nature becomes our nature. This cannot happen any other way. Without Jesus, we can only try to better ourselves with techniques, methods and systems. None of them can change our hearts.

Our marriage doesn't have to be plagued by those things which are destroying marriages all around us. God has provided powerful tools for those in covenant with Him so we can build our marriage on His blueprint. In addition He has given us His **power** to bring about changes in our lives and relationship.

It is not a case of only hoping things will improve, but of actually knowing that the power of God is *accomplishing* those things He has promised. When we have God's vision for marriage and know how to appropriate the tools He has given us, we have discovered His power!



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ACROSS

1 Ends the marriage covenant
3 Our home should be an oasis of _____
5 Purchased back what Adam lost
8 What takes away guilt and condemnation
10 Adam's job alone
11 Matthew 19:9 applies _____ marriage
13 Be reconciled or remain _____
15 Be fruitful and _____
18 _____ were naked and not ashamed
19 The first couple's job together
22 What you do after you leave
23 Our real enemy
24 Sin brought fulfillment of _____
26 Not an option for Christians
27 The type of heart Jesus came to change
28 Purchased by Jesus' blood
29 The basis for marriage

DOWN

2 We are a _____ part being
4 What God removed from Adam
6 Do nothing out of _____ ambition
7 God called the first man and woman
9 Sometimes couples are confused as to who this is
12 What two become in marriage
14 Adam and his wife had the _____ of God
16 Make excuse for sin
17 No darkness between them
18 Only way to change our nature
20 The whole is greater than the sum of the parts
21 Jesus _____ us from the curse of the law
25 Created marriage

Solution Page 218

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Life Application - Let's make it real

(Don't forget to cover this material together and to space it out over the entire week.)

Since the original one-flesh couple, Adam and Eve, is to be our model for our one-flesh relationship, let's become as familiar with them and their life as possible. We need to know God's original plan for our one-flesh and how our marriage today compares with that plan.

1. Read **Genesis 2:9-10**. Can you picture the Garden of Eden? Describe it in your own words.

2. **Genesis 2:8** gives us a picture of God and man alone in the garden. Adam and Eve were in the center of God's perfect will and were constantly aware of His presence. This is God's will for our homes, too. Can you list some things in your life right now that might keep this from being true in your home?

3. Adam was assigned work in the Garden **[Genesis 2:15]**. What was he to do?

According to **Genesis 1:29**, of what did the first couple's diet consist?

Read **Isaiah 1:19 and 2 Thessalonians 3:10.** How did Adam's work relate to the livelihood of his household?

In your home, how does the amount of time spent in work outside the home affect the level of peace within the home? How much work is necessary for provision? How can too much or too little work affect the home?

4. In **Genesis 2:18,** God verbalized that Adam needed human companionship and fulfillment so He made him a help "meet" or "suitable, adapted, completing" for him. **1 Peter 3:1,** also in the Amplfied, instructs wives to adapt themselves to their husbands. What does adapt mean to you?

Men need to be admired **[Ephesians 5:33 Amplified],** encouraged, and respected. If this is not your heart attitude toward your husband, give God permission right now to begin changing it.

5. In **Genesis 2:22,** God presented Eve to Adam and Adam was excited! **Verse 23** records his reaction. God then stated that the attraction to each other would be strong enough for man to leave even the closest relationship that he would know on earth before marriage, his father and mother. Adam recognized and appreciated the wonder and beauty of Eve and knew her importance in his life. **1 Peter 3:7** instructs husbands to live with their wives according to knowledge, honoring them. What does that mean to you?

Women need to be appreciated and loved **[Ephesians 5:25]**. If this is not your heart toward your wife today, give God permission right now to begin changing it.

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6. **Genesis 2:25** tells us that both Adam and Eve were naked and that they were not ashamed. As was discussed in the lesson, the word "both" here indicates equality before God. There is no superior or inferior gender in God's eyes, only different role assignments. Adam and Eve were not ashamed before each other or God. They were able to be totally open with each other and God. There was no area of their life that God was not a part of. Is this characteristic of your marriage today?

If not, would you like it to be? Give God permission to begin making those changes today.

7. **Genesis 1:28** shows us God's instructions to Adam and Eve for their home and surrounding area. Adam and Eve were told to subdue and rule over the rest of the earth. It is clear that they were not to passively let the rest of the world encroach upon them, but they were to actively affect it. The world today is constantly trying to influence and dominate our homes. Can you name just a few areas of your home life where you have seen this to be true?

How can you effectively "subdue and dominate" in those areas?

8. Adam and Eve had total unity and harmony of spirit, soul, and body. Their relationship with each other and with God was perfection, truly made in heaven. Satan recognized the power of that unity and desired to create strife and separation from God. He influenced man and woman to fulfill self instead of their one-flesh relationship. First one spouse disobeyed, then the other one followed. The disobedience of one spouse never justifies the disobedience of the other. Satan only succeeds in separating us more and more when we take that attitude. What are some areas where you have said, "Well, if he/she is going to do that, then I'm going to do this"?

Begin increasing your awareness of the enemy's subtle attacks. His one goal is to create disunity and cause you to function as two instead of one. At first, what he presents is usually appealing and seemingly very good. As the Lord increases your knowledge regarding the power and unity of your one-flesh relationship, you are going to be fine-tuning your "early warning" systems so that you will be able to pick up on the enemy's attempts long before he succeeds in separating you through strife.

9. When God established marriage, it was His plan that only death could break the covenant relationship. If you have been divorced and are now remarried, perhaps this lesson gave you new insight into God's covenant plan. If you have not already done so, it is important that you repent of both the divorce and the remarriage, since neither was God's plan for your life. Repentance breaks the cycle of condemnation that justification of sin produces. It sets you free to receive the fullness of God's blessing for your present marriage, establishing in your heart that marriage covenant is for life.

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When scripture says that remarriage while the first spouse is alive is adultery, it is the act of remarriage that is adulterous, not the ongoing sexual union. Couples sometimes ask, "If we repent of adultery, how can we continue to have sex and not sin again?" Repentance is for the act of marrying, not the ongoing sexual union. When the act of marrying is adultery, the marriage is established on a sinful foundation. God cannot bless sin.

Repenting of the basis of that sin, though, establishes the foundation of the marriage in Jesus and opens the door for Him to be a vital part of that marriage. If this is not clear to you, please search the scriptures and see for yourself what they really say. There is great confusion in the Church today because many opinions regarding divorce and remarriage are being heard. The clear trumpet sound has been muffled. It is critical that we come to understand what scripture says regarding this subject.

Once sin is confessed and you have received forgiveness, do not allow the enemy to harass you anymore regarding this issue. From this time forth, your story will be one of God's love and grace in your life. It will not be a stumbling block to others but will give a clear picture of God's plan for marriage. You will be able to help others avoid the pain and turmoil you have known by sharing with them the healing victory of Jesus. If this is your desire now, please pray this prayer.

Spouse who was previously married

"Father, I recognize that divorce is not Your solution to marital problems and that I was not in Your will when I divorced. I repent of the sin of divorce and receive Your full forgiveness and pardon. Never again will I allow the enemy to condemn me for my sin.

I recognize that remarriage was also against Your Word and Your will for me, and I repent of committing adultery when I remarried. I receive Your full forgiveness and will never again allow the enemy to speak to me of this matter."

Spouses Together

Because remarriage is adultery according to the Word of God, as spouses you need to repent to each other and receive each other's forgiveness for beginning your marriage on those grounds.

"I ask you (name of spouse) to forgive me also for causing you to commit adultery by marrying me."

After you have forgiven each other, pray this prayer together.

"Father, we thank you for Your forgiveness and that Your mercies are new every morning. Today we establish our marriage covenant upon the Lordship of Jesus Christ. We establish our relationship on a new, firm foundation in Him and promise to be faithful to each other until death separates us. We refuse old patterns and old excuses and from this day forth our testimony will be faithful to Your Word."

Date_____ Signed _____

Date_____ Signed _____

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Week 3

The Power of Synergism

WEEKLY PRAYER FOCUS

When the Coaching Team Meets to Pray

WEEK 3 - THE POWER OF SYNERGISM

GOAL: For each spouse to understand HIS or HER specific call of God, based on the biblical role model of Christ and His church.

INSTRUCTION: This is not a lesson on headship and submission! Please do not teach it that way! Each husband and each wife is to look at his or her own role and seek to excel in it. It is not a time to critique the spouse's performance. When both husband and wife are seeking to excel in their own role, the fullness of one flesh will be manifest.

PRAYER FOCUS: This is the week that strife is most likely to appear in your couples. Fight spiritual warfare on their behalf. Ask God for wisdom and discernment regarding specific spirits that are in operation. Follow directions given by the Holy Spirit. Pray for the couples to flow together in sowing into the ministry financially.

Coaching Team:

Personal Prayer Needs _____

_____

_____

_____

_____

Ministry Prayer Needs _____

_____

_____

_____

_____

_____

Notes from Prayer Time:

Praise Reports:

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WEEKLY COACHING TIPS

Teaching the Lesson

Live the lesson the week before you teach it. Spend time together as a couple in prayer as you prepare to teach. Each lesson is presented in both outline and narrative form. The flowing text is meant to give you an idea of how to present the outline. Please ***do not read*** the flowing text when you teach the lesson! Follow the order of the outline for the sake of those taking notes.

Make the lessons come alive to the group. Teach as a one-flesh team - both husband and wife together. In a powerhouse home, ***both*** spouses are to be strong in the Spirit. Allow Him to break traditional, man-made molds and follow Him freely. Remember to illustrate the principles with ***personal examples*** from your own lives. Lessons should **never** be taught by only one spouse or by one spouse from each coaching couple.

Make sure the bolded underlined words are used in the teaching. These are the words couples will be looking for to complete their notes.

The teaching time is not an interactive time. If couples have questions have them write them down and hold them for the wrap-up time at the end of the meeting.

The couple in training should teach at least twice during the course. Pray about which lessons those should be. We recommend that Coaching Couple teach Lessons 1 and 2 because they are foundational to the rest of the course. If the couple in training have not been through a group before and have never heard the lesson, the Coaching Couple must go over the lesson with them before they teach it.

1-2 minutes Wrap-up time at the end of the teaching. (QUESTIONS FOR CLARIFICATION)

This is a time to clarify—a missed word or a scripture reference that was not understood. This is not the time for doctrinal discussions or disagreements. Request that couples who are having a problem do their life application first and see if some of their questions are answered.

A. We Are Created to Complement Each Other

1. Creation.
   a. **Genesis 1:26**.
      1) God created Adam in His image.
      2) Adam was whole and complete.
   b. **Genesis 2:22**.
      1) Eve was taken from Adam, not formed separately.
      2) Each one retained qualities that the other needed.
   c. Man and woman were created to be **complementary**, not competing.
2. After the fall, it was no longer possible to discern God's plan for marriage by observing earthly couples.
   a. In **Ephesians 5:22-33**, God gave the example for marriage based on the relationship of Christ, the Bridegroom, and the Church, His Bride.
   b. Roles of husband and wife can be understood by observing Jesus' and the Church's interaction.

B. Jesus/husband and Church/wife roles:

1. This is not intended to compare the redemptive role of Jesus.
2. Some roles are the same for both husband and wife.
3. This lesson is designed to help you understand your role.
   a. Concentrate on God's plan for YOU.
   b. Trust that God will take care of changing your spouse.
4. Responsibility.
   a. God has placed within each person certain **abilities**.
   b. Responding to those abilities is called "responsibility."
   c. Attempting to respond in areas that are not our assignment is taking on the responsibility of the other spouse.
   d. If you have done that, repent and trust God to change your spouse.

C. Leaving and cleaving [Genesis 2:24]

1. It is Based on Covenant Relationship.
   a. This does not mean severing relationships with parents.
      1) Jesus left His Father to establish covenant with Church.
      2) He maintained relationship with His Father.
   b. It means establishing a primary relationship with your spouse.
2. Jesus to Church.
   a. Jesus covenanted with her.
      1) Loved, cared for, nurtured, and gave His life for her.
      2) Gave up all that being God meant to establish relationship with her **[Philippians 2:6,7]**.
   b. As commitment is with Jesus and the Church, so it is with husband and wife.
3. Church to Jesus—Gives up all to follow Jesus **[Luke 14:33]**.
4. Husband and wife.
   a. Marital relationship must be priority over all other earthly relationships.
   b. Don't sacrifice your primary relationship for a **secondary** one.

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We Are Created to Complement Each Other

When God created Adam, He made him complete and whole in His image **[Genesis 1:26]**. By taking Eve from part of Adam and not just forming her separately **[Genesis 2:22]**, He enabled each one to retain qualities that the other needed. God created man and woman to be **complementary** to each other and intended that male and female qualities would complement, not compete.

After sin entered into the world, it was no longer possible to discern God's plan for marriage by observing the actions of couples. So God gave us a heavenly example to follow. **Ephesians 5:22-33** tells us that the relationship of Christ, the Bridegroom, and the Church, His bride, are to be our example as husband and wife. We learn our roles as husband and wife by observing the interaction of Jesus and the Church.

In case you husbands are thinking, "How can I possibly do what Jesus did?" Our focus is not on the redemptive role of Jesus. We are looking at how He loves and interacts with the Church.

Focus on Your Roles

This lesson is designed to help you better understand your own role as a husband or wife. Concentrate on God's plan for you, not on the roles given to your spouse.

God has given each one of us certain **abilities**. When we respond to those abilities, that is "responsibility." We cannot respond to abilities God has not given us. Those are not our area of responsibility.

If we attempt to respond in areas that are our spouse's assignment, not ours, then we are taking on our spouse's responsibility. If you discover as we study this lesson that you have taken on responsibilities that are not yours, repent and let God help your spouse to fulfill his or her roles.

Jesus has entered into covenant with His Church. As husband and wife, we enter into marriage the same way. The Bible tells us to "leave and cleave" **[Genesis 2:24]**. Jesus left His Father to be joined with us. Leaving obviously does not mean severing relationship because Jesus certainly maintained His relationship with His Father. Jesus' primary earthly concentration, however, was His Church. He covenanted with her, loved her, cared for her, nurtured her, and eventually gave His life for her.

Philippians 2:6,7 tells us that Jesus gave up all that it meant to be God to come and establish relationship with His Church. The Church, in turn, is instructed in **Luke 14:33** to give up all to follow Jesus. As husband and wife our relationship should be a priority over all other earthly relationships. Never sacrifice your primary relationship (with your spouse) for a **secondary** relationship (children, mother, father, friend, boss, etc.).

PERSONAL EXAMPLES

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D. Jesus and the Church

1. Jesus to Church.
   a. Reassures her of His love and loyalty **[Matthew 28:20b]**.
   b. Provides her all the Kingdom of God offers **[Luke12:32]**.
   c. Forgives her **[Luke 23:34]**.
   d. Heals her **[Mark 1:29-34]**.
   e. Serves her **[John 13:1-7; Mark 10:45]**.
   f. Leads her **[Luke 9:23]**.
   g. Gives Godly purpose to lives **[Luke 5:8-10]**.
   h. Intercedes for her **[Hebrews 7:25]**.
   i. Comforts her **[Philippians 2:1-2]**.
   j. Exhorts and encourages her **[Romans 15:5 NIV]**.
   k. Gives her strength **[Ephesians 3:16]**.
   l. Example of God's heart **[John 14:9]**.
   m. Teaches her **[Luke 4:31,32; Matthew 7:28,29]**.
   n. Respects authority **[Luke 20:22-25]**.
   o. Opposes sin **[Luke 19:45]**.
   p. Discerns spirits **[Matthew 16:23]**.
   q. Has authority over spiritual darkness **[Luke 4:36]**.
2. Church to Jesus, or to Others by His Example and Direction.
   a. Loves Him **[Matthew 22:37]**.
   b. Honors Him **[1 Timothy 1:17]**.
   c. Esteems, respects, and reverences Him **[Revelation 4:11]**.
   d. Caretaker of what He has provided **[Hebrews 12:28]**.
   e. Heals in His Name **[Mark 16:18]**.
   f. Forgives as Has Been Forgiven **[Matthew 6:14; 2 Corinthians 5:18]**.
   g. Exhorts by His Example **[Hebrews 3:13]**.
   h. Comforts as Has Been Comforted **[2 Corinthians 1:4]**.
   i. Does His will as the Spirit leads **[Romans 8:14]**.
   j. Serves **[John 13:13-16]**.
   k. Respects God-given authority **[Romans 13:1-2]**.
   l. Intercedes **[1 Thessalonians 5:17; Ephesians 6:18]**.
   m. Takes authority over spiritual darkness by the Power of His name **[1 John 4:1; Mark 16:17]**.
   n. Ministers **[Matthew 28:18-20]**.
   o. Nurtures **[1 Corinthians 12:25]**.



Interactive

Before we begin looking at specific roles,

Husband: pick one thing your wife does that blesses you and tell her how much you appreciate it.

Wife: pick one thing your husband does that blesses you and tell him how much you appreciate it.

(Take three minutes and do this now)

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Jesus and the Church

Husbands, here are some examples of Jesus' relationship to His Church. We are only going to read the roles right now. We suggest you read the scriptures later and begin to discover the depth of your role as a husband.

Jesus constantly reassures the Church of His love for her and His faithfulness to her **[Matthew 28:20b]**. He provides for her all that the Kingdom of God has to offer **[Luke12:32]**. He forgives her **[Luke 23:34]**, He heals her **[Mark 1:29-34]**, He serves her **[John 13:3-7; Mark 10:45]**, and He leads her **[Luke 9:23]**. Jesus gives godly purpose to the lives of His followers **[Luke 5:8-10]**. He intercedes on our behalf **[Hebrews 7:25]**. He comforts **[Philippians 2:1-2]**, exhorts and encourages **[Romans 15:5 NIV]**, and gives strength to His Church **[Ephesians 3:16]**. He is an example of God's heart **[John 14:9]**, a teacher **[Luke 4:31,32; Matthew 7:28,29]**, a respecter of authority **[Luke 20:22-25]** and an opposer of sin **[Luke 19:45]**. He is a discerner of spirits **[Matthew 16:23]** and has authority over spiritual darkness **[Luke 4:36]**.

Wives, here are some examples of the Church's relationship to Jesus. We are only going to read the roles right now. We suggest you read the scriptures later and begin to discover the depth of your role as a wife.

The Church loves **[Matthew 22:37]** and honors **[1 Timothy 1:17]** Jesus. She esteems, respects and reverences Him **[Revelation 4:11]**. She is the caretaker of all that Jesus has provided **[Hebrews 12:28]**. She follows Jesus in His example as healer **[Mark 16:18]**, forgiver **[Matthew 6:14; 2 Corinthians 5:18]**, exhorter **[Hebrews 3:13]**, and comforter **[2 Corinthians 1:4]**. She is Spirit-led **[Romans 8:14]**. She has learned to serve as Jesus does **[John 13:13-16]** and to respect God-given authority **[Romans 13:1-2]**. She intercedes **[1 Thessalonians 5:17; Ephesians 6:18]** and takes authority over spiritual darkness in His name **[1 John 4:1; Mark 16:17]**. She ministers **[Matthew 28:18-20]** and nurtures **[1 Corinthians 12:25]** as an extension of His love for her.



Interactive

Before we begin looking at specific roles,

Husband: pick one thing your wife does that blesses you and tell her how much you appreciate it.

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(Take three minutes and do this now)

PERSONAL EXAMPLES

E. Roles of Husband and Wife.

1. **HUSBAND** – Reassuring Covering **[Ephesians 5:25; 1 Peter 3:7]**.
   a. Be sensitive to your wife's needs; spirit, soul, and body.
   b. Comfort her as Holy Spirit directs, not as you feel.
   c. Minister to her from the Word.
   d. Respond with empathy, not sympathy.
   e. Do not abdicate your **protection** of her or cause her to feel abandoned.

2. **WIFE** - Helper **[Genesis 2:18; Proverbs 31:10-12]**.
   a. Comes from Hebrew word "to surround."
   b. This is not a secondary but a vital role.
   c. Surround your husband with:
      1) Support.
      2) Exhortation.
      3) Comfort.
   d. Make available to him all the godly **qualities** within you to help him develop into the man he is called to be.

3. **HUSBAND** - Leader **[1 Corinthians 11:3]**.
   a. Final leadership responsibility lies with husband.
   b. Exercise in love the authority given to you.
      1) Will bring **strength** and stability to family.
      2) Be an example of standing firm despite circumstances.
   c. Resist the enemy, not your family.
   d. Receive godly counsel and wisdom from your wife.

4. **WIFE** - Supporter **[Ephesians 5:22-24; 1 Peter 3:1,2]**.
   a. Husbands need to be respected and honored.
      1) Even if they are not acting like it.
      2) Honor the authority of God and He will change the man.
   b. God has given men the desire to conquer.
   c. When a wife is supportive, her husband is more willing to take the initiative.
   d. **Criticism** can hinder him from going forth boldly.
   e. Respect the authority God has placed in him.
      1) Work together in decision-making.
      2) Don't side with children against him.

5. **HUSBAND** - Provider **[1 Timothy 5:8; Deuteronomy 6:6-9]**.
   a. Provide your family with not only physical needs but also all that kingdom living includes.
   b. Be the primary source of Gospel **teaching** for your family.
   c. Be instrumental in bringing each family member into salvation and the fullness of the Spirit.
   d. Give godly purpose to lives.

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We are going to now pass out a card for each of you with some of your roles as husband and wife. Only your roles are on your card, so follow along as we cover each one of them.

HUSBAND: REASSURING, COVERING [Ephesians 5:25; 1 Peter 3:7]

Loving your wife as Jesus loves the Church means being sensitive to her needs - spirit, soul, and body. Comfort your wife when the Spirit tells you she needs comforting, not when you think she needs comforting. Minister to her from the Word. Jesus responded to His Church with empathy, not sympathy. It is important for wives to know that they are "covered" by their husbands. Do not abdicate your **protection** over her or cause her to feel abandoned and alone.

WIFE: HELPER [Genesis 2:18; Proverbs 31:10-12]

As was shared in Lesson 2, the word "helper" comes from the Hebrew word "to surround." The role of helper is not a secondary one but a vital role of surrounding a husband with support, exhortation, and comfort, when needed. Being a helper means making available to your husband all the godly **qualities** God put in you to enable him to lead as he has been directed and to help him develop into the godly man he is called to be.

HUSBAND: LEADER [1 Corinthians 11:3]

The burden of final leadership responsibility for the outcome of his family lies with the husband. A man who exercises, in love, the authority given him by God will bring **strength** and stability to his wife and family. Led of the Spirit and directed by the Father, you are to be an example of standing firm despite the circumstances. You are to resist the enemy, not your family, and to treat what the Lord speaks to your wife with the same respect that you treat what you personally receive from Him.

WIFE: SUPPORTER [Ephesians 5:22-24; 1 Peter 3:1,2]

Husbands need to be respected and honored. This is not dependent upon his performance. As you honor his authority, God will change him. God has given men the desire to go forth and conquer. This translates in every day life into mastering new skills, taking on greater responsibility in work, and striving to be the very best at what he does. A man that knows his wife stands behind him is more willing to step out and try new ventures. **Criticism** of your husband can hinder him from going forth boldly as God directs. In your home, respect the authority God has placed in him, working together in decision-making, not undermining him or siding with the children against him.

HUSBAND: PROVIDER [1 Timothy 5:8; Deuteronomy 6:6-9]

God intends for husbands to provide not only for the physical needs of their wife and family but also for their spiritual. This means that along with supplying food, shelter, clothing, etc., you are to make clear to your family all that kingdom living includes. You should be the primary source of Gospel **teaching** for your family. You are to be instrumental in bringing each family member into salvation and the fullness of the Spirit. Just as Jesus did, you are to give godly purpose to the lives of your wife

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6. **WIFE** - Administrator **[Proverbs 31:13-27]**.
   a. Skillful and godly administration will increase and multiply that which your husband provides.
   b. As the Spirit leads, wisely invest that which is saved to produce even more.
   c. To know God's plan, must spend time daily in Word and prayer with Him.
   d. **Prosperity** comes from seeking the face of the Lord and knowing Him.

7. **HUSBAND** - Example of God's Heart **[Mark 10:44; Matthew 6:14,15; Mark 6:17,18]**.
   a. God's heart is always for reconciliation and restoration.
   b. This includes forgiving, serving, and healing.
      1) Be quick and constant in **forgiveness**.
         a) Does not depend on repentance of others.
         b) Jesus forgave before He was asked.
      2) Serve your wife and family with a humble spirit and a joyful heart.
      3) Step out boldly to be an instrument of God's healing to your family.

8. **WIFE** - Reflection of God's Love **[1 John 4:19-21; John 13:35]**.
   a. Caring for your husband and family should be a joy and reflect heart of a servant.
   b. Forgive quickly, not keeping a **record** of wrongs.
   c. Draw strength from the Word.
      1) Gives you the ability to weather circumstances.
      2) Helps you minister healing and wholeness.
   d. Words carry the power of life or death **[Proverbs 18:21]**.
      1) Use words to nurture.
      2) Never destroy with them.

9. **HUSBAND** - Lover, Champion **[Ephesians 5:25-28; 1 Corinthians 7:3-5; Ruth 3:9]**.
   a. Wives need to be loved and cherished.
   b. They are sensitive to **motives**.
   c. You must reassure your wife of your love for her.
   d. Reinforce your faithfulness with actions.
   e. Honor her with your appearance.
   f. Be a gentle, faithful lover ministering to her needs.

10. **WIFE** - Lover, Companion **[1 Corinthians 7:3-5; Song of Solomon 2:16; 1 Peter 3:4-6]**.
   a. Your first ministry is to your husband.
      1) Do not neglect him.
      2) Make sure you have God's desire for other ministry.
   b. Remain well-kept and pleasing in appearance as an honor to him.
   c. Submit your flesh and emotions to the **control** of the Holy Spirit.
   d. Honor and respect him; compliment him.
   e. Be the physical lover he needs.

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and family. In giving counsel and direction, always keep in mind the spiritual purpose in the situation.

WIFE: ADMINISTRATOR [Proverbs 31:13-27]

Skillful and godly administration will enable a wife to increase and multiply that which her husband has provided. The Spirit will lead you to wisely invest that which is saved so that it may produce even more. To know God's plan for your home and family, you must spend time daily in His presence and in His Word. As you seek the Lord, He will instruct you regarding the **prosperity** of your home.

HUSBAND: EXAMPLE OF GOD'S HEART [Mark 10:44; Matt.6:14,15; Mark 16:17,18]

As husband you are to demonstrate the heart of God to your family. God's heart is always for reconciliation and restoration. This includes forgiving, serving, and healing. You are to be quick and constant in your **forgiveness**. This does not depend on your wife's or your children's state of repentance. Jesus forgave before He was asked. You are to serve your wife and family just as Jesus served the Church, with a humble spirit and a joyful heart. You are to be an instrument of God's healing just as Jesus was. Do not be timid. Step out boldly in these areas to minister to your family.

WIFE: REFLECTION OF GOD'S LOVE [1 John 4:19-21; John 13:35]

Wives have opportunities daily to minister the love of God within their homes as well as outside. Caring for your husband and family should be a joy and reflect the contented heart of a servant. Forgiveness should be quick, not keeping a **record** of wrongs suffered. Strength drawn from the Word of God will enable you to weather circumstances and minister healing and wholeness wherever there is need. Remember, your words carry the power of life or death [Proverbs 18:21]. Always use words to nurture and love, never to destroy.

HUSBAND: LOVER, CHAMPION [Eph. 5:25-28; 1 Corinthians 7:3-5; Ruth 3:9]

Wives need to be loved and cherished. They are extremely sensitive to the **motives** behind an action. They look not only to what their husband says but also to what he does. You need, therefore, to continually reassure your wife of your love for her and reinforce your faithfulness to your relationship through your actions, as well as your words. Saying you love her will mean little if your actions do not say the same. Honor her with your appearance. Be a gentle, steadfast lover to her, allowing your physical love to minister to her needs.

WIFE: LOVER, COMPANION [1 Corinthians 7:3-5; Song of Solomon 2:16; 1 Pet. 3:4-6]

A wife's first ministry must be to her husband. Make sure you have God's plan for you and that you are not neglecting to minister first to your husband and to your family as you get involved in other ministry. It is an honor to your husband that you remain well-kept and pleasing in your appearance. Submit your flesh and your emotions to the **control** of the Holy Spirit. Take an interest in what your husband enjoys doing. Let him know that you honor and respect him. Compliment him. Treat him as you did when you were dating, admiring and appreciating who he is and what he does. Ask God to teach you to be the physical lover that your husband desires.

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11. **HUSBAND** - Example of God's Sovereignty **[Hebrews 3:13; 2 Corinthians 10:5,6]**.
    a. Take firm, uncompromising stand against **sin**.
        1) Hate the sin.
        2) Love the sinner.
    b. Keep family on track with Lord; point out areas needing correction.
    c. Mix exhortation with love and encouragement.
    d. Always edify with words even when challenging to excellence.
    e. Respect God-given authority for your authority to be respected.

12. **WIFE** - Reflection of God's Creativity **[1 Corinthians 12:7; Titus 2:3-5]**.
    a. Each woman has unique talents and gifts.
    b. Don't **compare** yourself with others but allow God to develop what is uniquely you.
    c. You reflect a specific aspect of God's personality and ministry flowing from you will reflect that to others.
    d. Your gifts and talents should complement those of your husband and, like-wise, his gifts should complement yours.
    e. Couple should flow in harmony even if you are ministering or working separately.

13. **HUSBAND** - Intercessor, Warrior **[James 4:7; James 5:16]**.
    a. You are chief intercessor for your wife and family.
    b. You are responsible for spiritual warfare on behalf of your wife and family.
    c. Take authority over the spirits of darkness that come against your family.
    d. Be Spirit-led in **discernment** of enemy activity and fleshly motives in your family.

14. **WIFE** - Intercessor, Discerner **[Ephesians 6:18; 1 Thessalonians 5:17]**.
    a. Your intercession for your husband and family brings you assurance of God's hand in their lives.
    b. Exercise authority over the enemy in the name of Jesus.
    c. You are your husband's chief **intercessor**.
    d. Do not fear the work of the enemy; be alert to his attacks.
    e. Ask the Holy Spirit to develop discernment within you and to clothe you with wisdom.

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HUSBAND: EXAMPLE OF GOD'S SOVEREIGNTY

[Hebrews 3:13; 2 Corinthians10:5,6]

Husbands, like Jesus, must take a firm, uncompromising stand against **sin** even when it might be easier to look the other way; as disciplinarians—hating the sin but loving the sinner. You must keep your family on track in their relationship with the Lord, pointing out to them areas of deficiency that need to be corrected. Exhortation, however, must always be mixed with love and encouragement. Never crush with your words. Always edify and lift up, even when challenging to excellence. Remember, you must honor and respect God-given authority if you expect your own authority to be respected.

WIFE: REFLECTION OF GOD'S CREATIVITY [1 Cor.12:7; Titus 2:3-5]

God has placed within each woman unique talents and gifts. Do not **compare** yourself to others, but allow God to develop within you what is uniquely you. Know who you are in Christ and be confident in His love for you. You reflect a specific aspect of God's personality, and ministry flowing from you will reveal to others that aspect of God. Your gifts and talents complement and complete those of your husband, as his complement yours. As a couple you should flow in harmony even if you are working or ministering separately.

HUSBAND: INTERCESSOR, WARRIOR [James 4:7; James 5:16]

Just as Jesus constantly intercedes for the Church, you must be the chief intercessor for your wife and family. You are responsible for spiritual warfare on behalf of your family and you need to let them know you are praying for them. You must take authority over the spirits of darkness that are coming against your family. God has given you the ability to be Spirit- led in your **discernment** of enemy activity. He will also enable you to discern fleshly motives in family members and others that affect the family. Call on God for wisdom in dealing in these areas and use the authority God has given you over the enemy.

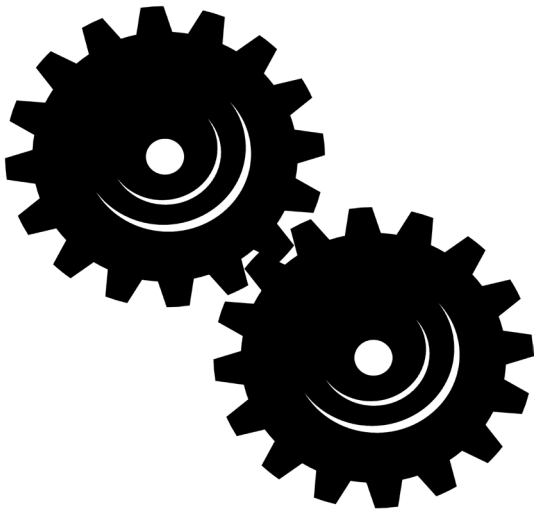
WIFE: INTERCESSOR, DISCERNER [Ephesians 6:18; 1 Thess.5:17]

The intercession of a godly wife for her husband, her children, and her grandchildren brings her assurance of God's hand in their lives. She has no fear of adversity for she exercises authority over the enemy in the name of Jesus. You are to be your husband's chief **intercessor**. Be open to direction from the Holy Spirit during the day to alert you to his prayer needs. You need not fear the work of the enemy in the lives of your family when you are alert to his attacks. Ask the Holy Spirit to develop His discernment within you and to clothe you with the wisdom of God.

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FOLLOW UP:

1. Men **read** your favorite Gospel in light of what Jesus was to the Church and did for the Church. Compare this to your relationship with your wife.
2. Women **read** your favorite Gospel in light of how the Church responded to Jesus. Compare this to your relationship with your husband.
3. Both husband and wife - keep in mind that this lesson discusses **YOUR responsibility to God,** not your spouse's responsibility to you. Do not criticize your spouse. Remain in faith regarding what the Word says about him or her. Agree with God and His Word, not with what Satan says.
4. This is not a lesson about headship and submission. It is a lesson about **dual responsibility** in marriage. Perhaps, though, it has changed the way you previously viewed the roles of husband and wife.
5. If you are far from fulfilling your role, **trust** in the Lord to bring you into the fullness of it. Don't receive condemnation. Remember, God is not finished with any of us yet.



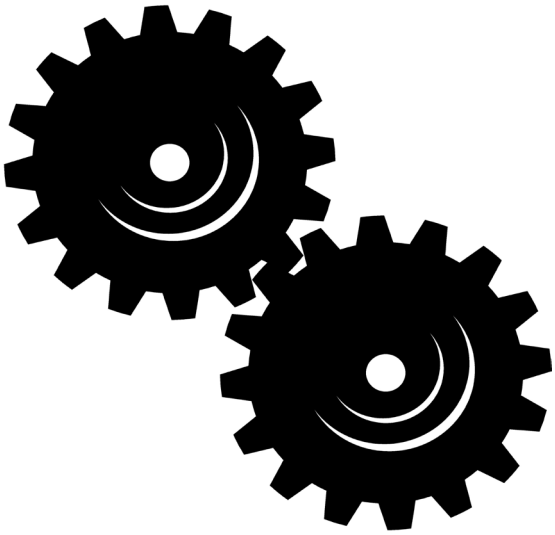
*A gear is a component within a transmission device that transmits rotational force to another gear or device. A gear... is a round wheel which has linkages ("teeth" or "cogs") that mesh with other gear teeth, allowing force to be fully transferred without slippage. Depending on their construction and arrangement, geared devices can transmit forces at different speeds, torques, or in a different direction, from **the power source**.* (Wikipedia 2007)

A husband and wife flowing together are like gears. They mesh and interact to transmit the power of God into their marriage and then outward to others.

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FOLLOW UP:

1. Men **read** your favorite Gospel in light of what Jesus was to the Church and did for the Church. Compare this to your relationship with your wife.
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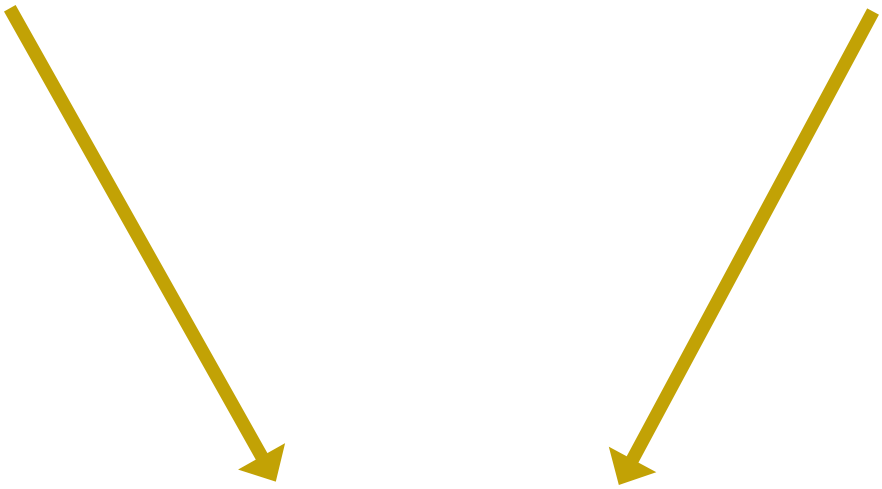


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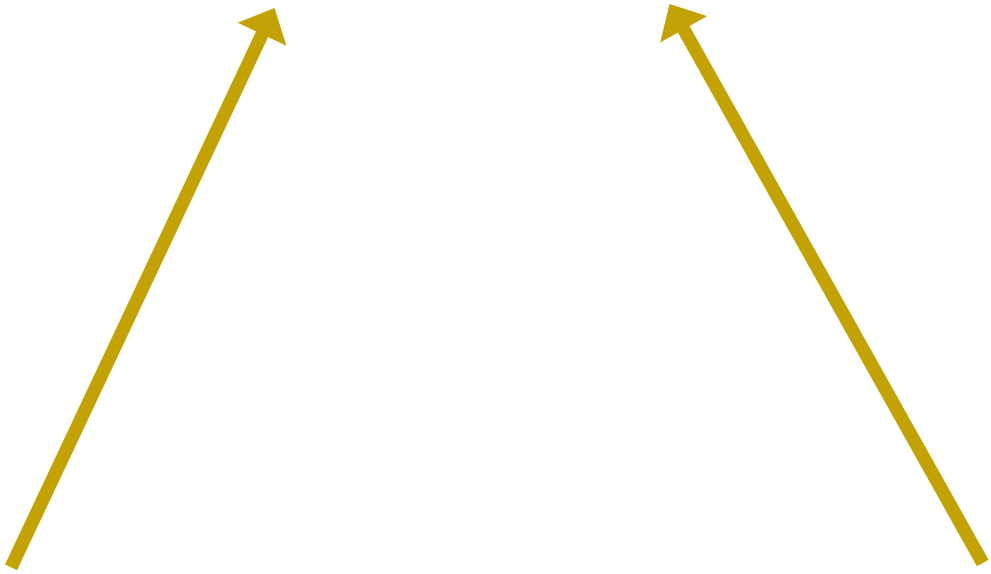
A husband and wife flowing together are like gears. They mesh and interact to transmit the power of God into their marriage and then outward to others.

PERSONAL EXAMPLES

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Inside the back cover you will find
His and Her removable Roles Cards
that you can put in your Bible or
some other convenient place.



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Life Application - Let's make it real

This lesson is designed to clarify the dual responsibility of husband and wife in marriage. It does not concentrate on headship and submission. It may, however, have changed the way you have perceived headship and submission in the past.

1. In light of this teaching, what is your understanding of headship?

Is this different than what you believed it to be before?

If so, how?

What scripture(s) best depict(s) for you how Jesus functioned in headship?

2. In light of this teaching, what is your understanding of submission?

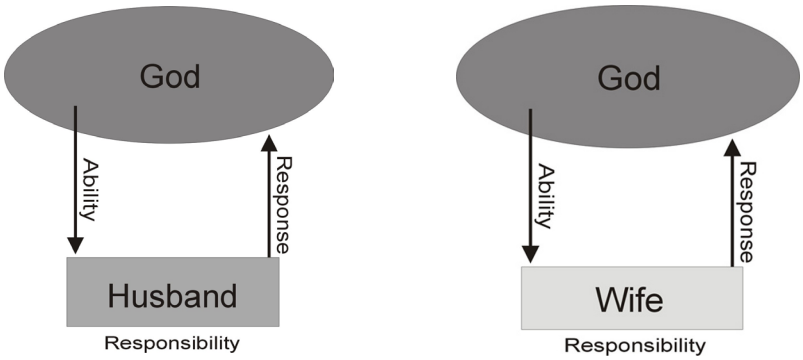
Is this different than what you believed it to be before?

If so, how?

What scripture(s) best depict(s) for you how the church functions in submission to Jesus?

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3. Responsibility is simply responding to God for the ability He has given you. You cannot respond for an ability He has not given.



Maybe as you became more aware of your roles this week, you felt inadequate or like a failure in some of these areas. That is the beauty of God's system. It is His ability that He has given you. You do not have to rely on your own strength or expertise.

Maybe your role models in life have not given you a good picture of how you are to flow in your roles. That's okay as well. Since God gave you the ability, He will help you fulfill it as you respond to Him in obedience. He will give you the correct role model from His Word.

Likewise, if you take on the responsibility of someone else, you will not have grace to fulfill it. You cannot fulfill someone else's roles. Sometimes when we feel our spouse is not doing such a good job, we tend to step in and take over. God's plan works differently. He wants you to pray for your spouse, not usurp the role.

In the following sections, write several words under each role that come to mind when you hear the word.

Example:

Leader

Husband	Wife
strong, wise, discipler, risk taker	security, out front, aloof

Helper

Husband	Wife
chores, subservient, maid	counselor, wisdom, direction

After each section, take a few minutes to discuss how you each viewed the word. Then look back in the lesson and see what scripture says about it. Sometimes our perceptions of a role can cloud how we flow in it or encourage our spouse to flow.

PROVIDER

Husband Wife

LOVER, COMPANION

Husband Wife

LEADER

Husband Wife

HELPER

Husband Wife

ADMINISTRATOR

Husband Wife

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4. Which role discussed this week is the biggest challenge for you as an individual?

Husband:

Wife:

Which combination of roles do you find most challenging as a couple? (example: provider-administrator)

Talk about these together. Does knowing that your abilities are from the Lord and that your job is to respond to Him take any pressure off you?

How can you encourage each other in these areas?

5. What roles do you feel most comfortable with?

Husband:

Wife:

Why do you think you have done well in these areas?

6. Are there areas where you have tried to fulfill each other's roles?

If you are comfortable talking about these areas, take time now and share together. Do not accuse (I had to do it because you are so irresponsible!) Just talk about how it makes you feel when important roles are not being fulfilled in your home. Ask each other how you can work together as a powerful team to see God's roles brought into your home.

Remember, when you feel that your spouse is not flowing as God would have him or her, take that it the Lord in prayer. Do not attempt to rush in to fill the gap. If the Lord has not called you to that responsibility, you will not be supplied with the power required to carry it out. Too many families are out of order because each spouse is attempting to fulfill the other's position and not praying for their spouse in those areas of lack. Remember, pray it on them; don't lay it on them.

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Week 4

The Power of Sowing and Reaping

WEEKLY PRAYER FOCUS

When the Coaching Team Meets to Pray

WEEK 4 - THE POWER OF SOWING AND REAPING

GOAL: To become aware of the constant process of sowing and reaping in marriage. To learn how to select good seed and what to do with poor crops.

INSTRUCTION: Encourage your couples to keep in mind all the good things they have sown. There is a real tendency with this lesson to become discouraged and only look at poor crops. Caution them against falling into this trap.

PRAYER FOCUS: Intercede against discouragement and strife. Seek the Holy Spirit specifically regarding your couples. Pray for tender hearts ready to receive the next teaching on forgiveness. Pray for couples to understand the principle of financial sowing and reaping as they sow financially this week.

Coaching Team:

Personal Prayer Needs _____

_____

_____

_____

_____

Ministry Prayer Needs _____

_____

_____

_____

_____

Notes from Prayer Time:

Praise Reports:

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WEEKLY COACHING TIPS

Ministry After the Class

Those couples needing extra help should be encouraged to remain after the meeting to receive ministry. Do not take time during the meeting for that purpose.

Ministry to couples should always be one-flesh, couple to couple. Let the Holy Spirit lead you as to how and when to minister. He knows what each couple needs and will direct this ministry time. Don't feel pressured that you have to figure it out.

Normally just the two leadership couples will be ministering. Other couples should leave and let the Lord continue working in their own marriages. Be open, though, to the direction of the Holy Spirit regarding other couples ministering with you.

Remember, our goal is to help the couple learn to hear from the Lord themselves. We want to help guide them and get them through areas when they are "stuck" but we don't want to become the voice of God for them. Always encourage couples to seek the Lord for themselves as well as receiving help from you. It is their marriage and they need to invest in it themselves.

Attendance

After they begin a group, couples are expected to attend weekly. If one spouse cannot make the meeting, then the other one should attend and share the lesson with the one that missed. If neither spouse can make the lesson, **it is up to the Coaching Couples whether or not they will make up that lesson with them.**

Some couples prefer one-on-one meetings and will take advantage of your willingness to meet personally with them. Other couples will really need to make up an important lesson they missed. You make the call. Ask the Lord what you should do if a couple misses a week.

Meetings are never to be recorded. Only one lesson is to be taught at a time. Do not combine lessons.

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A It's the Law

1. "Be not deceived: God cannot be mocked. A man reaps what he sows. The one who sows to please his sinful nature, from that nature will reap destruction; the one who sows to please the Spirit, from the Spirit will reap eternal life. Let us not become weary in doing good, for at the proper time we will reap a harvest if we do not give up" **[Galatians 6:7-9 NIV]**.
   a. Like a natural law, it is destined by God to fulfill the purpose for which it was created.
   b. **Ignorance** does not stop it from operating.
      1) If someone is ignorant of the law of gravity and jumps from a window, they will still hit the ground.
      2) This would truly be a case of perishing for the lack of knowledge **[Hosea 4:6]**.
   c. We are guaranteed a **harvest [Galatians 6:7-9]**.
   d. We will reap a harvest resulting from what we have sown.
2. Seed Sowing.
   a. Seed selection is either from God or from Satan.
      1) *"This day I call heaven and earth as witnesses against you that I have set before you life and death, blessings and curses. Now choose life, so that you and your children may live"* **[Deuteronomy 30:19,20 NIV]**.
      2) Jesus (Life) always sows life/enemy who sows death. **[John 10:10]**.
   b. No seed is neutral.
   c. We are always sowing; consequently, we are always reaping.
   d. When we are born again, we are directed to choose only life-giving seeds **[Romans 8:5,6]**.
   e. Old habits cause us to choose seed from the wrong bag.
3. Types of Seed We Sow.
   a. Words.
      1) "Our children are so rebellious," or "All our children are taught of the Lord and great is the peace of our children."
      2) "I just can't do anything right," or "I can do all things through Christ Who strengthens me."
      3) "We've never had anything and we're never going to have anything," or "You still the hunger of those you cherish; their sons have plenty, and they store up wealth for their children."
   b. Attitudes.
      1) Humility vs. pride; gratitude vs. bitterness; selfishness vs. agape love.
      2) Joy vs. sorrow; eagerness vs. reluctance; acceptance vs. judgment.
   c. Actions.
      1) Acceptance vs. rejection; freely giving with a willing heart vs. demanding others to reach out first.
      2) Kindness vs. violence; unconditional love vs. keeping track of wrongs; praise vs. criticism.
4. How We Sow.
   a. We are always sowing into lives—our own, our spouse's, our children's, others.
   b. The heart is the soil **[Jeremiah 4:3,4]**.
   c. Types of soil (hearts) **[Matthew 13:18-23]**.
      1) Rocky or thorny soil (hard heart) makes it difficult to produce a crop.
      2) Soil should be well watered by the Word of God.
         a) Crops grow better.
         b) Weeding is easier.
   d. Soil needs to be prepared to receive the seed **[Jeremiah 4:3]**.
      1) In ourselves this is done by prayer and the Word.
      2) For others, we help prepare their hearts through intercessory prayer and spiritual warfare.

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It's the Law

"Be not deceived: God cannot be mocked. A man reaps what he sows. The one who sows to please his sinful nature, from that nature will reap destruction; the one who sows to please the Spirit, from the Spirit will reap eternal life. Let us not become weary in doing good, for at the proper time we will reap a harvest if we do not give up" **[Galatians 6:7-9 NIV]**.

Spiritual laws, just like natural laws, are destined by God to fulfill the purpose for which they are created. **Ignorance** of the law does not stop it from operating. If someone jumps from a fifth-story window and does not know about the law of gravity, their lack of knowledge will not keep them from falling. This truly would be a case of someone perishing for lack of knowledge **[Hosea 4:6]**.

Every day in the same way we walk in the effects of spiritual laws. We may be ignorant of their operation, but nevertheless, these laws operate and determine the outcome. One of the most basic of these laws is sowing and reaping. This law, as described in **Galatians 6:7-9**, indicates that we are going to reap a **harvest**—it is inevitable, a sure thing. It further explains that this harvest is going to be a direct result of what we have planted. It matters not that we know we are planting or that we don't know we are planting. Either way - the crop comes to harvest.

Where do we get the seeds we sow? **Deuteronomy 30:19-20** tells us, *"This day I call heaven and earth as witnesses against you that I have set before you life and death, blessings and curses. Now choose life, so that you and your children may live."* There are two sacks from which seed may be selected—the life sack and the death sack. Everything sown comes from one of these two sources. **[John 10:10]** There are no neutral seeds. Jesus, Who is life, always sows from the life sack. Satan, our enemy, always sows from the death sack. When we are born again we are directed to begin choosing only life-giving seed, **[Romans 8:5,6]** but unfortunately old habits very often die slowly and we are caught digging into the old death bag more often than we care to admit. In this lesson we will examine the types of things we have sown into our marriage and family and we will begin exploring how to select life-giving seed.

Seeds that are sown may be words, attitudes or actions. **(TEACHING NOTE: SEE EXAMPLES IN THE OUTLINE. ADD YOUR OWN.)** Remember, sowing is a constant process. It is important to be using the right seed. Become aware of what you are planting.

The seeds that we select are sown into lives—our own, that of our spouse, our children, and others. The heart is the soil in which the seed will take root and grow **[Jeremiah 4:3,4]**. According to **Matthew 13:18-23**, there are different types of soil in which to plant. Rocky or thorny soil makes it difficult to produce a healthy crop. We need to make sure the soil in which we are planting is well watered by the Word of God thus making it vigorous, healthy soil that produces a strong, abundant crop. Soil well watered by the Word not only helps crops to grow better but also makes weeding easier. **Jeremiah 4:3** tells us to break up our fallow (uncultivated) ground. This applies to the heart in preparing it to receive the seed of God. If we are preparing our own heart, we break up the uncultivated ground with much prayer and time spent in the Word of God. If we are interceding for the heart of another person to be prepared, however, we do this through prayer and fighting spiritual warfare for them.

PERSONAL EXAMPLES

Interactive **(Take 3 minutes and then resume the lesson)**

Recognizing that the seeds you plant are words, attitudes, and actions, take a few minutes and focus on *one* good seed you have *each* planted in any of these areas.

B. Factors of the Harvest.

1. Time Factor.
   a. Harvesting occurs in a different season than the sowing.
   b. After preparing the soil and planting the seed, water the seed with the Word.
   c. Fertilize the crop with your actions **[James 2:26]**.
   d. Don't dig up your seed to see how it is doing.
   e. Don't harvest an **immature** crop **[Mark 4:26-29]**.
      1) Crop will first appear as blade, not mature plant.
      2) Don't lose hope when it does not appear as what you have sown.
      3) Give it time to mature.
2. Multiplication Factor.
   a. We always reap in kind what sown. *"For whatever a man sows that, and that only is what he will reap"* **[Galatians 6:7 Amplified]**.
   b. We always reap more than sown **[Hosea 8:7; Matthew 13:8]**.
   c. Each new multiplication of crop provides seed for future sowing.
   d. How downward spirals are created in marriage.
      1) They begin as a single seed that Satan gives us to plant. (Usually the seed is a thought.)
      2) We accept the seed, plant it, and reap the harvest.
      3) Further seed is then provided for more sowing and a larger crop is the result.
      4) Small areas of irritation can become major areas of **contention**.

C. Recognizing Crops.

1. In ourselves, our spouse, our children, others.
2. Good Crops.
   a. Discover what seeds have been sown to harvest good crops.
   b. Carefully select more seed of the same type to continue good crops.
3. Undesirable Crops.
   a. Repent.
   b. This is like a weed killer and crops begin to die immediately.
      1) Crops may take time to fully die.

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Interactive **(Take 3 minutes and then resume the lesson)**

Recognizing that the seeds you plant are words, attitudes, and actions, take a few minutes and focus on *one* good seed you have *each* planted in any of these areas.

Factors of the Harvest

There are some factors of sowing and reaping that we need to note. First the harvest always comes in a different season than the sowing. We know this even from natural crops. No farmer gathers in a harvest the day after he has planted. After you have prepared the soil and planted your seed, continue watering the soil with the Word of God. Fertilize the crop with your actions **[James 2:26]**. Don't dig up your seed to see if it's working and don't harvest an **immature** crop before its time just because you're in a hurry for results. As your crop begins to appear it will not look like what you have planted **[Mark 4:26-29]**. When a farmer plants corn, the little green shoot that first appears above the ground looks nothing like a kernel of corn. Don't lose hope and tear up your crop. Give it time to mature.

Another factor of sowing and reaping is that you will always reap in kind what you have sown. The last part of **Galatians 6:7** in the Amplified Version says, *"For whatever a man sows, that and that only is what he will reap."* No farmer would plant corn and expect to reap wheat. Likewise, if you sow love you are guaranteed a harvest of love.

Another factor is that you will always produce more than you sow **[Hosea 8:7; Matthew 13:8]**. Therefore, for each seed you sow the crop that springs up will be filled with the same kind of seed. Each corn kernel that will produce hundreds, if not thousands, of kernels of corn. These new seeds when replanted will perpetuate future crops of the same kind, only in greater measure.

As we examine these principles of sowing and reaping, it is easy to see why there are areas in our marriages that have spiraled downward through the years. We have often ignorantly been sowing death, reaping the harvest, resowing the same seed, and reaping greater destruction. No wonder things that were once small areas of irritation have become major areas of **contention**. Satan, the old peddler of death seeds, has been busy bringing death seeds to us and we have been accepting them - but no more! Today we begin selecting our seeds carefully for their life-giving properties. We purpose to diligently cultivate them to abundant crops.

As we become aware of harvests we are reaping, it is important that we first recognize the good crops we have produced. There is sometimes a tendency for couples to focus only on undesirable crops. You have sown good ones too. Discover what seeds you sowed to produce those good crops and carefully select more seed of the same type to continue producing those crops.

PERSONAL EXAMPLES

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2) There may even appear to be a growth spurt.
3) Don't get discouraged.

c. Do not receive condemnation from the enemy.
d. Allow God to restore in areas of undesirable crops as you sow good ones **[Joel 2:25]**.
e. Repent immediately anytime you catch yourself sowing the wrong seeds **[1 John 1:9; Deuteronomy 22:9]**.

D. Sowing Good Crops.

1. Choose seed from God's bag **[Deuteronomy 30:19]**.
   a. Choose the Word to speak and godly characteristics to sow.
   b. Ask God to give you seed for sowing **[2 Corinthians 9:10]**.
2. Prepare the Soil **[Jeremiah 4:3]**.
   a. For yourself—spend time in prayer and the Word.
   b. For others—spend time in intercession and spiritual warfare.
3. You must speak forth the Word to sow it.
   a. Even God speaks His Word to bring it forth.
   b. **Genesis 1:3,6,9,11; Isaiah 55:11**.
4. Fertilize seed with **actions** appropriate to harvest you are believing to receive **[James 2:26]**.
5. Realize that the enemy seeks to plant his seeds in your thoughts.
   a. Guard your thoughts **[2 Corinthians 10:5]**.
   b. Think on those things given by the Lord **[Philippians 4:8]**.

E. Avoiding Strife.

1. *"For where envying and strife is, there is confusion and every evil work"* **[James 3:16 KJV]**.
2. "It is an honor for a man to cease from strife and keep aloof from it" **[Proverbs 20:3a Amplified]**.
3. It takes two to perpetuate strife. If one does not respond, there can be no strife.
   a. One spouse must take an active stand against strife.
   b. This is not a passive ignoring or a defiant silence.
   c. Strife is very much like a merry-go-round. Is easier to stop when it first **begins** spinning than when is going full bore **[Proverbs 15:1]**.
4. Is more important to avoid strife than to appear justified **[Matthew 23:12]**.
   a. Your spouse is not the enemy, Satan is **[Ephesians 6:12]**.
   b. Sow love when the other sows strife **[Romans 12:21; Philippians 2:3; Galatians 5:14,15]**.
   c. When you sow peace and harmony, you are **guaranteed** a harvest of like kind in greater measure **[Galatians 6:7-9]**.
   d. There can be no strife if the second person refuses to yield to it.
5. Only the Power of God Can Change a Pattern of Strife in a Relationship.
   a. Sheer will power and determination are not enough.
   b. An excellent method of yielding to God is a "strife break."
6. Strife Break.
   a. Give each other permission to call a strife break anytime.

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As we recognize areas where we have sown poorly, we must be careful not to come under condemnation. Instead, as we recognize those areas, we need to repent. Repentance is like a weed killer that we spread over those poor crops. They begin to die immediately but it may be a while before they are completely gone. In fact, right after repentance, poor crops sometimes seem to go through a growth spurt. Do not become discouraged. Eventually the undesirable crops will be choked out and replaced by the new crop of good seeds that are coming up. Do not receive condemnation from the enemy. It is God who will restore in those areas where undesirable crops have grown **[Joel 2:25]**. As you repent and sow good seed, it will take a while to see the new harvest. Hang in there! If you catch yourself sowing incorrectly again, be quick to repent **[1 John 1:9; Deuteronomy 22:9]**. That old crop has to die. Begin selecting good seed to sow from God's seed bag. Follow **Deuteronomy 30:19**. Choose the Word and godly characteristics to sow. Ask God to give you seed for the sowing **[2 Corinthians 9:10]**.

Prepare your soil well **[Jeremiah 4:3]**. If it is your heart, spend time in prayer and in the Word. If you are sowing into someone else, spend time in intercession and spiritual warfare. Speak forth the Word to sow it. Even God speaks forth His Word to see things brought to pass **[Genesis 1:3,6,9,11; Isaiah 55:11]**. Begin to fertilize your seed with **actions** appropriate to the harvest you are believing to receive **[James 2:26]**.

Remember that Satan seeks to plant his seeds in your thoughts. Guard your mind and thoughts according to **2 Corinthians 10:5**. Take every thought captive. Think on those things that the Lord commands in **Philippians 4:8**. Do not accept enemy seed.

Avoiding Strife

No teaching regarding sowing and reaping would be complete without discussing strife. What are the consequences of strife in a home? **James 3:16 KJV** says, *"For where envying and strife is, there is confusion and every evil work."* **Proverbs 20:3a** in the Amplified version says, "It is an honor for a man to cease from strife and keep aloof from it." Observing the consequences of strife, we can readily understand why this is true. Obviously no couple should engage in strife nor allow it in their home.

It takes two to perpetuate strife. One person cannot be in strife alone. If one spouse does not respond in strife, there can be no strife. When strife begins to enter the relationship, one spouse must take an active stand against it. This is not a passive ignoring or a defiant silence. Strife builds when two enter in.

It is much like a merry-go-round. One person gives it a spin. At that point it is very easy for the other one to stop it. It does not have much momentum. If, however, the other person also gives it a push, the speed increases. Now it is harder to stop. If, in turn, the other spouse gives it another push, the momentum is really increased and it becomes increasingly more difficult to stop **[Proverbs 15:1]**. The key is to stop strife the minute it **begins**.

It is more important to avoid strife than to appear justified **[Matthew 23:12]**. Remember, your spouse is not the enemy, Satan is **[Ephesians 6:12]**. Sow love, peace, and harmony when your spouse sows strife **[Romans 12:21; Philippians 2:3; Galatians 5:14,15]**. You are **guaranteed** a harvest of like kind in greater measure **[Galatians 6:7-9]**. There can be no strife if the second person refuses to yield.

Do the same with your children. Sow love when they sow strife. Bind the work of the enemy, but love the child steadfastly.

There is very little chance that a pattern of strife in a relationship can be broken by sheer will power. It takes the power of God to change this pattern. One excellent method of avoiding strife is to take a strife break.

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b. Calling a strife break is admitting that **both** of you are in strife. (Do not say, "You're causing strife.")
c. Simply say, "Strife Break."
d. Yield your most unruly member (your tongue) to the Spirit **[James 3:3-10]**.
e. If you are baptized in the Holy Spirit, we recommend you pray together in the Spirit for three minutes - no more, no less.
    1) If longer, you will be reluctant to do it.
    2) If shorter, it will not be effective in breaking the strife.
f. If you are not familiar with praying in the Spirit, we will be learning about it in Lesson 7. If strife is a problem in your relationship and you want to know more about this now, check with your leaders.
g. By praying in the Spirit, you will be sowing to the Spirit and not to the flesh **[Galatians 6:8]**.
h. Your harvest will come from what you have **sown**.
i. In that harvest you will discover the power of God to produce new life.

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Strife Break

Each spouse needs to give the other permission to call a strife break anytime strife appears. Remember, calling a strife break is admitting that **both**, including yourself, are in strife. It takes two to create strife. Do not say, "You are causing strife," or "Obviously you are in strife." Instead, one or the other of you simply says, "Strife break!" Then the two of you yield your most unruly member, your tongue, to the Spirit **[James 3:3-10]**. If you are baptized in the Holy Spirit, we recommend you pray together in the Spirit for three minutes - no more, no less. If you attempt to make it longer, you will become reluctant to do it. If you attempt to make it shorter, it probably will not be effective.

If you are not familiar with praying in the Spirit, we will be learning about the Baptism of the Holy Spirit in Lesson 7. If strife is a problem in your relationship and you want to know more about this before then, please check with us after the meeting.

By praying in the Spirit, you will be sowing to the Spirit and not to the flesh **[Galatians 6:8]**, and ministering unity to your relationship. Your harvest will come from what you have **sown**. And in that harvest you will discover the power of God to produce new life.

PERSONAL EXAMPLES

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Life Application - Let's make it real

Whether we realize it or not, we have been sowing and reaping all our married life. During this life application we are going to examine the crops we have produced, and decide which ones we want to perpetuate and which ones we want to destroy. Once we have dealt with the old crops, we will begin sowing new ones.

1. Begin to look at each aspect of your family as a gardening area. Become aware of what has been sown and what crops have been produced. There is sometimes a tendency to concentrate on what is wrong. Remember to look for good crops, also. In each of the following areas examine what you have reaped and then determine what you have sown to produce that crop. First look at the harvest and then figure out what seed was sown to produce that crop. Record the harvest in each garden and the seeds sown on each seed bag.

EXAMPLE

MYSELF



HARVEST

1. I know scripture well.
2. I am frustrated a lot.
3. I have a lot of friends.
4. I am healthy.



SEEDS

1. I read my Bible daily.
2. I set too many goals.
3. I am interested in others.
4. I eat wisely and exercise.

HUSBAND

WHAT YOU HAVE REAPED



WHAT YOU SOWED



WIFE

WHAT YOU HAVE REAPED



WHAT YOU SOWED



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HUSBAND

WHAT YOU HAVE REAPED IN YOUR WIFE'S LIFE



WHAT YOU SOWED IN YOUR WIFE'S LIFE



WIFE

WHAT YOU HAVE REAPED IN YOUR HUSBAND'S LIFE



WHAT YOU SOWED IN YOUR HUSBAND'S LIFE



TOGETHER

WHAT WE HAVE REAPED IN OUR CHILDREN



WHAT WE SOWED IN OUR CHILDREN



TOGETHER

WHAT WE HAVE REAPED IN OUR HOME



WHAT WE SOWED IN OUR HOME



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2. Now examine the harvests you have reaped. Are there good harvests you want to see continued? Star (*) those seeds which have produced good crops. Continue planting and replanting them.

Are there any weeds? Do you want them to stop growing? If so, repent and spray the weed killer on them. Using a red marking pencil, draw a line through those weeds. The blood of Jesus covers every confessed sin. Those weeds are now dying off. You may continue to see traces of them for a while. Just remember, as long as you don't sow bad seeds, there are not going to be any more weeds. If you do catch yourself sowing any undesirable seeds, repent immediately and they will not come to harvest.

3. Now to plant new crops. First, you must cultivate the soil. If you are sowing into yourself, spend time in prayer and in the Word. If you are sowing into someone else, spend time in intercession and spiritual warfare. Keep the soil well-watered with the Word of God. Here are the directions for planting.

2 Corinthians 9:10 tells us, *"Now He who supplies seed to the sower and bread for food will also increase your store of seed and will enlarge the harvest of your righteousness."* Go to the Lord and ask Him for seed. Obtain your new seed from the Word of God, His expressed will for you and your loved ones. Draw from His seed bag.

Leviticus 19:19b tells us not to sow two crops in the same field. The Word of God will never produce a bad crop. If weeds begin to surface in the garden, we know from whose bag they have come. We cannot sow faith in God and faith in Satan (doubt) in the same field. Be encouraged, what you are planting from the Word is going to come to harvest if you don't give up.

Ecclesiastes 11:4 says, *"Whoever watches the wind will not plant; whoever looks at the clouds will not reap."* If we look to circumstances, we will not sow the proper Word in each situation. We must sow into our marriages as the Lord directs us, regardless of past records or seemingly impossible circumstances.

Finally, we must sow consistently and wait patiently for the new crops to mature. **Hebrews 10:35,36 NIV** tells us, *"So do not throw away your confidence; it will be richly rewarded. You need to persevere so that when you have done the will of God, you will receive what He has promised."*

****

Record on the following pages the new seed that you are planting into yourself, your spouse, your children, and your home. Then keep a record in each of the gardens as you see the harvests appear.

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HUSBAND

WHAT YOU WANT TO REAP IN YOUR LIFE



WHAT YOU NEED TO SOW IN YOUR LIFE



WIFE

WHAT YOU WANT TO REAP IN YOUR LIFE



WHAT YOU NEED TO SOW IN YOUR LIFE



HUSBAND

WHAT YOU WANT TO REAP IN YOUR WIFE'S LIFE



WHAT YOU NEED TO SOW IN YOUR WIFE'S LIFE



WIFE

WHAT YOU WANT TO REAP IN YOUR HUSBAND'S LIFE



WHAT YOU NEED TO SOW IN YOUR HUSBAND'S LIFE



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TOGETHER

WHAT WE WANT TO REAP IN OUR CHILDREN



WHAT WE NEED TO SOW IN OUR CHILDREN



TOGETHER

WHAT WE WANT TO REAP IN OUR HOME



WHAT WE NEED TO SOW IN OUR HOME



4. Strife occurs in our lives and in our marriage when we have not been pulling weeds effectively. Satan will give us as many seeds for the sowing as we are willing to receive **[Matthew 13:24-27]**. As the crops begin to come up, he returns to point them out to us. If he concentrates on the weeds in our own garden, it results in condemnation. If he concentrates on the weeds in our spouse's garden, it results in judgment, criticism, and strife. If we allow the cycle to continue, with the maturation of each new crop of weeds we have new seeds to sow. Satan doesn't play fair. He even brings up old crops that have long since been gone. He will package his seeds in all kinds of attractive wrappers to get us to take them and plant them. The seeds for strife come from these crops of the enemy. We must be quick to recognize these crops as they begin to appear in our gardens. Be diligent: weed your garden every day! If anything begins to appear that is not of God, repent. **Matthew 15:13** records Jesus saying, *"Every plant that My heavenly Father has not planted will be pulled up by the roots."* Let this become our standard in caring for our fields.

Do not receive demonic communication regarding your spouse. Examine every thought that you have regarding your spouse and ask yourself, "Would Jesus say that?" If it's not from the Lord, it's from the enemy. There are no neutral seeds. Don't take that death seed and plant it in your garden. Remember, it takes two to engage in strife.

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Notes, Thoughts, Suggestions

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Sow Much Fun

Find the words in the grid. Words can go horizontally, vertically and diagonally in all eight directions.

S X W W O R D S L M P P
A E W S N O I T C A B E
T W A T P R A Y I N G Z
T O H S H A R V E S T I
I S R S O N V R Y L W L
T R J S E N K Q H X N I
U S K T M L T A S H P T
D P O R J M F E E A L R
E O R I Z B E A E R W E
S R L F L D R R J A B F
G C N E S T G K L M L L
T I R I P S G G F H T B

actions
attitudes
break
crop
fertilize
flesh
harvest
heart
law
praying
reap
season
seeds
soil
sow
spirit
strife
words

Solution on page 218

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Week 5

The Power of Forgiveness

WEEKLY PRAYER FOCUS

When the Coaching Team Meets to Pray

WEEK 5 - THE POWER OF FORGIVENESS

GOAL: To understand the true meaning of forgiveness, recognize the absolute necessity to forgive, and to learn HOW to forgive.

INSTRUCTION: Be prepared for possible confrontation from those who are holding unforgiveness and don't want to give it up. Minister after the meeting to those who need special help in facing this week's Life Application.

PRAYER FOCUS: Forgiveness is key to marriage healing and strengthening. It is also key to physcial and mental health. Pray for couples to see that forgiveness is not just a good idea, it is commanded by God. Seeing people as God sees them makes it possible for us to not only forgive them but release grace and blessing to them as well.

Continue holding your couples in prayer as they allow the Lord to cleanse their hearts. Continue with spiritual warfare as the Holy Spirit directs with special emphasis on people not taking offense and holding bitterness. This is a powerful turning point and couples' hearts must remain soft to receive what the Lord has for them. Pray that if couples hold any offenses against churches or ministries regarding finances, they will forgive so that they may be free to be led of the Spirit to give whenever and however He directs.

You are going to begin to see deeper and deeper works done in each couple by the Spirit of God. Remain sensitive to His direction in your time of intercession for your couples. Pray ahead for the couples who need to receive the Baptism of the Holy Spirit.

Coaching Team:

Personal Prayer Needs _____

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Ministry Prayer Needs _____

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Notes from Prayer Time:

Praise Reports:

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WEEKLY COACHING TIPS

Why Seven Couples Maximum?

Why do we recommend that there be no more than seven couples in each class?

Well, first of all because that is the direction the Lord gave when He gave the blueprint for the course. Initially we were obedient to His direction, but then occasionally we added a couple or two because of scheduling conflicts. We discovered that the group dynamic changed when that happened.

Since then we did some homework and learned that studies have shown that intimacy in a group (the level of comfort and willingness to share openly) changes greatly when more than fourteen people are in the group. Fourteen will share at a deeper level than fifteen or more.

Amazing. The Holy Spirit gave us clear directions and studies back Him up!

A. God sets the standard.

1. Most people don't have a problem with the **concept** of forgiveness.
2. It is more difficult to do.
   a. We harbor "justified" unforgiveness.
   b. We explain away unforgiveness
      1) "She doesn't want to be forgiven."
      2) "He hurt me beyond repair".
3. Definition of Forgiveness.
   a. To grant free pardon for or remission of an offense or debt
   b. To give up all claim **[Matthew 6:14, 15]**.
4. Jesus freely pardons our sins **[Psalm 103:2-4]**.
   a. We also need to grant pardon freely.
      1) God sets the standard we have to live by.
      2) We can only be forgiven as we forgive.
      3) "I can't forgive" really means "I won't forgive."
5. Results of Unforgiveness **[Matthew 18:23-35]**.
   a. If we do not forgive, we are "delivered … to the torturers" **[Matthew 18:35]**.
   b. Unforgiveness brings pain and turmoil into our lives.
   c. It is a hindrance in our relationship with God
6. We are to **initiate** forgiveness **[Matthew 5:23,24; Mark 11;25]**.
   a. If we are the ones who have been offended.
   b. If we have committed the offense.
7. Forgiveness is a command.
   a. We blame others for the effects of our unforgiveness.
      1) We won't prosper with sin in our lives **[Proverbs 28:13]**.
      2) We need to examine our own hearts, not the other person's **[Matthew 7:1-5; Luke 6:37]**.

B. Judgment and Bitterness.

1. How we judge.
   a. We judge others by their actions and ourselves by our **intentions**.
   b. We want judgment for others, but mercy for ourselves.
   c. We compare the size of the sin ('big' sins and 'little' sins). To God **Sin is Sin** **[1 John 2:4; 1 John 3:4]**.
2. The results of Judgment
   a. We will be judged with the same judgment we use to judge others **[Matthew 7:1]**.
   b. When we judge we often end up doing exactly the same thing as the person we judged.
3. The next step from unforgiveness and judgment is **bitterness** **[Hebrews 12:15]**.
   a. Bitterness will affect many others (not just you and the offender).
   b. We justify our own sins of retaliation and hardness of heart.
   c. Love is crushed in an atmosphere of bitterness.

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God Sets the Standard

Most people don't have a problem with the **concept** of forgiveness, but when we are hurt and need to forgive, we often choose to harbor "justified" unforgiveness in our hearts. We explain away this unforgiveness with reasons such as "she doesn't want to be forgiven;" "he hurt me beyond repair;" "they do it over and over again."

To forgive *means to grant free pardon for or remission of an offense or debt; to give up all claim*. **Matthew 6:14,15** in the Amplified Version reads, *"For if you forgive people their trespasses - that is, their reckless and willful sins, leaving them, letting them go and giving up resentment - your heavenly Father will also forgive you. But if you do not forgive others their trespasses - their reckless and willful sins, leaving them, letting them go and giving up resentment - neither will your Father forgive you your trespasses."*

Jesus paid the full price for our sins and when God forgives, He freely grants pardon **[Psalm 103:2-4]**. God has set the standard. We can only be forgiven as we forgive.

Very often, however, we are like the unmerciful servant in **Matthew 18:23-35**. We want God to totally forgive us and wipe the slate clean regarding our sins, but we justify holding onto the sins of others. The unmerciful servant was turned over to the torturers. **Matthew 18:35** says, *"This is how my heavenly Father will treat each of you unless you forgive your brother from your heart."* Unforgiveness brings turmoil and pain into our lives.

If we say "I can't forgive" we really mean "I won't forgive." When we carry unforgiveness in our heart we begin to sense a hindrance in our relationship with God. **Matthew 5:23,24** and **Mark 11:25**, make it clear that we are to **initiate** forgiveness whether we are the ones offended or the ones who committed the offense.

Sometimes we blame others when we experience the effects of our unforgiveness. (Examples: "It's his fault that family devotions never get started." "It's her fault that our finances are in such a mess.") **Proverbs 28:13** tells us we will not prosper if we conceal our sin. It is not the fault of the person we refuse to forgive. It is a direct result of our own unforgiveness. We need to examine our own hearts, not the other person's **[Matthew 7:1-5; Luke 6:37]**.

Judgement and Bitterness

We judge others by their actions, but we judge ourselves by our **intentions**. We want judgment for others, but mercy for ourselves. Often the "little" sin of our life doesn't seem very significant compared to the "big" sin of someone else, but to God **SIN IS SIN** **[1 John 2:4; 1 John 3:4]**. We will be judged with the same judgement we use to judge others **[Matthew 7:1]** and often end up doing exactly the same thing for which we judged them.

If we continue in unforgiveness and judgement, the next step is **bitterness**. **Hebrews 12:15** tells us to see to it that *"no one misses the grace of God, and that no root of bitterness grows up to cause trouble and defile many."* When bitterness is allowed to take root, it is no longer an issue just between the offender and the one offended. Eventually many others will be affected - family, friends, other relationships

All kinds of sin can be justified by bitterness. We seek to strike back, to get even. Our own hearts become hard and cold. Love is crushed and often destroyed in an atmosphere of bitterness.

PERSONAL EXAMPLES

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C. Discover the Power of Forgiveness.

1. God wants us to learn to forgive and release all claim.
   a. It is not necessary for the offender to repent before we forgive.
   b. The act of forgiveness releases the offender to repentance**[Romans 2:4]**.
   c. Jesus and Stephen are our example **[Luke 23:34; Acts7:60]**.
2. Forgiveness is an act of the **will** not a feeling.
   a. Agree with the will of God.
   b. Follow the leading of His Spirit.
   c. Determine to forgive.
   d. Our feelings will follow our decision.
3. What if a person repeatedly keeps doing or saying the same things?
   a. There is no limit to the number of times we are to forgive **[Matthew 18:22]**.
   b. Love keeps no record of wrongs **[1 Corinthians 13:5]**.
   c. Love covers a multitude of sins **[1 Peter 4:8]**.
   d. When you have forgiven much you can expect to receive much love **[Luke 7:47]**.
4. How do we forgive? Forgive as God does.
   a. Be quick to forgive.
   b. Don't remember previous offenses **[Isaiah 43:25; Psalm 103:12]**.
      1) This is not sudden amnesia.
      2) Don't **actively** remember the offense. (Don't dwell on it).
   c. Treat each new offense as the first.
   d. Don't rely on your human capability this is only possible through the power of God.
5. Do you have trouble forgiving yourself?
   a. Many times we feel freer to release others from their guilt than we do to release ourselves.
      1) Perhaps we know ourselves all too well, our shortcomings and our failures.
      2) Constantly feeling unworthy is a sign that we have unforgiveness toward ourselves.
   b. Christ has made us worthy by His blood.
      1) **Colossians 1:10** and **1 Thessalonians 2:12** both tell us to walk worthy of our calling.
      2) God would not command us to walk worthy if He had not made us so.
   c. If God can forgive us, who are we to retain our own sin?
      1) Are we more righteous than He?
      2) In **Genesis 16**, Sarai was upset and angry with herself for giving her servant girl to Abram to bear him a child.
         a) She took her anger out on Hagar, the servant girl.
         b) Hagar despised Sarai and Sarai mistreated Hagar.
         c) We often take unforgiveness toward self out on others, usually those closest to us or the ones who remind us most of our failure to forgive.

D. Taking up Someone Else's Offense.

1.If someone offends our spouse or children we might get angry and take up their offense.

2. Just like with the dog, once you have picked up the offense, how do you let it go? **[Proverbs 26:17]**.
   a. Repent of having taken up the offense and let it go.
   b. Help the one who has been offended to forgive.

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Discover the Power of Forgiveness

Our Father wants us to learn to forgive and release all claim when we are wounded or offended. It is not necessary for the offender to repent before we forgive. It is the very act of forgiveness that releases the offender to repentance **[Romans 2:4]**. While they were dying, both Jesus and Stephen sought forgiveness for those who sought their death without any desire to repent **[Luke 23:34; Acts 7:60]**.

Forgiveness is an act of our **will**, not our feelings. When we put our will in agreement with the will of God, follow the leading of His Spirit, and determine to forgive, our feelings will eventually follow.

But what if a person keeps doing or saying the same things again and again? **Matthew 18:22** says there is no limit to the number of times we are to forgive. According to **1 Corinthians 13:5**, love keeps no record of wrongs. **1 Peter 4:8** tells us that love covers a multitude of sins. Jesus told us in **Luke 7:47** that where there has been much forgiven there is much love. If we are given the opportunity to forgive our spouse often, we can believe for a return of great love.

Once we have forgiven our spouse and he or she does the same thing again, we need to be quick to forgive again and choose to forget the previous offenses. When we forgive as God does, we forget the offense **[Isaiah 43:25; Psalm 103:12]**. This doesn't mean we suddenly have amnesia. It means that we do not **actively** remember the offense. We do not dwell on it. Each new offense should be as though there had been no other. This means we also don't bring up past offenses that have been forgiven. This is not possible in our own human power. It is only possible through the power of God.

How about yourself? Do you have trouble forgiving yourself? Many times we feel freer to release others from their guilt than we do to release ourselves. Perhaps it is because we know ourselves all too well, our shortcomings and our failures. A constant feeling of unworthiness is a sure sign that we have unforgiveness toward ourselves. Christ has made us worthy by His blood. **Colossians 1:10** and **1 Thessalonians 2:12** both tell us to walk worthy of our calling. There is no way that God could command us to walk worthy if He had not made us so.

If God can forgive us, who are we to retain our own sin? Are we more righteous than He? In **Genesis 16**, Sarai was upset and angry with herself for giving her servant girl to Abram so that she could bear him a child. She took her anger out on Hagar, the servant girl. Hagar despised Sarai and Sarai mistreated Hagar. Often we take our unforgiveness toward self out on others, usually those closest to us or the ones who remind us most of our failure to forgive.

Taking Up Someone Else's Offense

If someone offends our spouse or our children, we may get angry and take up their offense. **Proverbs 26:17** tells us that meddling in a quarrel that is not our own is like picking up a dog by the ears.

Think of that for a moment. How do you put down a dog that you have picked up by the ears? Any way you do it you're going to get hurt. Taking up the offense of another is the same thing. It is very difficult to put down. There is only one way to do it. Repent of having taken up the offense and let it go.

Help the one who has been offended to forgive. When your spouse has been wounded, you need to respond in **empathy** not sympathy. That means, not feeling

PERSONAL EXAMPLES

c. Respond with **empathy** not sympathy.
   1) Don't feel sorry for them help them get healed.

3. You must forgive the offender even if the one offended will not.
4. We cannot afford even small areas of unforgiveness in our marriage.
   a. Jesus took our divisions to the cross.
   b. *"For He, Himself is our peace, who has made the two one and has destroyed the barrier, the dividing wall of hostility by abolishing in His flesh the law with its commandments and regulations. His purpose was to create in Himself one body to reconcile both of them to God through the cross, by which He put to death their hostility"* **[Ephesians 2:14-16]**.

E. Words of Encouragement

1. There are some who feel there is nothing to forgive, nothing between the two.
   a. He has told us that you will recognize the word "disappointment."
   b. There has been much disappointment between the two of you and you need to forgive and set each other free in this area.
   c. This applies also to areas in which children have disappointed you.
2. For others the hurt is so deep and so enormous that it is going to be a slow, step-by-step healing.
   a. Be encouraged.
   b. The Lord is going before you and is making a way for you.
      1) The healing is coming.
      2) Do not be overwhelmed or dismayed.
      3) You cannot begin to imagine the joyful love that awaits you two. It is preserved in the Father's heart all these years just for the appointed time.
      4) Soon you will begin to glimpse its beginning.
3. And then there are some who cannot yet look beneath the surface.
   a. On the surface all is calm and you fear if you look any deeper, things may not be all you want them to be.
   b. The Lord would have you know that there is more—much more, but you must take the step of faith and trust that the glory to come will surpass the present beauty.
4. Today begin to discover the power of forgiveness.
   a. Do that which you previously had thought was impossible.
   b. Remember, it is an act of the will, not a feeling.
      1) Ask God to show you how He sees the person.
      2) Allow His compassion to well up within you. Choose to do it - be **obedient**.
   c. Take the hurt you received to the cross and exchange it for the love and mercy of Jesus.
      1) Confess it as done and then remember the offense NO MORE.
      2) Refuse to dwell on it.
5. Sow good seeds.
6. Bless the one you are forgiving **[Matthew 5:44]**.
      1) Treat your spouse as you would have God treat you.
      2) Forgive much and be loved much!
7. With the power of God in our lives, there is no obstacle to forgiveness.
8. With His nature dwelling within us, we discover the power that enables us to forgive and trust again.

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sorry for your spouse, but understanding that he or she has been wounded and helping him or her to forgive the offender. Forgiveness brings healing. Even if they refuse to forgive, you must forgive the offender.

We cannot afford even small areas of unforgiveness in our marriage. *"For He, Himself is our peace, who has made the two one and has destroyed the barrier, the dividing wall of hostility by abolishing in His flesh the law with its commandments and regulations. His purpose was to create in Himself one body to reconcile both of them to God through the cross, by which He put to death their hostility"* **[Ephesians 2:14-16]**. Even though this scripture refers to the Jews and the Gentiles, it is an excellent scripture for husband and wife to help us realize that Jesus took our divisions to the cross. Don't allow the enemy to attempt to rebuild that wall of unforgiveness!

Words of Encouragement

As we were preparing this, God spoke to us that there are some who feel there is nothing to forgive, nothing between the two. He has told us that you will recognize the word "disappointment." There has been much disappointment between the two of you and you need to forgive and set each other free in this area. This applies also to areas in which children have disappointed you.

For others He has said the hurt is so deep and so enormous that it is going to be a slow, step-by-step healing. Be encouraged. The Lord is going before you and is making a way for you. The healing is coming. Do not be overwhelmed or dismayed. You cannot begin to imagine the joyful love that awaits you two. It has been preserved in the Father's heart all these years just for the appointed time. Soon you will begin to glimpse its beginning.

And then there are some who cannot yet look beneath the surface. On the surface all is calm and you fear that if you look any deeper, things may not be all you want them to be. The Lord would have you know that there is more—much more, but you must take the step of faith and trust that the glory to come will surpass the present beauty.

Today, now, this minute, begin to discover the power of forgiveness. Do that which you previously had thought was impossible. Remember, it is an act of the will, not a feeling. Ask God to show you how He sees the person. Allow His compassion to well up within you. Choose to do it - be **obedient**. Take the hurt you received to the cross and exchange it for the love and mercy of Jesus. Confess it as done and then remember the offense NO MORE. Refuse to dwell on it.

Sow good seeds. Bless the one you are forgiving **[Matthew 5:44]**. Treat your spouse as you would have God treat you. Forgive much and be loved much! When we have the power of God in our lives, there is no obstacle to forgiveness. When we have His nature dwelling within us, we discover the power that enables us to forgive and trust again.

Interactive

Do any of the words of enouragement apply to you?

Look again at these three situations. Talk with each other for the next few minutes. If one or more of them apply(ies) to your marriage, give each other permission to work on these areas this week. Ask the Lord to help you this week to face the things you need to and to see victory in these areas. (Time three minutes and then close the class)

PERSONAL EXAMPLES

Life Application - Let's make it real

It is time to discover the power of forgiveness!

Scripture says that David was a man after God's own heart **[Acts 13:22]**. Yet we read in the life of David that he committed sin, even murder and adultery. Then how can it be said that he was a man after God's own heart? For one thing, he was quick to forgive. Throughout **2 Samuel** we see David again and again offended and wounded, but David was consistent in his forgiveness, keeping his heart pure. When David became involved in adultery with Bathsheba, even arranging for her husband to be killed so that David might have her, he readily admitted his guilt and repented when confronted **[2 Samuel 11 and 12]**. When the child of that union died despite David's prayer and fasting, he readily forgave himself and did not hold unforgiveness against God. How many of us could have done that, or would we spend years regretting what we had done?

David's son, Absalom, on the other hand, is a classic picture of unforgiveness. In **2 Samuel 13**, Amnon raped Absalom's sister. The unforgiveness in Absalom's heart led to murder, conspiracy against the king, envy, strife, and eventually to Absalom's death **[2 Samuel 13 to 2 Samuel 18:15]**. **We cannot afford** to hold unforgiveness in our hearts. Regardless of what the offense was or how big the failure was, if Jesus could shed His innocent blood for it, we certainly cannot hold an offense against someone else or ourselves. Right now, today, we are going to get rid of that garbage. We are going to free others and ourselves.

1. It is time to let Jesus help you clean house in the area of unforgiveness.

Each of you sit down alone and make a list of everyone the Holy Spirit brings to mind that you have not forgiven. He may begin to show you areas of unforgiveness that you have harbored from as far back as childhood. You need to forgive anyone who has ever offended you.

This may be a difficult time for you. Some of the feelings of shame, humiliation, and hurt may come flooding back as you remember the offenses. Allow Jesus to heal those hurts as you release forgiveness to each person. (You may wish to speak your forgiveness of them out loud. Sometimes the spoken word has power to "cement" things that have been mere thoughts in your mind.)

Are there any reasons that you have for not forgiving these people? Does the Word of God support any of these reasons?

When we hold unforgiveness in our hearts, it is the soul that is wounded. Our soul (mind, will, and emotions) refuses to let go of the hurt and makes a conscious decision to retain the offense. The more we yield to the leading of the Spirit, the more we will be quick to forgive those who have wounded or offended us.

As you forgive each one, use a red pen to cross them off your list. Let that red ink remind you of the blood of Jesus blotting out each offense. Release to Jesus all who have offended you. Ask Him to help you see each one as He sees them.

This period that you are alone may take some time. Give each other whatever time is necessary to finish. It may even take several days to work through all of it. Be patient and continue to pray for each other during this time.

2. Now examine your heart and see if there are areas of unforgiveness toward yourself. By an act of your will, choose to forgive yourself. Ask God to help you see yourself as He sees you.

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3. When you have each completed your time alone and have forgiven all that the Lord has shown you, come back together. Now ask the Holy Spirit to show you as a couple if there is anyone you have not forgiven that has offended the two of you or your family. Consider not only people but also churches, ministries, and organizations. Many people today are carrying unforgiveness toward ministries or previous churches and pastors. Because they have not forgiven them, they cannot settle peacefully in any church or support any ministry.

As He brings them to mind, forgive them as a couple. Pray for each other and encourage each other when forgiving is difficult. Release all hurt and retribution to Jesus. Ask Him to place His compassion for each of the offenders in your hearts.

If there are those who have offended your entire family and if you sense your children are ready for this, you may wish to gather the whole family together and forgive those who have wounded all of you. If you do not believe your children are ready for this now, you as a couple need to forgive the offenders in the name of your family and pray for the day when the children will also be able to release them in forgiveness.

4. Ask the Lord to show you if either of you have taken up the offense of others. Is there anyone that has wounded your spouse or your children that you are refusing to forgive? Have you sided with friends or relatives in a conflict they have had with someone else? Are you finding it difficult to forgive those who offended them?

If you realize that you have taken up another person's offense, repent of having done so. Then forgive the offender. If the offended person is your spouse or your child, help him or her to forgive the offender if they have not already done so. Agree to help each other get healed when wounding occurs in the future.

5. Finally, the time has come for you to forgive each other for any offenses, disappointments, repeated commissions or omissions (things you have done or have failed to do), and anything else that the Holy Spirit shows you. Share this forgiveness with each other after a time of prayer together. This is not a time to accuse or lay guilt on each other. Treat each other with the mercy and tenderness that you would want of Jesus if you were talking with Him about your own sin.

As you forgive each other, also repent for any times that you have brought up past sins that had already been forgiven. When you are finished with all the Lord has shown you, pray this prayer together:

"Lord, Jesus, today we receive Your forgiveness for our sins. We will not remember them anymore. We receive Your compassion for each other and determine from this day forth to walk in love and mercy toward each other. Wash us now with Your blood. Cleanse us from all unrighteousness. Let our hearts be tender toward each other.

Let Your love cover a multitude of sins. May we see each other through Your eyes from now on. Today we believe we have received this in Your Name. Amen."

6. Now begin walking out the forgiveness you have given and received. If one spouse stumbles, let the other help him or her up **[Ecclesiastes 4:10]**. Each time, continue to ask yourself, "Am I treating this person the way I want Jesus to treat me when I sin?" A couple that is quick to forgive can overcome any obstacles the devil throws in their path.

Can you solve this cryptogram about marriage? Hint: R=Y

MZGH RVE BVDLFKG, RVE FH HV MXR SZXHLG AZG

TXPA - WEA RVE PEDG CV SZXHLG AZG BEAEDG -

-WGDHXDC JGQAHGD



Solution on page 218

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Week 6

The Power of Faith

WEEKLY PRAYER FOCUS

When the Coaching Team Meets to Pray

WEEK 6 - THE POWER OF FAITH

GOAL: To help couples understand what a faith vision is, how to develop one, and the necessity for having one for each other and for their one-flesh relationship.

INSTRUCTION: Caution couples against taking their list of grievances against their spouse and making it into a checklist regarding what they want God to change. This is to be GOD'S faith vision for each other.

PRAYER FOCUS: You are going to begin to see deeper and deeper works done in each couple by the Spirit of God. Remain sensitive to His direction in your time of intercession for your couples. Pray ahead for the couples who need to receive the Baptism of the Holy Spirit. Pray for your couples to have new faith regarding their finances as they prepare to give financially this week.

Coaching Team:

Personal Prayer Needs _____

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Ministry Prayer Needs _____

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Notes from Prayer Time:

Praise Reports:

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WEEKLY COACHING TIPS

Where Does the Giving Go?

That's a fair question. People will want to know where the money they give is going to go.

The registration fee for classes is deliberately kept low because we want couples to seek the Lord regarding what they should give financially. We know that in giving they are blessed and so we would rather see them blessed than just pay for a course. The financial giving of couples provides income to the ministry for outreach across the United States and around the world. These funds help to train new leaders, translate materials, and print class materials in languages to reach new countries.

Currently a secondary, higher registration fee is offered to couples who prefer not to give in the weekly offering. Couples may choose the registraton fee that best suits their needs.

All giving to the ministry is tax deductible. Couples can give cash, checks, money orders, or by credit cards. Please make sure they complete a giving envelope if they give cash so that they can receive tax credit for their giving.

Monthly automatic withdrawal from their bank account is also available. They just need to complete the form found in your Class Packet. You can include the form with your Weekly Impact Report.

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A. Seeing As God Sees

1. How do you see yourself?
   a. How do you see your spouse?
      1) When you think of him or her, what comes to mind first?
      2) Are they loving thoughts or have the years clouded your opinion?
2. Have you thought about how God sees you or how He sees your spouse?
   a. God is filled with faith for each of us.
   b. **1 Samuel 16:7**: *"For the Lord does not see as man sees; for man looks at the outward appearance, but the Lord looks at the heart."* **(NKJ)**
3. **Psalm 139:13-18** says that from the very beginning of our life, God knew us and loved us. (See scripture in text)
4. God has always been for you.
   a. He is not waiting for you to prove yourself.
   b. He loved you from the very beginning and He has faith in you.
   c. *"For I know the thoughts that I think toward you," says the Lord, thoughts of peace and not of evil, to give you a future and a hope"* **[Jeremiah 29:11]**.
      1) No child is a mistake; no life is without **purpose**.
      2) People and events often shape our lives in a very different direction than God planned.
      3) We must learn what God has to say about us and what His plans are for us.
5. When Jesus went to the cross, He died for each one of us.
   a. Through His death and resurrection He paid the price and won the victory to bring God's plan to our lives.
   b. When we enter into covenant with Jesus, through Him we are able to see the plan that God has for us.
   c. Our Father sees us now through what the blood of Jesus accomplished for us.
      1) We are redeemed, healed, delivered, and made whole.
      2) He sees us only as Jesus has made us.
      3) When we allow Him, He **transforms** us into what God has planned.
6. To believe that God's promises are for you, you need to believe that God loves you.
   a. If you are not absolutely certain that God loves you with an unconditional love, it is hard to believe His promises.
   b. You may believe that all of His promises are for His children **[Jeremiah 29:11; Mark 7:27; Psalm 84:11]**, but may not believe that includes you.
      1) Are you in covenant with God?
      2) Then you are His child! His plan and His promises are for you! It is time for that truth to become reality for you.

B. God's Vision in Your Marriage

1. God has a plan for each one of us.
2. Covenant means death to independent living.
   a. You are now **one** as husband and wife.
   1) God's plans for your spouse are now a critical part of your life and His plans for you are now a critical part of your spouse's life.
   2) It is important that you begin to see each other as God sees you.

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Seeing As God Sees

How do you see yourself? How do you see your spouse? When you think of him or her, what comes to mind first? Are they loving thoughts or have the years clouded your opinion?

Have you ever thought about how God sees you or how He sees your spouse? Do you think He thinks as you do? God is filled with faith for each of us. **1 Samuel 16:7** tells us, *"For the Lord does not see as man sees; for man looks at the outward appearance, but the Lord looks at the heart."* **(NKJ)**

Psalm 139:13-18 says that from the very beginning of our life, God knew us and loved us. *"For You formed my inward parts; You covered me in my mother's womb. I will praise You, for I am fearfully and wonderfully made; Marvelous are Your works, and that my soul knows very well. My frame was not hidden from You, when I was made in secret, and skillfully wrought in the lowest parts of the earth. Your eyes saw my substance, being yet unformed. And in Your book they all were written the days fashioned for me, when as yet there were none of them. How precious also are Your thoughts to me, O God! How great is the sum of them! If I should count them, they would be more in number than the sand; When I awake, I am still with You."*

God is for you. He always has been. He is not waiting for you to prove yourself. He loved you from the very beginning and He has faith in you. *"For I know the thoughts that I think toward you," says the Lord, thoughts of peace and not of evil, to give you a future and a hope"* **[Jeremiah 29:11]**. No child is a mistake; no life is without **purpose**. The problem is people and events often shape our lives in a very different direction than God has planned. We cannot settle for that, though. We must learn what God has to say about us and what His plans are for us.

When Jesus went to the cross, He died for each one of us. Through His death and resurrection He paid the price and won the victory to bring God's plan to our lives. When we enter into covenant with Jesus, through Him we are able to see the plan that God has for us.

Our Father sees us now through what the blood of Jesus accomplished for us. We are redeemed, healed, delivered, and made whole. We are beautiful in His sight. He does not see our faults, our sins, or where we have fallen short. He has perfect vision when it comes to us because He sees us only as Jesus has made us. Jesus shares the Father's vision for each of us and when we allow Him, He **transforms** us into what God has planned.

To believe that God's promises are for you, you need to believe that God loves you. If you are not absolutely certain that God loves you with an unconditional, eternal love, it is hard to believe His promises. You may be absolutely certain that all of His promises are for His children **[Jeremiah 29:11; Mark 7:27; Psalm 84:11]**, but may not believe that includes you. Are you in covenant with God? Then you are His child! His plan and His promises are for you! It is time for that truth to become reality for you.

God's Vision in Your Marriage

God has a plan for each one of us. Because covenant means death to independent living, you are now **one** as husband and wife. God's plans for your spouse are now a critical part of your life and His plans for you are now a critical part of your spouse's life. It is important that you begin to see each other as God sees you.

PERSONAL EXAMPLES

3. The enemy also has a plan to destroy each of us.
   a. He makes sure that we hear and experience things that are contrary to God's plan for us.
   b. When you married, each of you had been affected in some way by the enemy's attack against **God's** plans.
   c. Your life together has either reinforced what God believes about you or what the enemy has convinced you is true.
4. You must decide with whom you are going to agree.
   a. Will you go to God and ask Him how He sees each of you?
   b. Are you willing to settle for what the enemy has told you that you are?

Interactive

This is going to be a personal interactive, not done as a couple.

Did you realize that God has a plan for your life? Have you ever asked Him how He sees you? Have you listened to other voices that have discouraged you about His plan for you? Have circumstances made you believe that God is not for you?

Spend the next few moments with the Lord and let Him share with you how much He loves you and how He sees you.

(Time three minutes and then continue the

C. Faith

1. *"Now faith is the substance of things hoped for, the evidence of thing not seen"* **[Hebrews 11:1]**
   a. Substance means the "ultimate reality that underlies all outward manifestations and change."
   b. Evidence is defined as "something that furnishes proof."
   c. **Faith is the ultimate reality that underlies all outward change and furnishes the proof of what is unseen.**
   d. Faith is the vehicle that brings what God sees and believes into reality in our lives.
2. Faith requires vision.
   a. **Proverbs 29:18 (KJV)** says, *"Where there is no vision, the people perish."*
      1) If not having vision brings death, then having vision brings **life**.
      2) This is not our vision; it is God's.
      3) We need to know how God sees us and what He says about us.
   b. The Word of God is His will for us.
   c. Ask Him to show you in His word how He sees you and your spouse.
      1) Not a selfish seeking of scriptures supporting what we want to see, but sincerely seeking what God says.
      2) Knowing His vision and praying His Word, we are in **agreement** with His vision and plan **[Matthew 18:19]**.
   d. You can begin praying "generic" scriptures today for your spouse as you wait for specific ones from the Lord.
      1) **Proverbs 31** is a wonderful prayer for a husband to pray over his wife.
      2) **Psalm 1** is a powerful prayer for a wife to pray for her husband.
      3) This is a good place to begin speaking God's Word over your spouse.
         a) Put his or her name in those scriptures and begin speaking them in agreement with God.
         b) (Example: *"Blessed is John who walks not…." or "Mary's worth is far above rubies…"*)

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The enemy also has a plan to destroy each of us and so he makes sure that we hear and experience things that are contrary to God's plan for us. When you married, each of you had been affected in some way by the enemy's attack against **God's** plans. Your life together has either reinforced what God believes about you or what the enemy has convinced you is true.

You have a choice, then, and must decide with whom you are going to agree. Will you go to God and ask Him how He sees each of you, or are you willing to settle for what the enemy has told you that you are?

Interactive

This is going to be a personal interactive, not done as a couple.

Did you realize that God has a plan for your life? Have you ever asked Him how He sees you? Have you listened to other voices that have discouraged you about His plan for you? Have circumstances made you believe that God is not for you?

Spend the next few moments with the Lord and let Him share with you how much He loves you and how He sees you.

(Time three minutes and then continue the class)

Faith

Scripture tells us, *"Now faith is the substance of things hoped for, the evidence of thing not seen"*. **Hebrews 11:1** The dictionary tells us that substance means the "ultimate reality that underlies all outward manifestations and change." Evidence is defined as "something that furnishes proof." **So faith is the ultimate reality that underlies all outward change and furnishes the proof of what is unseen.** Faith is the vehicle that brings what God sees and believes into reality in our lives.

Faith requires vision. **Proverbs 29:18 (KJV)** says, *"Where there is no vision, the people perish."* If not having vision brings death, then having vision brings **life**. This is not our vision, though, it is God's. We need to know how God sees us and what He says about us. And where do we find what God says? In His Word!

The Word of God is His will for us. Ask Him to show you in His word how He sees you and your spouse. This is not a selfish seeking of scriptures that support what we want to see, but a sincere seeking to learn what God says. When we know what His vision is and we pray His Word, we put ourselves in **agreement** with His vision and plan **[Matthew 18:19]**.

There are many wonderful "generic" scriptures that you can begin praying today for your spouse as you wait for specific ones from the Lord. **Proverbs 31** is a wonderful prayer for a husband to pray over his wife. **Psalm 1** is a powerful prayer for a wife to pray for her husband.

This is a good place to begin speaking God's Word over your spouse. Put his or her name in those scriptures and begin speaking them in agreement with God. (Example: *"Blessed is John who walks not…."* or *"Mary's worth is far above rubies…"*) As God begins to give you specific scriptures for your spouse, write them down. Put your spouse's name in them and pray God's Word for him or her.

PERSONAL EXAMPLES

e. As God begins to give you specific scriptures for your spouse, write them down.
f. Put your spouse's name in them and pray God's Word for him or her.

D. Speaking As God Speaks.

1. **John 15:7 NIV**: *"If you remain in Me and My words remain in you, ask whatever you wish, and it will be given you."*
2. Our children learn to speak by listening to us, their parents.
   a. The time we spend with our **Father** is what will determine how we will speak.
   b. **1 Peter 3:12 Amplified** tells us that *"...His ears are attentive (open)"* to our prayers.
      1) It must be just as exciting for God to hear us speak His Word as it is for us as parents to hear our children begin to speak.
      2) He wants to hear us speaking what He says about our spouse, our marriage and our family.
3. God backs up His Word.
   a. **Isaiah 55:11 (Amplified)**: *"So shall My Word be that goes forth out of My mouth; it shall not return to **Me** void—without producing any effect, useless—but it shall accomplish that which I please and purpose, and it shall prosper in the thing for which I sent it."*
   b. **Psalm 103:20** tells us that God sends His angels to accomplish His Word.
   c. We need to discover the power of God's Word!
4. Every time you speak about your spouse, determine if you are agreeing with what God has spoken to you or if you are agreeing with what your natural eyes are seeing.

E. Seeing What We Speak

1. As God reveals His vision, if you are lacking the faith, His Word will renew your mind to that truth.
   a. If you are having a hard time believing that God wants you healed, speaking these scriptures will help you to see that healing is God's will.
      1) *"He forgives all my sin and heals all my diseases"* **[Psalm 103:3 NIV]**.
      2) *"He himself bore our sins in his body on the tree, so that we might die to sins and live for righteousness; by his wounds you have been healed"* **[1 Peter 2:24]**.
   b.. **Romans 10:17** tells us that *"faith comes by **hearing**, and hearing by the word of God"*
      1) The more you hear the Word of God spoken, the more it renews your mind.
      2) As the Word renews your mind to the truth, you begin to BELIEVE God wants you healed.
      3) That is faith.
   c. When your mind is renewed to truth, it causes the Word to drop into your heart and become belief **[Romans 12:2 NKJV]**.
2. When your heart believes, (is convinced, is persuaded, is won over, and trusts), your mouth speaks mountain-moving, creative scripture.
   a. Scripture is God's will and you are agreeing with Him.
   b. Your faith rests in Him, not your own ability **[1 Corinthians 2:5 NIV]**.
   b. Faith is based in the **power** of God, not a formula.
3. Faith is the evidence of things not yet seen.
   a. Paul encourages us, *"…we do not look on the things which are seen, but at the thing which are not seen. For the things which are seen are temporary, but the things which are not seen are eternal"* **[2 Corinthians 4:18]**.
      1) As you seek God's vision and plan, remember what He sees and plans may not be visible right now.
      2) We need to focus on what is not yet seen, not on that which we can see.
   b. Change is seen and accomplished in the spirit realm long before it is seen in the natural **[Romans 4:19-21]**.
      1) God **spoke** and created the world. All throughout **Genesis 1**, what God **said** was created.

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Speaking As God Speaks

John 15:7 NIV tells us, *"If you remain in Me and My words remain in you, ask whatever you wish, and it will be given you."* Our children learn to speak by listening to us, their parents. The time we spend with our **Father** is what will determine how we will speak. **1 Peter 3:12 Amplified** tells us that *"...His ears are attentive (open)"* to our prayers. It must be just as exciting for God to hear us speak His Word as it is for us as parents to hear our children begin to speak. He wants to hear us speaking what He says about our spouse, our marriage, and our family.

God backs up His Word. In **Isaiah 55:11 (Amplified)** He says, *"So shall My Word be that goes forth out of My mouth; it shall not return to Me void—without producing any effect, useless—but it shall accomplish that which I please and purpose, and it shall prosper in the thing for which I sent it."* **Psalm 103:20** tells us that God sends His angels to accomplish His Word. We need to discover the power of God's Word!

Every time you speak about your spouse you need to determine if you are agreeing with what God has spoken to you or if you are agreeing with what your natural eyes are seeing. You may be asking, "Well, how do I do that when things are so clearly different from what God is saying? " As usual, you do it God's way.

Seeing What We Speak

As God begins to reveal His vision, if you are lacking the faith to believe Him, His Word will renew your mind to that truth. For instance, if you have just discovered that it is God's will for you to be in health yet you are having a hard time believing that, speaking scriptures such as, *"He forgives all my sin and heals all my diseases,"* **[Psalm 103:3 NIV]** or *"He himself bore our sins in his body on the tree, so that we might die to sins and live for righteousness; by his wounds you have been healed"* **[1 Peter 2:24]**, will help you to see that healing is God's will. **Romans 10:17** tells us that *"faith comes by* **hearing**, *and hearing by the word of God"* The more you hear the Word of God spoken, the more it renews your mind.

As the Word renews your mind to the truth, as the scripture becomes real to you, then you begin to BELIEVE God wants you healed. That is faith. When your mind is renewed to truth, it causes the Word to drop into your heart and become belief **[Romans 12:2 NKJV]**. When your heart believes, (is convinced, is persuaded, is won over, and trusts), your mouth then speaks mountain-moving, creative scripture. The words of scripture are God's will and you are agreeing with Him. Your faith rests in Him, not your own ability. **[1 Corinthians 2:5 NIV]** Faith is based in the **power** of God, not a formula.

Remember, faith is the evidence of things not yet seen. Paul encourages us in scripture, *"…we do not look on the things which are seen, but at the thing which are not seen. For the things which are seen are temporary, but the things which are not seen are eternal."* **[2 Corinthians 4:18]** As we seek God for His vision and plan, we need to remember that what He sees and plans may not be visible right now. We need to focus on what is not yet seen, not on that which we can see.

Change is seen and accomplished in the spirit realm long before we see it in the natural **[Romans 4:19-21]**. God **spoke** and created the world. All throughout **Genesis 1**, what God **said** was created. When Jesus walked the earth He **spoke** and the blind saw, the lame walked, and the dead came back to life.

PERSONAL EXAMPLES

2) When Jesus walked the earth He **spoke** and the blind saw, the lame walked, and the dead came back to life.

4. We need to do what God does - **speak** the Word.
   a. It is not enough to just think it or read it.
   b. Speaking what God says is powerful.
      1) Faith is always spoken when it has not yet been seen in the natural.
      2) As you agree with God about what He says, you begin to discover the transforming power of faith!
5. Believing what God says does not mean ignoring the circumstances, it means overcoming them.
   a. God *"...calls those things which are not as though they were"* not those things that are as though they were not **[Romans 4:17]**.
   b. We are not ignoring physical reality; we are merely saying God's Word is more **powerful**.
      1) When God promised Abraham that he would be the father of many nations, he faced the circumstances of his 100-year-old body and Sarah's dead womb.
      2) He did not ignore the physical realities. He just believed God was more powerful than the circumstances of his life **[Romans 4:19-22]**.
      3) And he was right!

F. What About Trust

1. Faith requires trust.
   a. One dictionary definition of trust is "confidence."
   b. Speaking what God says and believing His Word requires confidence in Him.
2. Trusting God may seem hard, but trusting **people** sometimes seems impossible.
   a. People wound us, disappoint us, and hurt us.
   b. Many times our spouse has been the one who has done those things most frequently.
3. Most couples begin their marriage trusting each other.
   a. As the years go by, though, trust can be eroded slowly through disappointments or unmet expectations.
   b. Or trust may be totally shattered through trauma such as adultery, abuse, or abandonment.
   c. Either way, once trust is broken there can be jealousy, doubt, fear and constant suspicion.
4. Trusting **God** is key to faith.
   a. We must trust God, not our spouse, to restore trust in our relationship.
      1) Jesus can rebuild trust even before your spouse is worthy of that trust.
      2) Jesus is completely trustworthy and you can rest in the fact that He is working in you, your spouse, and your relationship.
5. Trusting God takes the pressure off of each other and gives us the freedom to grow in Christ.
   a. Freedom is not based in performance, but in the power of God.
   b. If we put our trust in each other, failure can be devastating.
      1) *"Cursed is the one who trusts in man, who depends on flesh for his strength"* **[Jeremiah 17:5 NIV]**.
      2) When our trust is in Jesus, failure on the part of our spouse can be forgiven and we can grow together.
6. The first step is to forgive your spouse for the sin or disappointments that have broken trust.
   a. If you do not forgive, you hinder the work of God.
   b. Once you have forgiven, place your trust in God.
      1) He is bigger than any challenge we face.
      2) He is able to change hearts **[Jeremiah 32:39; Ezekiel 11:19]**.
      3) He never fails **[1 Corinthians 15:57]**.
      4) You can trust Him to finish the work He has begun **[Psalm 138:8 and Philippians 1:6]**.

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We need to do what God does - **speak** the Word. It is not enough to just think it or read it. Speaking what God says is powerful. And faith is always spoken when it has not yet been seen in the natural. As you agree with God about what He says, you begin to discover the transforming power of faith!

Believing what God says does not mean ignoring the circumstances, it means overcoming them. God *"...calls those things which are not as though they were"* not those things that are as though they were not **[Romans 4:17]**. We are not ignoring physical reality; we are merely saying God's Word is more **powerful**. When God promised Abraham that he would be the father of many nations, he faced the circumstances of his 100-year-old body and Sarah's dead womb. He did not ignore the physical realities he saw. He just believed God was more powerful than the circumstances of his life **[Romans 4:19-22]**. And he was right!

What About Trust

Faith requires trust. One dictionary definition of trust is "confidence." Speaking what God says and believing His Word requires confidence in Him.

Trusting God may seem hard, but trusting **people** sometimes seems impossible. People wound us, disappoint us, and hurt us. Many times our spouse has been the one who has done those things most frequently.

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When we trust God it takes the pressure off of each other and gives us each the freedom to grow in Christ. That freedom is not based in performance, but in the power of God. If we put our trust in each other, failure can be devastating. *"Cursed is the one who trusts in man, who depends on flesh for his strength"* **[Jeremiah 17:5 NIV]**. When we put our trust in Jesus, though, failure on the part of our spouse can be forgiven and we can grow together.

The first step is to forgive your spouse for the sin or disappointments that have broken trust. If you do not forgive, you hinder the work of God. Once you have forgiven your spouse, place your trust in God. He is bigger than any challenge we face. God is able to change hearts **[Jeremiah 32:39; Ezekiel 11:19]**. God never fails **[1 Corinthians 15:57]**. You can trust Him to finish the work He has begun **[Psalm 138:8 and Philippians 1:6]**.

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E. Remember.

1. As you seek the Lord, He will show you how He sees your spouse **[Romans 12:2]**.
2. As God gives His vision from His Word, write it down so that you can have it before your eyes **[Habakkuk 2:2,3]**.
3. Then begin to speak God's Word forth for your spouse, confessing what God says to be true **[Isaiah 55:11]**.
   a. Meditate day and night on the Word He has given you **[Psalm 1:2; Psalm 119:148]**.
   b. The more you have the truth of the Word within you, the less you are going to be swayed by temporary **circumstances**.
4. Then believe God's Word for your spouse **[Jeremiah 1:12]**.
5. Speaking God's Word forth with heart belief is going to change the circumstances **[Mark 11:24]**.
   a. Trust God to bring His Word to pass in your own life, the life of your spouse, and in your marriage **[Romans 10:11]**.
   b. What God says is more real than the circumstances you see.
6. Jesus said if we have faith as a mustard seed, we could move mountains **[Matthew 17:20]**.
   a. A mustard seed is a tiny little seed that grows into a very large plant **[Matthew 13:31]**.
   b. Starting **small** is no problem to God.
7. Begin believing God today.
   a. Spend time with Him and get to know how He thinks and what He says.
   b. Learn from Him how He sees you, how He sees your spouse, your marriage, and your family.
   c. Write down what He gives you.
   d. Make the scriptures personal.
   e. Begin praying His Word and trust that He is working in your lives.
8. As you begin to see that God's Word is more powerful than any circumstance, you will discover the power of faith!

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Remember

As you seek the Lord, He will show you how He sees your spouse **[Romans 12:2]**. As God gives His vision from His Word, write it down so that you can have it before your eyes **[Habakkuk 2:2,3]**. Then begin to speak God's Word forth for your spouse, confessing what God says to be true **[Isaiah 55:11]**. Meditate day and night on the Word He has given you **[Psalm 1:2; Psalm 119:148]**. The more you have the truth of the Word within you, the less you are going to be swayed by temporary **circumstances**. Then believe God's Word for your spouse **[Jeremiah 1:12]**. Speaking God's Word forth with heart belief is going to change the circumstances **[Mark 11:24]**. Trust God to bring His Word to pass in your own life, the life of your spouse, and in your marriage **[Romans 10:11]**. What God says is more real than the circumstances you see.

Jesus said that if we have faith as a mustard seed, we could move mountains **[Matthew 17:20]**. A mustard seed is a tiny little seed that grows into a very large plant **[Matthew 13:31]**. Starting **small** is no problem to God. Begin believing God today. Spend time with Him and get to know how He thinks and what He says. Learn from Him how He sees you, how He sees your spouse, your marriage, and your family. Write down what He gives you. Make the scriptures personal. Begin praying His Word and trust that He is working in your lives. As you begin to see that God's Word is more powerful than any circumstance, you will discover the power of faith!

PERSONAL EXAMPLES

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Life Application - Let's make it real

1. Ask God to show you how he sees your spouse and your marriage. Remember, this is God's vision for your spouse and your marriage, not what you want them to be. Pray and ask Him to give you scriptures that describe your spouse and your marriage as He sees them. Write them down and pray them daily for each other and for your marriage. Allow the Lord to share with you His excitement over what you are praying for each other.

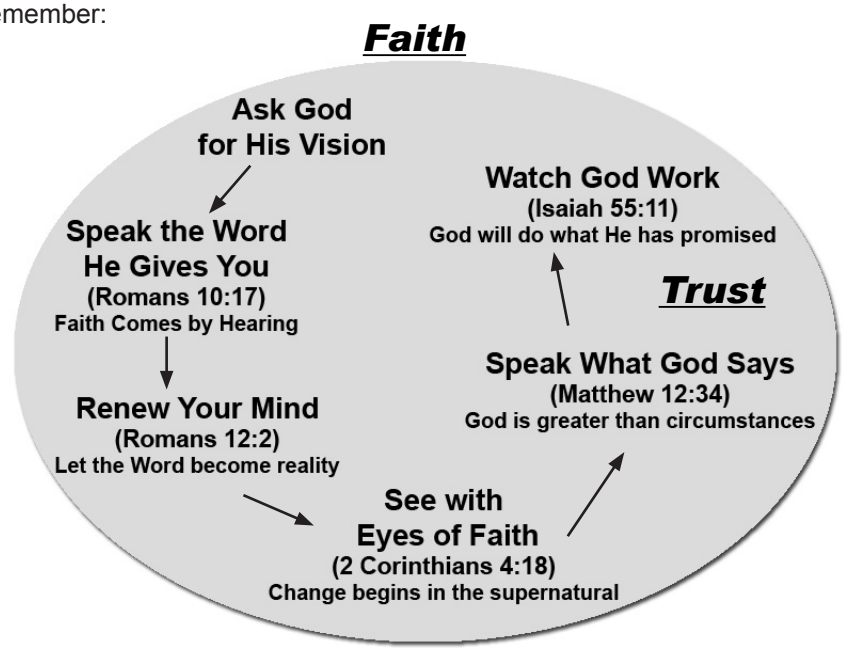
If you are not that familiar with the Word and are not quite sure where to start, there are many "generic" scriptures that speak of God's vision for a godly man and a godly woman. You may wish to use these to get started and then let God begin to fine tune His specific vision for your spouse and marriage.

EXAMPLE: **Psalm 1** is a good description of a godly man. A wife whose husband's name is John may write, *"Blessed is John who does not walk in the counsel of the wicked or stand in the way of sinners or sit in the seat of mockers. But John's delight is in the law of the Lord...etc."*

A man whose wife's name is Mary might state from **Proverbs 31**, *"Mary is worth far more than rubies. I have full confidence in her and I lack nothing of value. She brings me good, not harm, all the days of her life...etc."*

As God gives His vision from His Word, write it down so that you have it before your eyes. **[Habakkuk 2:2,3]** Then speak out what God says about your spouse. **[Isaiah 55:11]** Then meditate day and night on that Word He has given you. **[Psalm 1:2; Psalm 119:148]** The more you have the truth of the Word within you, the less you are going to be swayed by temporary circumstances. Then believe God's Word for your spouse. **[Jeremiah 1:12]** Speaking God's Word with heart belief is going to change the circumstances. **[Mark 11:24]** Trust God to fulfill His promises in your life, the life of your spouse, and in your marriage. **[Romans 10:11]**

Remember:



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HUSBAND

In the following section, write the faith vision you are believing for your wife. Use a concordance or topical index from a study Bible, if necessary, to find scriptures that depict what the Lord desires her to be. (No coaching from the wives. This is his assignment.)

WIFE

In the following section, write the faith vision you are believing for your husband. Use a concordance or a topical index from a study Bible, if necessary, to find scriptures that depict what God desires for him to be. (No coaching from the husbands. This is her assignment.)

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YOUR MARRIAGE

Now the two of you together, write a vision for your marriage, your life together. Ask God what His long- and short-term goals are for you.

DON'T STOP NOW

Ask the Lord to give you a faith vision for each of your family members. Begin praying His word and will for all those you love.

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Week 7

The Power of Spiritual Intimacy

WEEKLY PRAYER FOCUS

When the Coaching Team Meets to Pray

WEEK 7 - THE POWER OF SPIRITUAL INTIMACY

GOAL: For couples to understand why they should pray together, how to pray together, and the necessity for the Baptism of the Holy Spirit.

INSTRUCTION: Be prepared, following the meeting, to lead anyone who requests into the Baptism of the Holy Spirit. Be sensitive as to how the Holy Spirit would minister to each individual, sometimes He will do it publicly and at other times privately. He will lead you. There is a special anointing on ***2=1*** to help people receive their prayer language when they are baptized. We believe this is due to the fact that it is so important for couples to pray together, especially in the spirit. Walk in the might of that anointing as you minister.

PRAYER FOCUS: Continue praying for anyone in your group who still needs to receive the Baptism of the Holy Spirit. Begin seeking the Lord for the upcoming Leaders in Training couple for each group. Continue to pray specifically as the Holy Spirit directs. Pray that as your couples pray together, they will ask the Lord what their part in the financial giving should be.

Coaching Team:

Personal Prayer Needs _____

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Ministry Prayer Needs _____

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Notes from Prayer Time:

Praise Reports:

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WEEKLY COACHING TIPS

A Word About Praying in the Spirit from Mike and Marilyn Phillipps

Several years ago we arranged for the rental of two buses to provide transportation during the annual convention. We soon discovered that to drive a bus required a chauffeur's license. We explained to the officials that our men had excellent driving records and had transported people for us in the past, but that did not change the minds of the officials. They said that if they were going to be transporting people in a public conveyance such as a bus, they had to have a chauffeur's license. They explained that the responsibility of driving a vehicle filled with passengers carried with it different requirements than just driving a car or a van. Since none of our leaders had a chauffeur's license, we had to hire bus drivers that met the requirements stated by law.

When the officials insisted that those who drove the buses had to have a chauffeur's license, were they telling us that our drivers were second-class citizens? Were they saying that our drivers had poor driving records? Were they saying that people with chauffeur's licenses were somehow better than those who did not have them? Of course not. They were simply saying that driving a bus requires training and skills different than those needed to drive a car.

When people job hunt they discover that various jobs carry with them different requirements. Some require a college degree while others require experience in certain fields or with certain equipment. Do these requirements somehow say that those who do not have them are inferior to those who do? Would it be prudent to believe that employers who have certain requirements for hiring are prejudicial or elitist in their requirements? Of course not. The requirements they list, just as the chauffeur's license, are based on the demands of the job. Without meeting the requirements, it would be extremely difficult to meet the demands of the job.

So it is with 2=1 leadership. Throughout the lessons that Coaching Couples teach there are multiple times when couples are encouraged to pray in the spirit. Week Four introduces the concept of praying together in the spirit in a strife break. Week Seven teaches couples the importance of praying together, both in their native language and in the spirit. This lesson introduces the Baptism of the Holy Spirit and tells couples that their coaching couple will pray with them if they would like to receive the Baptism and the gifts, including tongues. Week Eight teaches couples how to come into agreement by praying together in the spirit until they hear the same thing from the Lord.

Each one of these lessons requires leadership to do something they have experienced, not just what they have heard about. It is not enough to have a theoretical understanding. The men who drove the vans no doubt had a theoretical understanding of the concept of driving a bus. That was not enough for the passengers of the bus.

When we require that ***2=1*** leadership be baptized in the Holy Spirit and open to all the gifts, we are not saying they are better than others or that they have better gifts or are better Christians. There are many people who are not baptized in the Holy Spirit who have better marriages than some who are. They may also be much better church members or have sweeter dispositions or greater character development.

Being baptized in the Holy Spirit and being open to all the gifts of the Spirit are a job requirement for ***2=1*** coaches because they need that to teach their class. Both of us received the Baptism of the Holy Spirit without manifesting tongues. We both experienced blockages of different types that kept us from receiving what scripture makes evident comes with the package. We were surrounded by people, though, that knew the Word of God and encouraged us to seek the truth of the Word.

It is important that ***2=1*** coaches be willing to press through with couples, helping them to discover what is blocking the move of God in their lives. This is only possible when the Baptism of the Holy Spirit and the subsequent gift of tongues is not a theoretical concept but a vital part of the coach's daily lives.

We highly recommend the Baptism of the Holy Spirit to everyone in the Body of Christ. It is a powerful tool in our arsenal of weapons, a vehicle of praise, and our "field phone" to our Commander in Chief, Jesus, in the heat of spiritual battle. We believe that every believer should have this gift as a personal benefit and blessing. We more than recommend it, though, for ***2=1*** coaches. For them, it is a job requirement.

A. Emphasis on Together.

1. This is perhaps the most important lesson of the whole Married for Life course.
   a. All the other lessons are like bricks.
   b. This lesson is like the mortar.
2. Many husbands and wives have active separate prayer lives.
   a. We need individual prayer time each day.
   b. Individual prayer is not sufficient for a couple.
3. The only way two can truly experience the spiritual **intimacy** God intends is for both to submit themselves to the guidance and direction of the Holy Spirit by praying together.
   a. It is the most intimate thing a husband and wife can do together.
   b. It is essential to the health of a marriage.
   c. It takes dedication, practice, and consistency for a vibrant one-flesh prayer life.

B. Reasons for Praying Together.

1. Many people seek out a person with whom they pray consistently.
2. Our spouse is to be our most intimate prayer partner **[Matthew 18:20]**.
   a. Our spouse is to be closer to us than anyone else on earth.
   b. Where two or more gather in His name, He is in our midst.
3. We have power of **agreement** **[Matthew 18:19]**.
   a. We need to learn how to move in that power.
   b. Agreeing with God's will brings it to pass on the earth.
   c. There will be more about agreement in next week's lesson.
4. Power in spiritual warfare increases exponentially **[Leviticus 26:8]**.
   a. We have authority in Jesus to tear down strongholds and break satanic holds
   b. *"I use God's mighty weapons, not those made by men, to knock down the devil's strong holds. These weapons can break down every proud argument against finding Him. With these weapons I can capture rebels and bring them back to God and change them into men whose heart's desire is obedience to Christ"* **[2 Corinthians 10:4,5 TLB]**.
   b. As we learn to blend as one in the power of the Spirit, we increase our warfare ability.
   c. We need to *"patrol our hedge"* together as husband and wife **[Job 1:10]**.
   d. There will be more about spiritual warfare in Lesson 10.
   e. As we learn to combine our power and effort, we will find that multiplication of ability of which the scripture speaks.

C. Guidelines for Praying Together.

1. Follow guidelines when praying together.
   a. Should be an intimate time between you, your spouse, and God.
   b. Not a time to **criticize** your spouse's prayers or discuss scriptural validity.
      1) A spouse constantly corrected or reprimanded during prayer time will be reluctant to pray out loud.
      2) If you are guilty of doing this, you need to repent.
      3) Resolve to seek unity in your prayer time together.
      4) Allow God to bring about growth in your spouse's prayer life.

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Emphasis on Together

This is perhaps the most important lesson you will receive in this Married for Life course. If each of the other lessons were thought of as bricks, this lesson would be the mortar. It cannot be emphasized enough how important it is for couples to pray together. Each spouse may have an active prayer life of his or her own, but that is not enough for a couple. It is equally essential that they have consistent prayer time together as one-flesh. Praying together is the only way that two can truly experience the spiritual **intimacy** God intends, as both spouses submit themselves to the guidance and direction of the Holy Spirit.

When husband and wife pray together consistently, they reach a level of intimacy not found anywhere else in marriage. It is even more intimate than their sexual union. The intimacy and nurturing of prayer together is essential for the good health of a marriage. It is this depth of intimacy, in fact, that makes it most difficult for couples to maintain an active joint prayer life. It takes dedication, practice, and consistency to maintain a vibrant one-flesh prayer life.

Reasons for Praying Together

Many people have friends who are their prayer partners, someone they meet with regularly to pray. In our own spouse, though, God has provided an intimate prayer partner for each of us, someone who is intended to be closer to us than anyone else on earth. He has told us that where two or more gather in His name there He is in the midst of us **[Matthew 18:20]**. We need to take advantage, as a couple, of the power we have in **agreement**, learning to bring His will to pass on earth **[Matthew 18:19]**. In next week's lesson we will be covering agreement in detail. It is important that we know how to come into agreement as a couple.

When we pray together we also have been given the power to increase our ability in spiritual warfare exponentially **[Leviticus 26:8]**. We have power praying separately, but using the principles of God's Word and the synergism of one-flesh, together our power is multiplied. As we learn to blend as one in the power of the Spirit, we increase our warfare ability. We have been given authority in Jesus to tear down strongholds and to break satanic holds: *"I use God's mighty weapons, not those made by men, to knock down the devil's strongholds. These weapons can break down every proud argument against finding Him. With these weapons I can capture rebels and bring them back to God and change them into men whose heart's desire is obedience to Christ"* **[2 Corinthians 10:4,5 TLB]**. We need to learn to patrol our hedge together as husband and wife **[Job 1:10]**. Lesson 10 will deal with one-flesh spiritual warfare. As we learn to combine our power and effort, we will find that multiplication of ability of which the scripture speaks.

Guidelines for Praying Together

There are certain guidelines to follow as you set out to blend together in prayer. Praying together should be a beautiful time of intimacy between a couple and God. It is not a time to **criticize** or critique your spouse's prayers. It is not a time to discuss the scriptural validity of prayers. A spouse constantly corrected or reprimanded during prayer time will be reluctant to pray out loud.

Perhaps you have been guilty of doing this in the past. If so, you need to repent and resolve to let God be the One who brings about growth in your spouse after all, it is He to whom your spouse is speaking in prayer, not you. You are privileged to sit in on that special conversation. Treat it with the respect it is due. Allow your joint prayer

PERSONAL EXAMPLES

c. Your attention to spouse's prayer concerns will give you a better understanding of his/her relationship with God.

1) Learn to better understand the heart of your spouse.

2) It is a special privilege to sit in on that conversation with God. Don't abuse it.

Interactive

Have you tried to pray together? How has it gone?

Take a few minutes now and discuss it together as a couple. If you pray together consistently, discuss why you believe that is working for you.

If you have trouble praying together, consider some of the things just mentioned and discuss what you think you might change so that you could pray together more often.

(Time three minutes and then continue with the clas)

2. Together follow Paul's example for prayer: *"I will pray with the spirit, and I will pray with the understanding also"* **[1 Corinthians 14:15 KJV]**.

a. There is a time to pray in the spirit (tongues) and a time to pray with understanding (in our native language).

b. Praying with understanding together.

1) It takes more maturity than praying in the spirit together.

2) There can be a tendency to manipulate or correct.

a) ("Oh, Lord, please help my husband to stop smoking. You know how irritating that is to me - how it congests me and gives me a headache. You know, Lord, how often I've asked him to stop but does He care? If he really loved me, he'd stop,")

b) (Oh, Lord, please help my wife to be a better lover. You know how cold she is to me and how frustrating that has been. You know I've done everything I know to do and it hasn't helped. She says she's trying, but I don't see any real effort on her part. Lord, change her heart.")

c) Sometimes praying with understanding can often carry messages to our partner disguised as requests to God.

3) Another conflict that can arise when we pray with understanding is the **length** of our prayer.

a) One spouse may desire to pray on and on while the other may feel that only a few words are necessary.

b) Many have ended their prayer time in strife and resolved not to attempt it again in the near future.

3. Enter into His presence with praise and worship.

a. Enter into His presence with praise **[Psalm 100:4]**.

b. The Lord inhabits the praises of His people **[Psalm 22:3]**.

c. Praise need not be formalized; just praise Him from your heart.

1) Just begin to praise and worship the Lord from your heart.

2) Allow the Holy Spirit to teach you.

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time to enable you to better understand your spouse's heart. As your spouse shares his or her concerns, you will have greater insight into his or her relationship with the Lord.

Interactive

Have you tried to pray together? How has it gone?

Take a few minutes now and discuss it together as a couple. If you pray together consistently, discuss why you believe that is working for you.

If you have trouble praying together, consider some of the things just mentioned and discuss what you think you might change so that you could pray together more often.

(Time three minutes and then continue with the class)

The Apostle Paul said, *"...I will pray with the spirit, and I will pray with the understanding also"* **[1 Corinthians 14:15 KJV]**. This example is a good one for us to follow in our prayer time. There is a time for us to pray in the spirit (tongues) and a time for us to pray with understanding (in our native language). It is, as a rule, however, much more difficult for a couple to pray together with understanding than to pray together in the spirit. It takes a good deal more spiritual maturity to pray together with understanding and not manipulate or correct each other with the prayer.

"Oh, Lord, please help my husband to stop smoking. You know how irritating that is to me - how it congests me and gives me a headache. You know, Lord, how often I've asked him to stop but does He care? If he really loved me, he'd stop," or "Oh, Lord, please help my wife to be a better lover. You know how cold she is to me and how frustrating that has been. You know I've done everything I know to do and it hasn't helped. She says she's trying, but I don't see any real effort on her part. Lord, change her heart." Sound familiar? Prayer with understanding can often carry messages to our partner disguised as requests to God.

Another conflict that can arise when we pray with understanding is the **length** of our prayer. Sometimes one spouse may desire to pray on and on for a given need while the other spouse feels that a shorter prayer would cover the topic. One may be extremely burdened for a given person or situation and the other may have little or no burden. When we pray with understanding we can often struggle over these issues. Many a couple has ended their prayer time in strife and resolved not to attempt it again in the near future.

When we enter into prayer together as a couple there are some important guidelines to follow that can keep us out of these conflicts. First of all, prayer time should begin with praise and worship of our Lord. The Word tells us to enter into the presence of the Lord with praise **[Psalm 100:4]**, and that the Lord inhabits the praises of His people **[Psalm 22:3]**. Repeatedly throughout scripture we are instructed to praise the Lord. Praise and worship do not need to be a formalized program. We have become conditioned that praise and worship must be led by a team and follow a certain order. Just begin to praise and worship the Lord from your heart and allow the Holy Spirit to teach you. You will be greatly blessed as you enter into His presence. Prayer will flow out of praise.

PERSONAL EXAMPLES

3) Prayer will flow out of praise.

4. Praying with the understanding (your native language).
   a. Use *"Do not fret or have any anxiety about anything, but in every circumstance and in everything by prayer and petition definite requests with thanksgiving continue to make your wants known to God"* **[Philippians 4:6]** as a guide.
      1) Thank God for what He has provided and how He has cared.
      2) Present to Him your needs and desires.
         a) The Word says to present a **petition**.
         b) It is good to write your requests down and keep track of answers to prayer.
      3) When you are praying together, limit prayers to things which concern you as one-flesh.
         a) Use your personal prayer time to cover individual concerns.
         b) Examples: One has a burden for a specific political official. One has a burden for the starving of the world.
      4) Discuss what these things will be before you begin praying.
   b. Pray the **Word** **[1 John 5:14,15]**.
      1) We know we are praying God's will.
      2) It keeps our own opinions out of the prayer.
      3) The Lord watches over His Word **[Jeremiah 1:12 NAS]**; it will not return to Him void **[Isaiah 55:11]**.
   c. Praying the Word is the same as expressing God's faith vision for the person or situation.
5. The Word also tells us to pray in the Spirit (tongues).
   a. One of the most significant things a husband and wife can do for their marriage.
   b. We *"edify and improve"* our one-flesh life **[1 Corinthians 14:4 Amplified]**.
   c. When two become one, it is essential that husband and wife be willing to submit themselves to the guidance and direction of the Holy Spirit.
      1) He is able to blend and direct them into a greater depth of unity and power.
      2) They experience more rapid growth and maturation on the spiritual level (spirit) as a result of their prayer time.
         a) We can experience more rapid spiritual growth (spirit).
         b) It can improve our communication (soul).
         c) It can improve our sexual intimacy (body).
   c. We submit our most unruly member, the **tongue**, to direction of Holy Spirit. **[James 3:8]**
      1) As we submit to Him together, we enable Him to mold us and blend us as He desires **[Romans 8:26-29]**.
      2) We are praying according to the desires of the Spirit, so we are in agreement with God.
      3) When we are in agreement with God, we, therefore, are in agreement with each other.
      4) Praying God's will in agreement brings it to pass in the earth **[Matthew 18:19]**.

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When praying with understanding, follow the instruction of the Apostle Paul, *"Do not fret or have any anxiety about anything, but in every circumstance and in everything by prayer and petition definite requests with thanksgiving continue to make your wants known to God"* **[Phil. 4:6 Amp]**. The Word says to present a **petition**. If you write down your requests, you can date them and then record the answers you receive. This orderly record of your prayer time will greatly encourage you as you see how mighty God has been on your behalf.

It is also very important that prayer with understanding be limited to those things which are of mutual concern to both husband and wife. Individual prayer time should be used for those strictly personal concerns such as countries, causes, or specific people for which God has burdened us to pray. Joint prayer-time should focus on those people or situations that you are interceding for together. Discuss what these things will be before you enter into prayer. It is not difficult to find mutual prayer concerns. Do not concentrate on the ones you are not burdened for together or criticize your spouse for not wanting to pray for what concerns you. Instead, concentrate on the ones you hold in common.

When praying with understanding, it is essential to pray the Word of God for the people and situations **[1 John 5:14,15]**. When we pray the **Word**, know we are praying the will of God and we keep our own opinions out of the prayer time. We will not tend to manipulate or correct if we stick with the Word. We know from scripture that the Lord is *"watching over"* His Word **[Jeremiah 1:12 NAS]** and that the Word *"... shall not return to Him...void"* **[Isaiah 55:11]**. Praying the Word is the same as expressing God's faith vision for the person or situation.

We also are instructed from the Word to pray in the spirit (tongues). We firmly believe that praying together in the spirit is the one most significant thing a husband and wife can do for the benefit of their marriage. We cannot give you chapter and verse on this one, but we have seen the tremendous fruit that has come out of praying together in the spirit in thousands of marriages.

According to **1 Corinthians 14:4**, when one prays in the spirit, he edifies himself. When we pray in the spirit together, we edify our one-flesh life. All three areas of our life together as a couple (spirit, soul, and body) change and improve as we submit our spirits to the leadership of the Holy Spirit. When two become one, it is essential that husband and wife be willing to submit themselves to the guidance and direction of the Holy Spirit. As each spouse submits to Him, He is able to blend and direct them into a greater depth of unity and power. They experience more rapid growth and maturation on the spiritual level (spirit) as a result of their prayer time. Our level of communication (soul) grows deeper and more meaningful as we consistently pray together in the spirit. Because spiritual intimacy is even greater than physical intimacy, our sex life (body) improves as we grow closer in the spirit realm.

There are several reasons for this growth. When we pray together in the spirit (tongues) we are both submitting our most unruly member, our **tongue**, to the direction of the Holy Spirit **[James 3:8]**. As we submit to Him together, we enable Him to mold us and blend us as He desires **[Romans 8:26-29]**. Because we are praying according to the desires of the Spirit, we know we are in agreement with God to see His will brought to pass on the earth. We know that when we are both in agreement with God, we are in agreement with each other. Flowing together in consistent agreement in our prayer time will overflow into the other areas of our relationship. We can be assured that when we are speaking the will of God as one, we will see it come to

PERSONAL EXAMPLES

e. There may be resistance to praying together in tongues because it “sounds funny.”
   1) Get over the embarrassment and into the fullness of God’s plan for you.
   2) Pray in your prayer language frequently so that you become freer in it.
   3) What better place to relax and become free than praying together in the privacy of your own home.

6. As a couple, make **appointment** daily with Jesus and keep it diligently.
   a. Honor that appointment with the same commitment as any other appointment..
   b. The enemy hates for couples to pray together and will use every trick to keep us from doing it.
   b. Don’t just talk about it, think about it, or discuss it - DO IT!
7. It is going to take dedication to establish this new practice.
   a. Even couples hurting too much to talk can pray together in the spirit and get their marriage healed.
   b. One-flesh growth flows out of the strength of prayer time together.
8. The Baptism or Infilling of the Holy Spirit.
   a. In order to pray in the spirit, we must receive tongues from the Holy Spirit.
   b. The Word of God is clear regarding God’s desire.
   c. If you have not received this gift or if you are not freely praying in tongues, take advantage of God’s offer to you.
   d. If you are not aware of what we are talking about or if your church teaches that all of this is not for today, please consider the following from the Word of God.

(Please present the rest of this lesson by reading the following text. Be sensitive to the Holy Spirit’s direction. There may be some in your group that are ready to receive right away. Others may need to be ministered to individually. Follow the guidance of the Spirit.)

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pass **[Matthew 18:19]**. Perhaps one of the biggest blocks to a couple praying together in tongues is that they think it "sounds funny." We all need to get over that embarrassment and into the fullness of God's plan for us.

You need to be free in your prayer language and be comfortable using it. The more often you use it, the freer you will become. What better place to relax and become free than praying together in the privacy of your own home. Make an **appointment** daily to meet with Jesus and pray as a couple. Honor that appointment with the same commitment you would honor any other appointment. The enemy hates for couples to pray together. He will do anything to keep us from coming together in prayer. Don't fall for his tricks. Don't just talk about it, think about it, or discuss it, just DO IT!

It is going to take dedication to establish this new practice. Couples who are hurting too much to even speak to each other can pray together in the spirit and receive healing in their marriage. It is important to remember that much of our one-flesh growth flows out of our prayer time together as a couple.

In order that we may pray in the spirit, we must be free in the use of the tongues the Lord has given us. This gift is received with the infilling of the Holy Spirit and the Word of God is very clear regarding His desire for us in this matter. If you have not received this gift or if you are not freely praying in tongues, take advantage of God's offer to you. If you are not aware of what we are talking about or if your church teaches that all of this is not for today, please consider the following from the Word of God.

(Please present the rest of this lesson by reading the following text. Be sensitive to the Holy Spirit's direction. There may be some in your group that are ready to receive right away. Others may need to be ministered to individually. Follow the guidance of the Spirit.)

PERSONAL EXAMPLES

A SCRIPTURAL STUDY OF THE BASIS FOR THE BAPTISM OF THE HOLY SPIRIT.

Before His ascension into Heaven, Jesus told His disciples to wait in Jerusalem until they were baptized with the Holy Spirit **[Acts 1:4,5]**. Those to whom He was speaking had been born again when he came to them after His death and resurrection **[John 20:22]**. It was obvious from what Jesus was telling them in the first chapter of Acts, though, that there was another, separate experience available to them. In **Acts 1:8**, Jesus promised them that they would receive power and become His witnesses to the ends of the earth. All of those who gathered to hear Jesus loved Him very much and had chosen to follow Him but they lacked courage and boldness. All of them had deserted Him when He was crucified with the exception of John and the women. Peter had even denied knowing Him. They obviously needed the power that it would take to live out their commitment to Him.

In **Acts chapter 2**, all of the disciples were gathered in one place. Even Mary, the mother of Jesus was there. The Holy Spirit came upon them and they were filled with power. The first outward manifestation of this infilling was that they all began to speak in tongues as the Spirit enabled them **[Acts 2:4]**. These tongues were understood by people from all nations who were in Jerusalem for the feast of Pentecost. This speaking all together in tongues gave the disciples tremendous unity and power such as had not been seen on the earth since God confused the languages at the tower of Babel **[Genesis 11:6-9]**. When we speak as one and have one heart and purpose, there is power. Speaking in tongues provided for them (and for us) that unity they had not previously had. It enabled them, and now us, to come together with believers from all over the world, speaking different natural languages but speaking together in the spirit.

The second manifestation of the Baptism was the boldness with which the disciples began to proclaim the Gospel. These same people who had previously been so afraid and timid were now drawing large crowds with their preaching. They were suddenly not concerned with what the crowds thought of them or if they were in danger. They had received the power necessary to live the Christian life.

Be assured that Satan knows the power of this experience. He has done much down through the ages to discredit it. In some churches he has even convinced them to give him the credit for the outward manifestations of the Baptism of the Holy Spirit, tongues in particular. He has gotten many people to overlook the experience and to even scoff at it, much to their loss. Without the Baptism of the Holy Spirit, we are very limited in what we can accomplish. We are not "plugged in" to the vital source of supernatural power that the Holy Spirit offers.

The Baptism or the Infilling of the Holy Spirit was not a one-time experience in the history of the church. Throughout the book of Acts, the same experience with the same manifestations occurred over and over again **[Acts 8, Acts 10, Acts 19]**. The first-century church moved in the spirit in a way that we often covet. Yet this same measure of power and authority is available to the church today if we would only receive it. If the Body of Christ were united today in the Holy Spirit power in which the first-century church moved, we would see victory and glory that we only dream of now. We can, however, begin in our home. In each of our lives this power is available the same way it was available to each disciple on the day of Pentecost. We only need to reach out and take it.

In **Luke 11:11-13**, Jesus tells us that if we who are earthly know how to give our children good things, how much more then will the Father in Heaven give the Holy Spirit to those who ask Him. We know then that we must ask to receive. James tells us that we have not because we ask not **[James 4:2]**. The Baptism of the Holy Spirit is available to anyone who has asked Jesus to be their Lord and Savior. We need only ask to be baptized in the Holy Spirit and He baptizes us. We can ask Him all by ourselves or we can ask other Spirit-filled Christians to lay hands on us and pray with us **[Acts 8:17; Acts 19:6]**. Know that when we ask, we receive. Take that promise and receive all that the Holy Spirit has for you.

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The tongues that we receive with the Baptism of the Holy Spirit is our own prayer language, not the Gift of Tongues. The Gift of Tongues, one of the nine gifts of the Holy Spirit, is what Paul was talking about in **1 Corinthians 14:5,13,22,23**. Scripture tells us that this gift must function in conjunction with the Gift of Interpretation to supernaturally deliver a word from God to the hearers **[1 Corinthians 14:27,28]**. The prayer language of tongues is what Paul was talking about in **1 Corinthians 14:4,14,15,18,19**. This is your personal prayer language which does not require interpretation **[Romans 8:26,27]**. If you do not understand the difference, please continue to study the scriptures and/or ask your leaders for help.

Be open for every gift God has for you. If tongues do not manifest readily when you receive the Baptism of the Holy Spirit, don't decide that God does not want you to have that gift. Instead ask the Lord what is blocking your gift. It may simply be an intellectual argument or just embarrassment. It may, however, be something more serious such as previous involvement in occult activities (e.g. horoscopes, Ouija boards, automatic writing, etc.). When tongues do not manifest, we need to ask the Holy Spirit for discernment regarding the blockage.

We need, however, to be cautious that we remain in the spirit in our attempts to receive and not enter into fleshly activities. Tongues do not have to be forced. If they are being blocked, we need only discern the blockage and remove it. They will then readily flow. We do not have to repeat after someone else or move our head or tongues a certain way. Just surrender your tongue to Him to speak through you and He will do it.

That does not mean that you don't make a sound and that God will supernaturally take over your speech. Very often you will become aware of words that are unfamiliar to you and you will tell yourself that they are nonsense. Take a step of faith and speak them out. Once you have been obedient in surrendering your tongue, the Holy Spirit will begin supplying you with a whole new, beautiful language. Begin using that language to praise God and to tell Him of your love for Him. As you use your language daily you will begin to see it increase. That increase and frequent usage will bring you to Paul's desire to "pray in the Spirit on all occasions" **[Ephesians 6:18 NIV]**.

Tongues are not the only gift or even the most important gift that God has for you. We emphasis it here because your prayer language is such a vital part of an active prayer life. There are so many times when we do not know how to pray or when our own opinion is clouding our ability to freely hear from God. We need the Holy Spirit to pray a powerful prayer through us, a prayer that is God's perfect will for the situation. Our body has a voice and our spirit has one as well. Praying in the spirit allows our spirit to freely speak what God is saying.

Life Application - Let's make it real

It is going to take consistency and discipline to develop your prayer life together as husband and wife. This week is the best time to start. As was shared in the lesson, don't just talk about it, just DO IT!

If you have never prayed together before, it may be like learning to ride a bicycle; trying to do two things at the same time. Be patient with yourselves and allow the Holy Spirit to guide you into one activity together. Pick a time daily to pray together. At first, don't be concerned about how much time you spend praying, only that you do it together. Keep a record of what you've prayed about. The enemy knows the power in what you are doing and he's going to do everything he can to discourage and delay your praying. Don't give up - make an appointment daily and discipline yourselves to keep it.

Remember to spend quality time praying in the spirit together. This knits you as one and edifies your one-flesh life. When praying in your native language, be sure to pray the Word of God for the people and situations for which you are praying. If you are having difficulty getting started, remember it takes more maturity to pray in your native language together, so start by praying in the spirit. Take time during your prayer time together to share with each other what God is saying to you individually. Let this be a special time of communication with God and each other.

If you already have a prayer time together, use this as a time to allow the Lord to deepen and strengthen it.

If you do not already have a prayer journal, you might consider using the following one. There is a section to record what you pray for each day and what the Lord says when He speaks to you. Following that is a section to record scriptures you are praying. There is also a section to record any special instructions or insights that you received while praying - any "new light" shed on those things for which you are praying. Finally, there is a section in which to record the answers you receive to prayer. We have included two pages here. If you like this format, make copies of a page and continue on with it. You may prefer to use another one or make up one of your own - just use some consistent way to keep a journal of your prayer time together.

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DATE _____

PRAYER TOPICS

WORDS RECEIVED FROM THE LORD

SCRIPTURES PRAYED

INSTRUCTIONS RECEIVED OR INSIGHT GAINED

ANSWERED PRAYER

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DATE _____

PRAYER TOPICS

WORDS RECEIVED FROM THE LORD

SCRIPTURES PRAYED

INSTRUCTIONS RECEIVED OR INSIGHT GAINED

ANSWERED PRAYER

© 2=1 ~ Discover the Power

DATE _____

PRAYER TOPICS

WORDS RECEIVED FROM THE LORD

SCRIPTURES PRAYED

INSTRUCTIONS RECEIVED OR INSIGHT GAINED

ANSWERED PRAYER

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Have you received the Baptism or the Infilling of the Holy Spirit? If not, there's no better time than the present to receive all that God has for you. If you want to be baptized by Jesus in the Holy Spirit, pray the following prayer.

"Lord Jesus, I want all that You have for me. I want to surrender all to You. Please baptize me in the Holy Spirit right now. I receive it. Thank you."

With both of you baptized in the Holy Spirit, you can pray with your understanding in your native language and in the spirit in tongues. Sometimes we don't know how to pray or what we should say. *"In the same way, the Spirit helps us in our weakness. We do not know what we ought to pray, but the Spirit Himself intercedes for us with groans that words cannot express"* **[Romans 8:26 NIV]**.

It is at times such as these that we need to pray in the spirit for He knows how to pray a perfect prayer, always in the will of God. Begin praying both ways in your daily prayer time together. Remember that praying in the spirit also edifies **[1 Corinthians 14:4]**.

If you received the Baptism of the Holy Spirit this week, do the same as you did when you were born again. Write the date below and sign your name. It is established for all eternity!

_____
DATE

_____
HUSBAND

_____
WIFE

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Week 8

The Power of Agreement

WEEKLY PRAYER FOCUS

When the Coaching Team Meets to Pray

WEEK 8 - THE POWER OF AGREEMENT

GOAL: To realize the reason we are called to agree, to learn what agreement God's way means, and to learn how to come into agreement God's way.

INSTRUCTION: During discussion follow up on those who may have been baptized in the Holy Spirit during the week. Be prepared in the Spirit to handle any doctrinal disagreements according to the instructions at the end of Lesson 7. Following the meeting, help free up those who need a more fluent prayer language.

PRAYER FOCUS: Keep up intercession for couples. The Holy Spirit is working in some areas now that He has never had access to before. Don't let up—press in for your couples. Pray that they will come into agreement concerning their weekly financial giving.

Coaching Team:

Personal Prayer Needs _____
_____
_____
_____
_____

Ministry Prayer Needs _____
_____
_____
_____
_____
_____

Notes from Prayer Time:

Praise Reports:

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WEEKLY COACHING TIPS

RESPONSIBILITIES OF MFL COACHES

To the Couples in Your Class

- ❑ Pray with your Coaches in Training for all the couples in the class, doing spiritual warfare for them and agreeing with the Lord's faith vision for each of them.
- ❑ Encourage the couples in your class and coach them through difficult areas.
- ❑ Remember, you not only teach, but model as well. It is process, not perfection.
- ❑ Make sure each couple in your class understands the importance of participating every week.
- ❑ Give vision to each couple that God has a plan for their marriage and help them learn what it is.
- ❑ Answer their questions honestly and seek help with answers you don't know.
- ❑ Relax and be real.

To Your Coaches in Training

- ❑ Encourage your Coaches in Training in their own marriage as well as in their coaching role.
- ❑ Teach all Married for Life lessons to the class with the exception of the ones you delegate as part of training. Go over the delegated lesson with your Coaches in Training before they teach, if they have not heard them before.
- ❑ Make sure they have completed all phases of coaching preparation - the three videos (Core Values, Maintaining Your Lighthouse, and Understanding Authority), the Joshua Bible Study, and have read the ***2=1*** coaching book.
- ❑ Pray with them for the two couples you will need to multiply into two new classes.
- ❑ Attend ***2=1*** impact meetings together.

Remember, your home is your point of outreach to your neighborhood, your friends and family, and your community. The more you are willing to allow God to flow through you with His power, the more miracles you will see in your own home.

RESPONSIBILITIES OF MFL COACHES IN TRAINING

To the Couples in Your Class

- ❑ You are in training during this class, so learn as much as you can in the weeks of the course.
- ❑ Support and assist your Coaching Couple in prayer and during the meeting.
- ❑ Teach at least two lessons that will be assigned to you.
- ❑ Lead the interactive time weekly, setting the pace with your own transparency.

To Your Coaching Couple

- ❑ Assist the Coaching Couple as requested.
- ❑ Meet each week with them for prayer and study.
- ❑ If you disagree with your Coaching Couple, please discuss it with them in private, not in front of the group..
- ❑ Assist the Coaching Couple in completing paperwork immediately after each meeting.
- ❑ Attend ***2=1*** impact meetings together.

This is the time for you to prepare to be a Coaching Couple. Observe, listen, and take advice and correction with an open heart. Make the most of the weeks you have together. During this time be thinking about how God will use your home as a point of outreach to others. Prepare and learn now and be ready to step out and teach your own MFL home group when this class is over.

A. God Intends for Us to Walk in Agreement in Our Marriage.

1. *"Can two walk together, unless they are agreed?"* **[Amos 3:3 NKJV]**.
2. Couples are often told **not** to walk together if they are not in agreement.
   a. Separation or divorce are erroneously recommended.
   b. One spouse is wrongly told to "go on in ministry" and leave other behind.
3. Because it is God's desire for us to walk together, we need to learn how to come into agreement.
   a. He has made us one **[Genesis 2:24; Matthew 19:5; Ephesians 5:31]**.
   b. What He has joined is not to be separated **[Malachi 2:16; Matthew 19:6]**.

B. Various Ways Couples Reach Agreement.

1. Lack of Strife.
   a. They reach a decision without arguing.
   b. They consider the alternatives and pick the best one.
2. Expert Opinion.
   a. The spouse with most experience or knowledge gives expert advice.
   b. The couple agrees to go with the expert's decision.
3. Compromise.
   a. Each spouse presents his or her own opinion or desire.
   b. They reach a compromise answer halfway between the two extremes.
4. Survival of the Fittest.
   a. Both spouses are convinced their opinion is the correct answer.
   b. They battle the decision out until one weakens.
   c. Whichever one lasts the longest wins.
5. Manipulation.
   a. "If you do it my way, I'll give you ..." (money, sex, a night on the town, etc.).
   b. One spouse forces the other to agree by offering or refusing certain favors.
6. Logic vs. Emotion.
   a. One spouse is better at logical argument while the other spouse better at an emotional one.
   b. The decision goes in favor of the one who performs best.
7. Default.
   a. One spouse feels strongly about the subject/other spouse doesn't care.
   b. The decision is made by the one who feels strongest/other one just passes.
8. Open Door/Closed Door.
   a. This is a favorite among Christians.
   b. If the "door is open," the decision is "yes."
   c. If the "door is closed," the decision is "no."
9. **None** of these are agreement God's way.

   "You want something but don't get it. You kill and covet, but you cannot have what you want. You quarrel and fight. You do not have, because you do not ask God. When you ask, you do not receive because you ask with wrong motives, that you may spend what you get on your pleasures" **[James 4:2,3]**.

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God Intends for Us to Walk in Agreement in Our Marriage

Amos 3:3 asks the question, *"Can two walk together except they be agreed?"* Agreement is essential in a relationship that desires to move as one. Worldly advice for troubled marriages, however, says that if we cannot come into agreement we should **not** walk together. Many times separation and divorce are recommended to a couple who seems to be in constant disagreement. Often even the Christian community will recommend that one spouse "go on in ministry" and leave the other one behind if they feel their spiritual progress is being slowed. God has expressed His desire in His Word, though, that we walk together as one. Three times His Word tells us that we have been made one **[Genesis 2:24; Matthew 19:5; Ephesians 5:31]**. He has told us explicitly that He hates to have separated that which He has made into one **[Malachi 2:16; Matthew 19:6]**. Knowing then that it is God's will for us to walk together, we need to learn how to come into agreement in that walk.

Various Ways Couples Reach Agreement

Most problems with agreement arise from the manner in which a couple attempts to reach that agreement. See if you recognize any of the following. First of all, there is the lack of strife approach. Using this method a couple calmly considers all the alternatives and reaches agreement without any argument. Then there's the expert opinion way of agreeing. One spouse has more experience or knowledge regarding the topic under discussion so the other spouse goes along with him or her in agreement. When couples have extremely differing views on a topic, they often enter into compromise agreement. Using this method the couple meets half way between their differing opinions and enters into a mutually satisfying compromise. Often, though, couples don't even attempt to negotiate. They simply fight out their differing opinions until one of them gives in. The one left standing gets their way - survival of the fittest. If a spouse has discovered they can't win that way, however, they may attempt to get the other spouse to agree with them by manipulation. In other words, "If you do it my way, I'll give you..." (money, sex, or whatever is valued). The other spouse must agree in order to get the reward. Emotion versus logic is another way for a couple to struggle to agreement. One spouse may be better at a logical presentation of their view, while the other may excel at an emotional presentation. The couple agrees on whichever view is presented best.

These methods of agreement all assume that the issue at hand is important to both spouses. Sometimes, however, one spouse doesn't care what decision is made. In that case the spouse with the opinion makes the decision and the other spouse agrees out of lack of interest. Finally, there is a method of agreement that is very popular with Christians. It is the open door/closed door method. The couple faces the issue on which they need to agree believing that if the door is open, the answer is "yes." If the door is closed, the answer is "no." One of the biggest problems with this method occurs when an open door suddenly closes. The couple doesn't know if the Lord closed it or if the enemy closed it. Do they consider the closed door a "no" or do they battle the enemy to reopen the door? And if a closed door suddenly opens, is the Lord saying, "It's okay now" or is the enemy drawing them into a trap? Open door/closed door is a very difficult way to know the will of God.

In fact, **none** of these methods of coming into agreement are agreement as God intends it to be. **James 4:2,3** makes very clear what is achieved in this manner: *"You want something but don't get it. You kill and covet, but you cannot have what you want. You*

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10. Without agreement as husband and wife, there is lack of **peace [James 3:16]**.
    a. This opens the door to enemy attack.
    b. It often keeps us out of God's will.
    c. It leads to blaming each other for failures.
        1) "I told you so."
        2) "You always think you're right."

Interactive

How many of these methods have you used to come into agreement? Take a few minutes and discuss what methods you have used and what the results have been.

(Time three minutes and then continue the class)

C. Agreement God's Way.

1. *"Again I tell you, if two of you on earth agree [harmonize together, together make a symphony] about anything and everything, whatever they shall ask, it will come to pass and be done for them by My Father in heaven"* **[Matthew 18:19 Amplified]**.
    a. We are to blend together in agreement like a symphony.
        1) Harmonize means to simultaneously combine tones.
        2) This is blending together as we are, not becoming the same as each other.
    b. God will do the blending if we allow Him the freedom.
2. Our goal in coming into agreement should be to fulfill the **will** of our Father.
    a. Jesus set the example.
    b. Jesus always sought to fulfill the will of His Father.
        1) *"...I do not seek My own will but the will of the Father who sent Me"* **[John 5:30 NKJV]**.
        2) *"My food is to do the will of Him who sent Me, and to finish His work"* **[John 4:34]**.
    c. Our agreement must also be based on fulfilling the will of our Father.
        1) The Father has a will for everything we do.
        2) We are not to seek to fulfill our own will.
    d. Agreement based on the will of our Father, assures we will see the answer come to pass.
        1) **1 John 5:14,15 NIV**.
        2) **Matthew 18:19 [Amplified]**.

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quarrel and fight. You do not have, because you do not ask God. When you ask, you do not receive because you ask with wrong motives, that you may spend what you get on your pleasures".

If we are not walking in agreement, there will be a lack of **peace** in our home **[James 3:16]**. Disagreement opens the door to enemy attack and often keeps us out of God's perfect will for us. Decision-making on the part of one spouse without the agreement of the other leads to blame when the decision proves wrong. "I told you so" or "you always think you're right" are often heard following the failure of an important decision.

Interactive

How many of these methods have you used to come into agreement? Take a few minutes and discuss what methods you have used and what the results have been.

(Time three minutes and then continue the class)

Agreement God's Way

Matthew 18:19 describes the value of agreement. *"Again I tell you, if two of you on earth agree [harmonize together, together make a symphony] about anything and everything, whatever they shall ask, it will come to pass and be done for them by My Father in heaven"* [Amplified].

Matthew 18:19 speaks of harmonizing, making a symphony. To harmonize means to simultaneously combine tones. In a symphony orchestra there are many instruments, each making a unique sound. The goal of the symphony is not to make them all alike but to blend their uniqueness into one beautiful sound. Clearly God's plan for agreement is different than ours, but how do we reach agreement His way?

First of all, our goal in coming into agreement should always be to fulfill the **will** of our Father. How do we know that? Jesus set the example for us when He lived His earthly life. He always sought to fulfill the will of His Father: *"...I do not seek My own will but the will of the Father who sent Me"* **[John 5:30 NKJV]**; and *"My food is to do the will of Him who sent Me, and to finish His work."* **[John 4:34]** Our Father has a will for everything we, His children, do. We need to learn to begin seeking His will in all things instead of pursuing our own will. We also have assurance from scripture that agreement based on the will of God will come to pass: *"This is the assurance we have in approaching God: that if we ask anything according to His will, He hears us. And if we know that he hears us-whatever we ask-we know that we have what we asked of him"* **[1 John 5:14,15 NIV]**; and *"...whatever they shall ask, it will come to pass and be done for them by My Father in heaven"* **[Matthew 18:19 Amplified]**.

How To Know The Will of God

That sounds simple, but how do we know the will of God? There are many things that we do not have to question. If He has stated it expressly in His Word, we know it is His will for us. For instance, we do not have to ask Him if He wants us to witness and lead others to Him. His Word tells us that is so **[Mark 16:15; Matt. 28:19; Acts 1:8]**. Nor do we need to seek His will regarding raising our children in a godly

PERSONAL EXAMPLES

D. How To Know The Will of God.

1. The Word.
   a. We do not have to ask if it is expressly written in the Word.
      1) Word tells us we are to evangelize, we do not have to ask **[Mark 16:15; Matthew 28:19; Acts 1:8]**.
      2) Word tells us we are to rear our children in a godly manner, we do not have to ask **[Deuteronomy 11:19; Isaiah 54:13; Titus 1:6]**.
      3) Word tells us we are to belong to a local body of believers, we do not have to ask **[Hebrews 10:25; Acts 2:42,46]**.
   b. God's will for us is expressed in His Word to us.
   c. We need to know His Word to know His will.
   d. Word often does not say how, when, where.
2. Specifics regarding God's will, however, cannot always be found in a chapter and verse of the Bible, such as:
   a. Where and how should we evangelize.
   b. How should we handle a specific situation with one of our children.
   c. What church should we join.
   d. Any other matter for which we cannot find specific guidance in scripture.

E. When God's Will Cannot be Found Specifically in the Word.

1. Ask **together** *"...whatever they shall ask..."* **[Matthew 18:19]**.
   a. It is not enough for one to hear from God and the other go along with it. **[Deuteronomy 19:15b]**..
   b. We can have confidence that God will answer **[Isaiah 30:21, John 10.3]**.
   c. God desires each spouse know Him and hear Him **[John 10:14]**.
   d. For agreement, both spouses must hear from God **[Amos 3:3]**.

2. Pray together in the spirit to seek God's will.
   a. When we pray in the spirit (tongues), we are praying the perfect will of God **[Romans 8:27]**.
   b. When we pray in the spirit (tongues), our minds are **unfruitful** **[1 Corinthians 14:14]**.
      1) We want to keep our own opinions out of our prayer **[Proverbs 3:5,6]**.
      2) We want the will of God, not our will **[Isaiah 55:9]**.

3. Share with each other what God has said to you.
   a. When God is speaking, both spouses will receive the same answer.
      1) God is not a God of confusion **[1 Corinthians 14:33]**.
      2) God does not want us to be double-minded **[James 1:8]**.
   b. If the answers not the same, one or both is not hearing correctly.
      1) One of you may have God's answer, or
      2) God may have an entirely different answer than either one of you have.
      3) Very often at first we hear our own desires in the matter.

4. If answers differ, return to **praying** in the spirit and seeking God's will.
   a. Do not pray that your spouse will "come around" and see things your way.

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manner for His Word is also very specific on this issue **[Deuteronomy 11:19; Isaiah 54:13; Titus 1:6]**. The Word also tells us to belong to a local body of believers **[Hebrews 10:25; Acts 2:42, 46]**, so there is no need to ask God if we should join a fellowship or church.

When God's Will Cannot be Found Specifically in the Word

However, specifics regarding each of these issues cannot usually be found in Biblical chapter and verse. For instance, where and how should we evangelize? How do we deal with this specific problem involving our children? What church should we join? What school should our children attend? Should we sell our home? What job should I take? We need to know how to seek God's will for these types of situations in our lives. It is not enough to think this choice looks better or that choice seems wiser. God has His specific will for each situation and we need to know how to discern it.

When we as a couple seek the will of God regarding a situation, we need to ask Him **together**. **Matthew 18:19** says, *"whatever they shall ask."* It is not enough for one spouse to seek God and hear, and the other to go along with the decision. God has given us a safeguard in both spouses hearing and confirming. In order for a couple to agree (harmonize) concerning God's will for a situation, both must hear from God. It is not enough for one spouse to hear and the other to go along with it **[Deut. 19:15b]**. God tells us in His Word that it is possible for each one to hear from Him **[Isaiah 30:21; John 10:3]**. Do not be deceived that only one of you can hear from God. It is His desire that each one knows Him and hears Him **[John 10:14]**. For agreement, both spouses must hear from God **[Amos 3:3]**.

As we seek the Lord, we want to keep our own opinion out of the prayer, so we should both go to our Father asking Him for His will for the situation. We do not want our will, we want His. When we pray with our understanding (in native language) we tend to pursue our own direction. This is especially true if we have strong feelings or opinions about a matter. It is imperative, therefore, that we seek the will of the Father by praying together in the spirit. When we pray in the spirit (in tongues) we are assured that the Holy Spirit is praying the perfect will of God **[Romans 8:27]**. We know also that when we pray in the spirit (in tongues), our minds are **unfruitful** **[1 Corinthians 14:14]**. Praying in the spirit will keep our own opinion out of the prayer **[Proverbs 3:5,6]**, and we will obtain God's will, not our own **[Isaiah 55:9]**.

When both spouses believe they have received an answer from God, answers should be compared. When God is speaking both will have the same answer. God is not a God of confusion **[1 Corinthians 14:33]**. He is not going to give two different answers, causing us to become double-minded as a couple **[James 1:8]**. If the answers we believe we have received are not the same, one of us may have heard from God, but there is a possibility that God has an entirely different plan and we both have missed it. There are no "right" or "wrong" answers when we share together. Very often, at first, we are still hearing only our own opinions. It takes time to pray through to God's answer. When the answers differ, we should return to **praying** in the spirit, seeking God's will. It is not a time to pray that our spouse will "come around" and see things our way. We are praying for God's will to be revealed to both of us. We may be the one who is not hearing correctly.

Continue to compare answers and return to prayer until both spouses are hearing the same answer. When much time has been invested in prayer and our will has become secondary, we can be confident that we are both hearing from God **[Luke 11:10]**.

1) Our pride often keeps us from admitting we could be wrong.
2) Past experiences should teach us that we are not always right even when we think we are.

b. Pray for God's will to be revealed to both of you.

5. When both spouses have received the same answer, you can be confident that you have heard from God **[Luke 11:10]**.
   a. Agreement reached in this manner is led of the Spirit of God, not our own flesh.
   b. There is peace in the answer when both have received **[James 3:17]**.
   c. One final confirmation—if the decision reached has a consequence directly opposing the Word of God, it is not from God.
      1) Any answer received must line up with the Word of God.
      2) The Spirit and the Word always confirm each other.
      3) More time we spend in the Word of God, the more our minds are transformed to quickly know His will **[Romans 12:2]**.
   d. ***The time it takes to come into agreement this way is far less than time it takes to unravel a wrong decision.***
6. Husband, in your role of headship, declare that as a couple you will not move without agreement.
   a. This does not deny your role of headship **[Ephesians 5:23]**.
      1) As husband, you are still responsible to God.
      2) This provides added counsel and confirmation.
         a) **Proverbs 11:14; Proverbs 15:22 (Amplified)**
         b) Even the Word must confirm itself. (Cannot take one isolated scripture.)
   b. Do not allow **circumstances** imposed on you to pressure or sway you as you seek God's heart.
      1) God knows your time frame and will give answer in His timing.
      2) If a couple is willing to take action without agreement, the enemy will delay the answer.
         a) Deadlines are not deadlines unless God says they are.
         b) The enemy delayed the answer to Daniel for 21 days **[Daniel 10]**.
   c. Refuse second best; always go for true, heartfelt agreement given by the Spirit of God.

F. Bringing God's Will to Pass on the Earth.

1. Jesus taught us to pray, *"...Thy will be done on earth as it is in heaven."*
2. *"...it will come to pass and be done for them by my Father in Heaven"* **[Matthew 18:19]**.
   a. Waiting to make sure you have God's will makes it possible to proceed in **confidence**.
   b. Agreement with the will of God enables His will to come to pass on the earth.
3. A couple consistently seeking agreement in this manner will begin to focus on the will of God as a way of life.
4. Seeing God's will come to pass on this earth will be another way discover the power.

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Agreement reached this way is led of the Spirit of God, not our own flesh. Both spouses will have peace regarding the answer. **[James 3:17]**. One final confirming check: answers received from God should always line up with the Word of God. The Spirit and the Word always confirm each other. Any consequence of a decision that does not line up with the Word should be a clue to us that we have heard incorrectly. Of course, the more we are in the Word, the more our minds will be transformed and the quicker we will recognize His will **[Romans 12:2]**. This process of agreement may take several prayer sessions and a prolonged period of time, but ***it takes far less time to come into genuine agreement than it takes to unravel the consequences of a wrong decision.***

The husband, in his role of headship, must declare that he and his wife will not take any action on a matter without genuine, heartfelt agreement. This does not deny the headship of the husband **[Ephesians 5:23]**. It enhances it with the added dimension of counsel and confirmation **[Proverbs 11:14, Proverbs 15:22 Amplified]**. After all, even the Word must confirm itself. We cannot take one isolated scripture and build a case on it if we cannot find confirming scriptures elsewhere. Why should we then think that we as humans need no confirmation? The husband is still responsible to God for the direction his family takes. By achieving agreement this way, however, he also has the protection of confirming prayer. Do not allow **circumstances** imposed from outside your relationship to pressure or sway you from seeking God's perfect will for you. God knows your time frame and will give you the answer in His timing. Do not allow deadlines set by man to be your criteria for decision. If, by your own admission, you are willing to proceed without agreement, the enemy will delay the answer the same way he did with Daniel **[Daniel 10]**. No deadline is a deadline unless God says it is. Refuse second best. Always go for true, heartfelt agreement given by the Spirit of God.

Bringing God's Will to Pass on the Earth

The greatest benefit of agreement achieved in this manner, though, is seeing the will of God come to pass on the earth. Jesus taught us to pray, *"...Thy will be done on earth as it is in heaven."* **Matthew 18:19** concludes with, *"...it will come to pass and be done for them by my Father in heaven."*

When we have prayed and waited on the Lord and can confirm the answer we have received with that which our spouse has received, we can proceed with **confidence** knowing we have the will of God. When we agree according to His will, we know that He will bring it to pass.

As we consistently seek agreement in this manner, we will begin to focus on the will of God as a way of life. What God desires in every area of our life will become our chief concern. Seeing God's will come to pass on this earth will become another way that we discover the power.

PERSONAL EXAMPLES

Life Application - Let's make it real

1. Identify some way that you as a couple have used to come into agreement in the past.

2. What have been the results of these methods?

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3. Consider a matter that you need to come into agreement about right now. What does the Word of God say concerning it?

If you can't find anything specific concerning it in the Word, begin praying together in the spirit to seek God's will for the situation. Remember that you must lay down all preconceived notions of what the "correct" answer is and pray in the spirit until you have the same answer from the Holy Spirit. This may take several times of prayer before you come to the point of both of you hearing the same thing. Do not become discouraged. It is well worth the time it takes to proceed in the perfect will of God.

SUBJECT WHICH REQUIRES AGREEMENT_____

DATE PRAYER BEGAN _____

FINAL ANSWER RECEIVED BY BOTH HUSBAND AND WIFE IN AGREEMENT WITH THE LORD _____
_____

DATE FINAL ANSWER RECEIVED _____

RESULTS _____
_____
_____
_____
_____

When you have reached agreement on the first topic, move on to others. What else do you desire to know God's perfect will concerning? Remember, always seek God's will together. Do not assume that one has heard from God and just "go along with it." The enemy has no power against your decision-making as a couple when you stand united in agreement with God.

"Though one can be overpowered, two can defend themselves. A cord of three strands is not quickly broken" **[Ecclesiastes 4:12 NIV]**.

SUBJECT WHICH REQUIRES AGREEMENT_____

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Week 9

The Power of Physical Intimacy

WEEKLY PRAYER FOCUS

When the Coaching Team Meets to Pray

WEEK 9 - THE POWER OF PHYSICAL INTIMACY

GOAL: To understand the importance of our physical union as man and wife, to gain insight into God's purpose for sexual intercourse, and to learn how to develop and enhance the physical realm of our relationship.

INSTRUCTION: Be open to the Lord wanting to heal wounds and deep hurts in the sexual area of couples' lives. Be ready to work with couples after the meeting as needed to help get people set free.

PRAYER FOCUS: Pray for those who are dealing with past hurts and sexual problems. Intercede for couples to grasp the depth of their physical union as God intended it to be. Continue Spirit-led intercession. Continue to pray that your couples are led of the Spirit in their financial giving. Contact those couples that God has instructed are to be the upcoming Coaches in Training or give their names to your Coaching Team Leader if they are taking care of it. It is time for them to begin praying about coaching.

Coaching Team:

Personal Prayer Needs _____

_____

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_____

_____

Ministry Prayer Needs _____

_____

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_____

_____

Notes from Prayer Time:

Praise Reports:

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WEEKLY COACHING TIPS

Graduation Day

Before you know it this class will be over and it will be time for your couples to graduate. It's not too early to begin planning your event now.



Do you have a location reserved? Graduations may be held in other public buildings or churches, but we recommend that you avoid facilities that require a fee.

Most churches will readily furnish a meeting room to Christian groups free of charge. Also there are often community centers or apartment clubhouses that are available without charge. They usually fill up quickly, though, so plan ahead.



PLEASE NOTE: If your group chooses a facility that charges a rental fee, your group must pay that fee themselves. It may not be taken out of the giving.

Have your certificates arrived? Check the names and make sure they are all correct.

Are your couples ready to share their stories with others? Make sure they get a copy of the guidelines you have in your class packet.

Encourage them to invite family and friends. This is a very special occasion and one they will want to share with others.

Have couples in your group invite friends and family. There is a section in their manual to list those they plan to invite. Encourage them to invite their pastors as well. You may have also received a list of names from the National Office of couples who are interested in hearing more about the ministry. Make sure they are invited as well as pastors in your area who are interested in the ministry.

Preprinted invitations and posters can be requested from the Home Office. Posters may be placed in churches, stores, etc. around your community. Please order this material and do not copy it.

Coaching Couples

By now you may have noticed that there are couples in your group that would make great Coaching Couples. Why not talk to them? They can train to teach a class - Married for Life, Parents for Life, or ONE for Life. Or they can be trained to coach couples who are doing self-studies or group studies. They can do email or telephone coaching or even through Skype with both video and audio. The possibilities are almost endless. If they have a heart to work with other couples, we have a way that they can do it.

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A. Covenant: The Basis for True Intimacy with God.

1. Produces life, spiritually, soulishly, physically **[John 10:10; Romans 8:11]**.
2. Spiritual purity is required for spiritual intimacy.
   a. Only available through the shed blood of Jesus **[Hebrews 9:22, 12:24]**.
   b. Jesus has provided the **only** means to intimacy with God.
   c. Covenant must be entered into for true intimacy.
3. Satan's counterfeits.
   a. Satan has falsely promised all kinds of avenues into intimacy with God.
      1) Religions, cults, communing with nature, meditation, etc.
      2) Everyone of them misses the vital element of covenant relationship through the blood of Jesus.
   b. God's plan cannot be **duplicated**.

B. Covenant Is Also the Basis for Intimacy Between Husband and Wife.

1. God's Design: Under Covenant Covering
   a. Commitment and protection of covenant allows couple to be totally vulnerable to each other **[Genesis 2:24,25]**.
   b. Man and woman were designed both physically and emotionally to experience great pleasure and satisfaction from sexual union.
2. Intimacy Produces **Life**.
   a. In Song of Solomon, references to fruit, gardens, and vineyards are used in conjunction with the relationship between the lover and his beloved.
   b. Children are natural examples of the life-giving aspect of our sexual union **[Genesis 1:28; Malachi 2:15]**.
   c. Sexual union as God created it is not self-centered nor self-seeking.
      1) It is refreshing and energizing.
      2) It produces a desire to give more than receive.
   d. Read Song of Solomon together to see the beauty of sexual union as God created it.
      1) Sexual union was God's gift to Adam and Eve in the Garden **[Genesis 1:28,31]**.
      2) It is also His special wedding gift to each couple that enters into His covenant plan for marriage **[1 Corinthians 7:3-5]**.
3. Physical purity is required for physical intimacy.
   a. You can tell how important something is to the heart of God by how much time the enemy spends perverting it.
   b. Satan has spent much time counterfeiting the intimacy of sexual union.
      1) Just as with spiritual counterfeits to imitate spiritual intimacy, Satan has also fabricated sexual **counterfeits** to imitate sexual intimacy (masturbation, homosexuality, fornication, adultery, incest, etc.)
      2) Do not produce sexual intimacy and are damaging counterfeits **[Romans 1:24-27]**.
   c. Many are not able to experience sexual intimacy as God intends because of the wounding of sexual sin.
   d. Sexual union without covenant covering permits vulnerability with no protection.
      1) Strips the ability to be intimate.
      2) Instead of edifying and ministering, it degrades and defiles.
      3) Instead of enhancing, it diminishes **[Proverbs 6:32,33]**.
   e. No wonder scripture tells us that one who commits sexual sin, sins against his own body **[1 Corinthians 6:18]**.

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Covenant: The Basis for True Intimacy with God

True intimacy is based in covenant relationship. Under the protection of covenant, intimacy was designed by God to produce life; spiritually, soulishly, and physically **[John 10:10; Romans 8:11]**. Spiritual purity, the basis for spiritual intimacy, is only available through the shed blood of Jesus **[Hebrews 9:22; 12:24]**. In the New Covenant, Jesus has provided the **only** means to intimacy with God; covenant relationship.

Satan has promised people all kinds of alternative avenues to "get close to God." Religions, cults, communing with nature, and meditation, are just a few of his counterfeit intimacies. God's plan cannot be **duplicated**, though, or produced through ungodly means.

Covenant Is Also the Basis for Intimacy Between Husband and Wife

Covenant relationship is also God's plan for intimacy between man and woman. The commitment and protection of covenant allow them to be totally vulnerable to each other and, therefore, experience a depth of relationship only possible under that covering **[Genesis 2:24, 25]**. God designed man and woman physically and emotionally to experience great pleasure and satisfaction from sexual union shared under covenant covering.

The Song of Solomon makes clear that covenant intimacy produces **life**. References to fruit, gardens, and vineyards are contained throughout the Song of Solomon and are always used in conjunction with the relationship between the lover and his beloved. God has given us a natural example of the life-giving potential of our sexual union in the creation of children **[Genesis 1:28; Malachi 2:15]**.

Sexual union, as God created it, is not self-centered or self-seeking. It never fulfills self at the expense of the other. Sexual love according to God's plan is refreshing and energizing, always desiring to give more than it receives. Read the Song of Solomon together and you will begin to see the beauty of sexual union as God created it. Just as sexual intimacy was God's gift to Adam and Eve in the garden **[Genesis 1:28, 31]**, it is His wedding gift to each couple that enters into His covenant plan of marriage **[1 Corinthians 7:3-5]**.

You can tell how important a matter is to the heart of God by how much time the enemy spends perverting it. Just as Satan has fabricated spiritual counterfeits to imitate spiritual intimacy, he has also fabricated physical **counterfeits** to imitate physical intimacy. He has deceived people into believing that masturbation, homosexuality, fornication, adultery, incest, and other sexual counterfeits produce sexual intimacy **[Romans 1:24-27]**. Many couples are not able to experience sexual intimacy in marriage because of the wounding of sexual sin.

Sexual union without covenant covering permits great vulnerability with no protection. It strips one of the ability to be truly intimate. Instead of edifying and ministering, it degrades and defiles, (makes foul, dirty, or unclean; pollutes, taints). Instead of enhancing, it diminishes **[Proverbs 6:32,33]**. It is no wonder that scripture tells us that one who commits sexual sin, sins against his own body **[1 Corinthians 6:18]**.

PERSONAL EXAMPLES

Interactive

Covenant provides protection for intimacy. Take a few minutes now and share what this means to you.

Have you experienced counterfeits to intimacy?

Do you see now why God provides for a greater depth of intimacy?

(Time three minutes and then resume the lesson)

C. Effects of Sexual Sin.

1. Man was created to be tender toward and understanding of his wife **[1 Peter 3:7]**.
   a. Jesus is the example of the intimate Husband.
      1) He overwhelmingly loves His bride.
      2) It is easy for us to respond to His love.
   b. When a man sins sexually, his must **harden** his heart.
      1) He uses, not enhances, a woman.
      2) A tender heart cannot endure the ravages of sexual sin.
   c. A man's callused, hardened heart often manifests in lust, not love, towards his wife.
      1) He cannot love his wife the way God intends.
      2) He can only show affection or interest when he wants to have sex.
      3) When he looks at wife or touches her, she feels defiled.
      4) Once his heart is hardened in sexual sin, only God can soften it again **[Ezekiel 36:26]**.
      5) No counterfeit of Satan's will enable him to love as God intended.
2. Woman was created to **respond** to the love of the man to whom she is married **[Ephesians 5:22]**.
   a. In response to his love, she gives herself totally to her husband.
      1) He loves and enhances that which she has entrusted to him.
      2) What she gives is returned to her in greater fullness so she responds again with greater love.
      3) A woman who is cherished usually has no problem loving and giving in return.
   b. When a woman sins sexually, what she gives is not returned to her.
      1) In counterfeit relationships, there is no enhancement of that which she has given.
      2) An emptiness develops within her and she cannot seem to find fulfillment.
   c. This often manifests in insecurity and poor self-image.
      1) She may not be able to respond to her husband physically.
         a) She may expect her husband to fulfill her deep inner emptiness.
         b) She feels he doesn't love her or meet her needs.
      2) Only Jesus can fill that void and give her the peace and fulfillment she desires.
3. Men and women wounded by sexual sin may seek fulfillment in compulsive behaviors with alcohol, drugs, food, gambling, or multiple sexual partners.
   a. Each time the disappointment is greater, though, and fulfillment slips farther away **[Proverbs 14:12]**.
   b. Just as spiritual purity is the basis for spiritual intimacy, so sexual purity is the basis for sexual intimacy.
   c. If you have lost that purity, Jesus longs to restore it to you.
4. When you enter marriage sexually pure, your sexual intimacy should be able to deepen as the years go by.

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Interactive

Covenant provides protection for intimacy. Take a few minutes now and share what this means to you.

Have you experienced counterfeits to intimacy?

Do you see now why God provides for a greater depth of intimacy?

(Time three minutes and then resume the lesson)

Effects of Sexual Sin

Jesus is the example of the intimate Husband. His overwhelming love for His bride makes it easy for us to respond lovingly to Him. In the same way, God created a man to be tender and loving toward the woman he marries **[1 Peter 3:7]**. When a man sins sexually, he must **harden** his heart to use, not enhance, a woman. The tender, loving heart that was God's plan for him cannot endure the ravages of sexual sin.

A man with a hardened heart cannot love a woman the way God intends. Many times in marriage a man's callused and hardened heart manifests in lust, not love, towards his wife. The man may be unable to show affection or interest in his wife other than when he wants to have sex. When he looks at her or touches her, she feels defiled and doesn't know why. Once a man has hardened his heart, only God can soften it again **[Ezekiel 36:26.]** No counterfeit of Satan's will ever enable him to love as God intended.

God created a woman to **respond** to the love of the man to whom she is joined in covenant **[Ephesians 5:22]**, giving herself totally to him. He, in turn, loves and enhances that which she has entrusted to him so that what she gives is returned to her in greater fullness, enabling her to respond with even greater love. A woman who is cherished usually has no problem loving and giving in return.

When a woman sins sexually, though, her giving of herself is not protected by covenant. In counterfeit relationships, there is no enhancement of that which she has given. An emptiness begins to develop within her and the fulfillment she seeks seemingly can't be found.

Many times this manifests in insecurity and poor self-image. A wife may not be able to respond to her husband physically. She may continually expect her husband to fulfill her deep inner emptiness and feel he doesn't love her or meet her needs. The truth is that only Jesus can fill that void and give her the peace and fulfillment she desires.

Men and women who have been wounded may seek fulfillment in compulsive behaviors such as drugs, alcohol, food, gambling or one sexual partner after another. Each time, though, the disappointment is greater and the fulfillment they are seeking slips farther away **[Proverbs 14:12]**. Just as the basis of spiritual intimacy is spiritual purity, so the basis of sexual intimacy is also purity. If you have lost that purity, Jesus longs to restore it to you.

When you enter marriage sexually pure, your sexual intimacy should be able to deepen greatly as the years of your marriage go by. Sometimes, though, purity

PERSONAL EXAMPLES

a. Purity is sometimes maintained through fear or distrust of intimacy.
b. This may keep people out of sexual sin before marriage, but it does not contribute to sexual intimacy after marriage.

D. Healing From the Wounding of Sexual Sin.

1. God, who designed sexual intimacy, has redeemed us from the curse of sin and death **[Romans 8:2]**.
   a. If you feel sex is dirty or if you fear enjoying it, Jesus longs to heal that wounding.
   b. He wants you to enjoy the fulfillment God has designed for you.
2. *"Marriage is honorable among all, and the bed undefiled"* **[Hebrews 13:4 NKJV]**.

E. Steps to Take to Be Healed from the Wounding of Sexual Sin.

1. **Repent**.
   a. Of all sexual sins you have committed.
      1) Before your marriage.
      2) Outside of your marriage.
      3) Any perverted sexual activity, whether before or during your marriage.
   b. Justification of sin only perpetuates the consequences.
   c. If you are not sure if something was sin or if scripture does not specifically mention it, ask the following questions:
      1) Did it edify?
      2) Did one or both partners feel defiled?
      3) Was there disagreement whether it was right or not?
   d. Lusting in your heart is sin **[Matthew 5:28]**.
      1) You may even have lusted toward your spouse.
      2) Ask God to teach you how to truly love your spouse.
   e. When you have repented for all sexual sin, receive not only the forgiveness of Jesus but also the **cleansing** of His blood **[1 John 1:9]**.
      1) It is the blood of Jesus that washes away the defilement of sin.
      2) Receive from Jesus the restoration of your innocence **[Psalm 51:10]**.
2. Forgive.
   a. Anyone who has wounded or used you sexually, whether consensual or not.
      1) Through incest or rape, premarital sex or adultery, fondling or petting, exposure.
      2) May have been a lover, a former spouse, a relative or friend, or even your spouse who related to you in lust, not love.
   b. Forgive them and release them to Jesus.
   c. Forgive yourself, whether you were a willing partner or an innocent victim.
      1) Forgive yourself for the defilement.
      2) Begin to love yourself as Jesus loves you. You are precious to Him.
3. Sever all ungodly **soul** ties.
   a. Anytime the mind, will, and emotions are deeply involved in a relationship, a soul tie is formed.
   b. Soul ties hold us mentally and emotionally to previous relationships and people.
   c. They can be formed under favorable conditions as well as unfavorable conditions.
      1) An example of an unfavorable condition is **Genesis 34:2,3,8**.
   d. Need to break all soul ties that bind you to a previous relationship.

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has been maintained in one's life through fear or distrust of intimacy. This may keep people out of sexual sin before they marry, but it does not contribute to sexual intimacy within marriage.

Healing From the Wounding of Sexual Sin

Thank God there is hope! God, who designed sexual intimacy, has redeemed us from the curse of sin and death **[Romans 8:2]**. He desires so much for us to know true intimacy that He has provided a way of healing when we have missed the mark. If you feel sex is dirty or if you fear enjoying it, Jesus also longs to heal that wounding so that you may enjoy the fulfillment that God has designed for you in your sexual union. **Hebrews 13:4 (NKJV)** says, *"Marriage is honorable among all, and the bed undefiled"*

Steps to Take to Be Healed from the Wounding of Sexual Sin

There are certain steps that must be taken to be healed. First of all, you must **repent** for all sexual sin. This includes sexual sin before marriage and during marriage and any perverted sexual activity, either before or after marriage. Justification of sin only perpetuates the consequences.

If you are not certain if something was sinful, and if scripture doesn't specifically mention it, ask the following questions. Did it edify? Did one or the other sexual partner feel defiled? Was there disagreement between partners as to whether or not it was right? Even lust in one's heart is sin **[Matthew 5:28]**. If you have lusted, even toward your spouse, you need to repent and ask God to teach you how to love your spouse. When you have repented for all sexual sin, receive not only the forgiveness of Jesus but also the **cleansing** of His blood that washes away the defilement of the sin **[1 John 1:9]**. As the defilement is cleansed away, receive from Jesus the restoration of your innocence **[Psalm 51:10]**.

Next, you need to forgive and release anyone who has wounded or used you sexually, whether it was with your consent or not. This may have occurred through incest, rape, a premarital sexual union or adultery. It may have been fondling, petting, or exposure. It may have been a lover or a previous spouse. It may have been a relative or a trusted friend. It may have even been your own spouse who related to you in lust, not love. You need to forgive them and release them to Jesus.

Then you need to forgive yourself. Whether you were a willing partner or an innocent victim, you must forgive yourself for your defilement. Begin to love yourself as Jesus loves you. You are precious to Him.

Next you need to sever all ungodly **soul** ties. Anytime the mind, will, and emotions are deeply involved in a relationship, a soul tie is formed. A soul tie continues to hold us mentally and emotionally to that person and that relationship.

An example of one formed under ungodly conditions is found in **Genesis 34:1-3**. *"And Dinah, the daughter of Leah, which she bare unto Jacob, went out to see the daughters of the land. And when Shechem the son of Hamor the Hivite, prince of the country, saw her, he took her, and lay with her, and defiled her. And his soul clave unto Dinah..."* [KJV]. Verse 8 of **Genesis 34** says, *"And Hamor communed with them, saying, The soul of my son Shechem longeth for your daughter..."* (KJV).

Any soul ties that bind you mentally or emotionally to a previous relationship need to be broken. This includes relationships with previous spouses. Severing of soul ties does not necessarily mean ending relationships, it means ending ungodly holds. For example, you may need to continue communicating with a previous spouse re-

1) Whether you consented or not.
2) This includes previous spouses.

e. Severing soul ties does not necessarily mean ending the relationship.
1) You may continue to relate, for example, to a previous spouse.
2) The emotional and mental ties will be broken, though.

4. Take authority over demonic spirits given access through sin **[Romans 6:16]**.
a. They create areas of demonic hold.
1) Areas in which you simply cannot maintain victory.
2) This is not a case of not trying; you are driven in this area.
b. Spiritual assignments can bring forth lust, shame, promiscuity, impotence, frigidity and many more.
c. Ask Holy Spirit to reveal to you any spiritual assignments and take authority over them in Jesus' name.
d. Break any generational patterns.
1) Take authority over assignments against your **children** and down through the generations.
2) If these assignments are not canceled in Jesus' name, the sin may be repeated from generation to generation.
3) Do the same for adopted children with different generational backgrounds.
a) Often they have been conceived in fornication.
b) If you do not break the assignments against them, they may struggle with the same strongholds.
c) You can set them free in Jesus' name.

5. After you have dealt with each of these areas, you have been set free in Jesus.
a. Are on the way to the healing of your sexual union as husband and wife.
1) Realize that sexual healing is not accomplished overnight.
2) The sin was removed as soon as you confessed it **[1 John 1:9]**.
3) Scars take some time to heal.
b. Be patient with each other during the time of healing.
1) **Performance** is the devil's measure of sexual fulfillment **[2 Corinthians 10:12]**.
a) It is self-centered and self-directed.
b) God gave your sex drive for the fulfillment of your spouse, not you.
2) Begin to see your love making as a time to minister to each other.
a) Get the focus off "me and my needs" and onto your spouse.
b) Do not do anything that would wound or defile your spouse.
3) Pray together in the spirit before making love.
a) Ask God to bless your union as He did Adam and Eve's **[Genesis 1:28]**.
b) Recognize that He is part of your sexual union.
c. Refuse condemnation regarding previous sexual relationships because they are now under the blood of Jesus **[Romans 8:1]**.

F. Maintaining Victory.

1. To maintain your victory and obtain total healing, you must keep yourself from impurity and renew your mind with the Word of God **[Romans 12:1,2]**.
a. Your mind is the **battleground** where the enemy attempts to regain what he lost.
b. As of 2007, one-third of divorce litigation in the United States was caused by online affairs.
1) Yet only 46% of men believe that online affairs are adultery.
2) If you are fighting lust, take great care to avoid internet sites that feed that lust.
3) Adult websites generate over $1 billion a year in revenue and 8-10 % of Internet users

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garding children, etc., but the emotional and mental ties will have been severed.

Finally, you need to take authority over any demonic spirits that were given access to your life through sin **[Romans 6:16]**. They create a demonic hold in your life. These are areas in which you simply cannot maintain victory; areas in which no matter how hard you try, you cannot break free. Spiritual assignments can create lust, shame, promiscuity, impotence, frigidity, etc. Ask the Holy Spirit to reveal to you any spiritual strongholds and break their hold in the name of Jesus.

Also take authority over and cancel any demonic spiritual assignments made on your **children** and succeeding generations because of your sin. If these assignments are not canceled, the sin may be repeated from generation to generation. Also, if you have children who are adopted, ask the Holy Spirit to reveal any spirits you need to deal with regarding them. Very often adopted children are conceived in fornication and struggle throughout their lives with the same spiritual holds. You can take authority over those spirits and set them free in Jesus' name.

When you have dealt with each of these areas and you have been set free, you are on your way to healing of your sexual union as husband and wife. Please realize that sexual healing is not accomplished overnight. The sin is removed as soon as you confess it **[1 John 1:9]** but the scars may take some time to heal. Be patient with each other as God completes the work.

Remember, **performance** is the devil's measure of sexual fulfillment. Performance is self-centered and self-directed **[2 Corinthians 10:12]**. God did not give you your sex drive for yourself. He gave it to you for your spouse that you might desire to bless and fulfill him or her. Begin to see your love-making as a time of ministry to each other. Get the focus off "me and my needs" and onto your spouse.

Do not engage in any activity that one spouse finds offensive. If you desire to minister to and bless your spouse, you do not want to do anything that wounds or defiles. Pray together in the spirit before you make love to each other. Ask God to bless your union as He did Adam and Eve's **[Genesis 1:28]**. Recognize that He is a part of your sexual union. Refuse any condemnation or nagging thoughts regarding previous relationships **[Romans 8:1]**. They are now under the blood of Jesus.

Maintaining Victory

In order to maintain victory and obtain total healing, it is imperative to keep yourself from impurity and to renew your mind with the Word **[Romans 12:1,2]**.

Your mind is the **battleground** in which the enemy is going to wage war to regain what he has lost. You must guard yourselves from the worldly image of sexual lust that is fed through pornography, romance novels, soap operas, the internet, advertising, and movies.

As of 2007, one-third of divorce litigation in the United States was caused by online affairs. Yet only 46% of men believe that online affairs are adultery. If you are fighting lust, take great care to avoid internet sites that feed that lust. Adult websites generate over $1 billion a year in revenue and 8-10 % of Internet users become hooked on cybersex. Avoid any type of internet interaction that leads to even an emotional attachment. Cybersex is sex. It is adultery.

Refuse that message. Flee from temptation **[2 Timothy 2:22]**. Replace your old thought patterns with the Word of God. You have the mind of Christ **[1 Corinthians 2:16]**.

PERSONAL EXAMPLES

become hooked on cybersex.

c. Avoid any type of internet interaction that leads to even an emotional attachment. Cybersex is sex. It is adultery.
   1) Guard yourselves from the worldly image of sexual lust.
   2) Refuse the message fed through pornography, soap operas, romance novels, the internet, etc.

b. Renew your mind (replace the old thought patterns with the Word of God.)
   1) You have the mind of Christ **[1 Corinthians 2:16]**.
   2) Refuse the enemy's thoughts.

2. Guard your sexual union together as husband and wife.

a. Lock your shields of faith together over your point of wounding.
   1) Examples: If one spouse has a problem with lust, give him or her permission to share whenever tempted or if one spouse was a victim of incest or rape, give permission to share when tempted with shame.
   2) Don't take that as an admission of failure.
   3) Lock your shields of faith together for protection against the enemy.

b. Stand united as a one-flesh team in the power of Jesus **[1 Corinthians 10:12,13]**.

3. Be led of the Spirit in all things **[Romans 8:14]**, including your sexual union.
   a. Usually we are led by **passion** (flesh) or feelings (soul).
      1) The Holy Spirit gives direction before and after we are married to keep us in God's will.
      2) If we have learned to hear His voice before marriage, we know how to hear Him after.
   b. Usually we have not sought His guidance regarding our sexual union.
      1) We need to become attentive to His voice.
      2) He will minister to us through our sexual union if we are obedient.
4. Make sure you take time to minister to each other sexually.
   a. Don't get so busy there's no time for making love.
   b. Don't become "so spiritual" that you don't have a physical relationship.
   c. God commands couples to have a sexual relationship **[1 Corinthians 7:3-4]**.
      1) This one aspect makes marriage **unique** from any other relationship.
      2) God will minister to you through a healthy sexual union.
      3) Without sexual union, marriage is vulnerable to enemy attack **[1 Corinthians 7:5]**.
   d. If your sexual relationship needs healing:
      1) Allow God to regenerate "courting."
         a Develop a renewed appreciation and respect for each other.
         b) As these are developed, love and desire will follow.
      2) Give each other time to grow in sexual love **[Song of Solomon 2:7; 3:5; 8:4]**.
      3) Submit yourselves to Jesus, allow Him to put desire for each other back in your hearts, and be obedient to His directions.
5. Our approach to sexual intimacy influences our children.
   a. We must not convey to them that sex is bad to keep them from sin.
   b. Teach them honestly regarding the fulfillment of sexual intimacy along with the reasons for God's commandments.
      1) They will be better equipped to enter marriage pure and with a healthy attitude toward intimacy.
      2) The wounding of sexual sin need not be repeated in the next generation.
         a) Wisdom and knowledge of the Word of God and our own example will help prepare our children to discover the power of God's plan for physical intimacy under the covering of covenant.

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Begin to guard your sexual union together as husband and wife. Lock your shields of faith over your point of wounding. For example, if your spouse has had a problem with lust, give him or her permission to let you know when lust is becoming a temptation. Don't take that admission as a failure. Lock your shields of faith together in the spirit as a protection. If your spouse was a victim of incest or rape, give him or her permission to share when shame is trying to come upon them. Then lock shields together in the spirit and protect from enemy attack. Stand united as a one-flesh team in the power of Jesus **[1 Corinthians 10:12,13]**.

Be led of the Spirit in all things **[Romans 8:14]**, including your sexual union. Usually we are led by our **passion** (flesh) or by our feelings (soul). The Holy Spirit gives direction and guidance both before and after we are married to keep us in God's will. If we have learned to listen to His voice before we are married, we will know how to hear it after we are married. Unfortunately, most of us have never asked the Holy Spirit anything regarding our physical relationship. We need to become attentive to His voice. He will minister to us through our sexual union if we are obedient to His direction.

Make sure you take time to minister to each other sexually. Don't get so busy that you have no time for making love. Don't become so spiritual that you no longer have a physical relationship. God has commanded husband and wife to have a sexual union **[1 Corinthians 7:3-4]**. Sexual intimacy in marriage is the one aspect of the relationship that makes it **unique** from other types of relationships. God gave your sexual union to you for a reason. He will minister to you through a healthy sexual union. Without it your marriage is vulnerable and subject to enemy attack **[1 Corinthians 7:5]**.

If the physical aspect of your marriage is in need of healing, allow God to begin by renewing the courting process. Begin by letting Him renew your appreciation for each other and develop a new respect for each other. As that respect deepens, love and intimacy will follow. Give Him the time needed each step of the way to complete the work. Do not become discouraged. Do not try to hasten the process **[Song of Solomon 2:7, 3:5, 8:4]**. Submit yourselves totally to Jesus and allow Him to change your hearts. Then be obedient to His directions.

Our approach to our sexual intimacy influences our children. We must not convey to them that sex is bad or dirty. Teaching children negative connotations regarding intimacy will not necessarily keep them out of a premarital sexual union, but it will certainly rob them of the joy God intends for them in marriage. If we teach our children honestly regarding the fulfillment of sexual intimacy along with the reasons for God's commandments, they will be better equipped to enter into marriage pure and with a healthy attitude toward sexual union. The wounding of sexual sin that many have experienced need not be repeated in the next generation. Wisdom and knowledge of the Word of God and our own example will help prepare our children to discover the power of God's plan for physical intimacy under the covering of covenant.

PERSONAL EXAMPLES

Life Application - Let's make it real

PLEASE NOTE: THIS LESSON INVOLVES EXAMINING PAST SEXUAL ACTIVITY. DO NOT "DUMP" INFORMATION ON YOUR SPOUSE. BEFORE ANY SIN OF THIS NATURE IS SHARED BETWEEN YOU, YOU NEED TO PRAY AND FAST AND PREPARE SPIRITUALLY. LESSON 11 WILL DEAL WITH HOW TO CONFESS SIN BETWEEN YOU AND TO RECEIVE HEALING.

1. If your sexual relationship needs healing, you need to follow the instructions given in the lesson. Repent of any unconfessed sexual sins and receive forgiveness from the Lord. Forgive yourself. Break all soul ties connected with the sin. Ask the Lord to help you discern any spirits that may have been assigned because of that sin. Cancel, in the name of Jesus, their assignments over you, your spouse, your children and your children's children down through the generations. If you were wounded sexually as a child or an adult, forgive the one or ones who hurt you. Pray the following prayer:

"Father, in the name of Jesus, I repent of all sexual sin in which I have been involved. I receive Your forgiveness now, in Jesus' name. I choose to forgive others who have hurt me. I choose to forgive myself. Jesus, I ask you now to cleanse out all the bitterness, all the resentment, all the hurt feelings with Your precious blood. I now break any and all ungodly soul ties with ..... (speak out every name God gives you). I break all of the authority connected with these ties in my life and I declare that I am loosed from all affects now, this day. I renounce Satan and all his works from my life. I take authority, in the name of Jesus, over any spirits assigned because of this sin,.....(names of spirits the Lord reveals to you). I cancel their assignment over me, over my spouse, over our marriage, over our children, and over our children's children down through the generations, in Jesus' name. I am freed by the blood of Jesus. Let every void be filled now with Your love, Lord Jesus. Jesus, You are my victory. You are my liberty. You are my freedom. Oh, God, restore my soul, in Jesus' name. Amen."

Allow the Lord to restore to you your innocence as He cleanses you from all unrighteousness with His blood **[1 John 1:9]**. Purity is now the basis for your sexual union as a couple. Learn to become obedient to the voice of the Spirit. Jesus said the Holy Spirit would "guide us into all truth" **[John 16:13]**. and that includes truth regarding intimacy in marriage. Ask God for the courage to obey. As you begin to approach sexual problems as one-flesh, you will begin to see healing emerge that you have not been able to attain on your own individually.

2. In the Bible, the **Song of Solomon** describes beautifully the intimate relationship between husband and wife. Within that text is found every element of sexual fulfillment as God has ordained it for marriage. If we study the verses, the depth of God's plan for sexual love is revealed to us.

Song of Solomon is graphically sensual. God is not bashful about His design for intimacy between husband and wife. In fact, the gratification of all five senses is found within the verses. The keys to the excitement of each of the senses give us a blueprint for the ingredients necessary for a healthy, vibrant sexual union.

Visual stimulation is an important aspect of sexual love **[Song of Solomon 1:5; 4:1-7; 5:10-16]**. A man is more sexually aroused by sight than a woman is. The devil has used this to great advantage in the world but God designed the man to respond favorably when he looks upon his wife. Both spouses need to realize that appearance is important, for though a wife is usually not stimulated visually, she may be hampered in her arousal by the unkempt appearance of her husband.

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Become more aware of each other's appearance and ask God to remind you to show your admiration verbally. Be honest - start with something you truly admire, no matter how limited. As you move in obedience in this area, your appreciation and admiration will grow and deepen. Use this time to allow God to make you more aware of your own appearance. Is there anything you can do to be more appealing to your spouse? Do you need to lose weight? Get a haircut? Pay more attention to dress? Exercise? Brush your teeth more often? Ask the Lord to help you in any area of improvement in which He convicts you. Resolve today to be a blessing in your appearance to your spouse.

AREAS I RESOLVE TO WORK ON

HIM	HER

Hearing is also part of sexual arousal **[S. of S. 2:14b; 5:2; 7:8,9]**. What we hear affects our perception of our spouse's feelings for us and often determines ours for them. Our words to each other have a bearing on our sexual union long before we enter into intimacy. Consistent words of endearment and praise will mean far more than words spoken just before anticipated love making.

God wants you to speak to each other regarding your appreciation for each other as sexual partners. Remember when you were first dating and how you admired each other? Has that appreciation gone out of your relationship? Do you as a husband realize and admire her beauty as you once did? Do you as a wife appreciate and admire his physique? We each need that so very much and yet sometimes it is the hardest thing for us to express to each other.

Read how the Lover and the Beloved speak to each other in **Song of Solomon**. Those two people had a true appreciation of each other and enjoyed a healthy physical relationship. They could openly express their love and desire for each other. That should be our goal also as husband and wife. Make a list of the things you appreciate about your spouse. Resolve to tell him or her often how you feel, not just when you want some desired result.

Lover to Beloved: (him to her)

Beloved to Lover: (her to him)

Smell **[S. of S. 1:12; 4:10,11]** and taste **[S. of S. 2:3; 4:10, 11]** are also important senses in sexual intimacy. We bless each other when we stimulate these senses with delightful fragrances. God does not make light of their affect on sexual intimacy, nor should we.

Make sure your breath is fresh and clean. Toothpaste and mouthwashes leave a nice lingering taste. Experiment with different colognes and perfumes and see which ones you both like. Make use of testers in stores. Try burning scented candles or simmering potpourri while you are making love. Make the atmosphere soft and romantic, filled with delightful scents.

Touch **[S. of S. 1:2; 2:6; 8:3]** is the final, not the first, step in sexual arousal. Stimulation of the other four senses will heighten the delight of sexual touch. Men need to be aware of the impact that this will have on sexual fulfillment for their wives. A woman is usually slower to arouse and will find more sexual fulfillment in a spouse who is willing to stimulate her other senses before proceeding to touch.

Women especially love to be held, hugged, and kissed at times other than love-making. Tender holding on the part of a husband blesses and comforts a wife. The love and tenderness you show to her will be returned to you as she responds with greater and greater love **[Ephesians 5:28]**.

3. Where your mind is during intercourse is very important. If you are thinking of someone else or imagining someone else, you are engaged in mental adultery. In the Song of Solomon both the lover and the beloved have their thoughts stayed on each other **[Song of Solomon 7:10; 8:6,7]**, therefore, their desire for each other remains strong. **Proverbs 23:7 (NKJV)** says, *"For as he thinks in his heart, so is he..."* Our thought life determines our actions.

To deepen your sexual union, you need to concentrate on each other. Are either of you involved in pornography? Know for certain that there is no such thing as "innocent" pornography. Pornography comes from the same root word as "poneria" in **Ephesians 6:12**, which means depravity or spiritual wickedness. It is one of the most deceptive strongholds of the enemy. Lust is never satisfied. What is a thought today will be an action tomorrow. If the enemy cannot keep you from entering into the intimacy of God's covenant plan, marriage, he will attempt to make you compromise that covenant commitment. He tells you his counterfeits will bring excitement to your sexual union with your spouse but he knows they will rob you of intimacy with each other.

Do you read romance novels or watch soap operas? These things create a false image of sexual union. None of these give the image of lasting, maturing love. Each one portrays the excitement of lust at first sight and, as the excitement dies, the people involved must go on to other lovers to find the same excitement. God intends for our sexual union to grow and deepen just as our love for each other grows and deepens. If we are filling our minds with the world's garbage, we are going to seek after just that. But if we are filling our minds with the Word of God and asking Him for His plan for us, we will seek after that. Allow God to give you the sexual union He desires for you. It is so far above the imitation that the world has fabricated. Go for the very best God has to offer. It is well worth the effort it takes to achieve it.

Problems with pornography and lust cannot be overcome alone. You need the help of your spouse. First receive the deliverance and cleansing of the blood of Jesus. Then join together in one-flesh unity against these demonic strongholds. Become accountable to each other in areas of weakness. Remember, though, you are not your spouse's Holy Spirit. It is your job to intercede and to stand beside in support. Allow the conviction of sin to come from the One who does it best. The devil has used these tools to divide you in the past. Now join together in the power of Jesus against him and his forces of darkness. Together you will have the victory!

"Drink water from your own cistern, running water from your own well. Should your springs overflow in the streets, your streams of water in public places? Let them be yours alone, never to be shared with strangers. May your fountain be blessed, and may you rejoice in the wife of your youth. A loving doe, a graceful deer - may her breasts satisfy you always, may you ever be captivated by her love..." [Proverbs 5:15-20 NIV]

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Week 10

The Power of Spiritual Warfare

WEEKLY PRAYER FOCUS

When the Coaching Team Meets to Pray

WEEK 10 - THE POWER OF SPIRITUAL WARFARE

GOAL: To teach couples to fight spiritual warfare as one-flesh. To heighten awareness of the ongoing spiritual battle in which we are engaged, to familiarize couples with their weapons and their usage, and to learn to detect enemy attack before it happens.

INSTRUCTION: Be prepared for the enemy to stir things up. He hates this lesson! Be prepared in the spirit to minister to people who feel you "shouldn't talk about the devil."

PRAYER FOCUS: Usually this is a week of heavy warfare. Continue to intercede specifically as the Holy Spirit directs. Begin praying up your outreach night. Pray that your couples stand together for the marriages of others by giving financially this week.

Coaching Team:

Personal Prayer Needs _____

_____

_____

_____

_____

Ministry Prayer Needs _____

_____

_____

_____

_____

_____

Notes from Prayer Time:

Praise Reports:

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WEEKLY COACHING TIPS

Your Graduation Night

When your class is finished, you need to hold a Graduation celebration. This is a special time for the couples in your class as well as an information night for those interested in knowing more about 2=1 and, specifically, the Married for Life course.

This is an opportunity for each couple to share what God has done in their lives during the preceding weeks. Graduation certificates are given to all couples that have not already received one in another group. You should have your certificates by now. If you do not have them, please notify the National Office. Certificates are not sent if there are outstanding registration fees in the group or if all weekly reports are not in the National Office. As soon as these matters are resolved, certificates are sent to you.

You have received a Graduation Packet. In that packet you will find all the forms and other materials needed. You will find instructions in the following Forms Section for the completion of each form as well as information on how to conduct the meeting.

The order of the meeting is just a suggested order. You may present the material in any order that is most comfortable for you and for your audience. Just make sure you include all the elements listed.

The entire meeting should not be longer than two hours, so it might be good to make good notes and stick to your outline. All couples who desire to be in a ***2=1*** class need to hear about the goals of the ministry and how the class runs. The fastest and easiest way to do this is to have them attend a graduation when it is all explained. They can register for a class at the end of the meeting. If you desire to meet with a couple separately so that you might fill a class, make sure you covered the starred items. No couple should start a 2=1 class without understanding what they will receive and what is required of them.

1. WELCOME
2. PRAYER
3. PRAISE AND WORSHIP
* 4. VISION OF ***2=1***
5. COUPLES SHARE THEIR STORIES
* 6. CLASS PROTOCOL
7. OPPORTUNITY TO GIVE
* 8. QUESTIONS AND ANSWERS
9. MINISTRY
10. REGISTRATION

A. Creation of One-Flesh Team.

1. God placed within both man and woman abilities.
   a. When combined they are an unbeatable warfare team.
   b. The fall handicapped one-flesh warfare, but through Jesus the ability was restored.
2. Consider everything taught in this lesson from the standpoint of one-flesh team warfare.
   a. Most families have only one spouse who does warfare.
   b. No wonder there are casualties.
   c. If you are not fighting the enemy **together**, you are wasting precious resources.
   d. Let this be a time of the Lord teaching both spouses how to war together.

B. We Have Same Abilities Placed in Adam and Eve.

1. The Fall perverted the outflow.
2. "Helper Suitable" ("help meet" in KJV).
   a. Comes from Hebrew root word meaning "to **surround**."
   b. Used numerous times in Old Testament.
      1) Only twice as "helper suitable" or "help meet."
         a) Both in reference to Adam's wife.
         b) **Genesis 2:18,20**.
      2) All other times it is used as "help" or "aid."
         a) Used in reference to the Lord.
         b) Refers to Him as a "help" or "aid" to Israel.
   c. God gave clever strategies to Israel to gain victories.
      1) Sometimes the Israelites did not even have to fight.
      2) God's help saved a great deal of casualties.
3. God placed within woman a similar ability to assist in battle.
   a. We have labeled it "**radar**."
   b. It is an inner knowing that senses enemy attack.
   c. God placed it in woman to detect enemy activity at a distance.
   d. It is one aspect of "suitable helper."
4. God gave Adam a corresponding **warrior** ability.
   a. In Adam's heart, God placed a desire to win.
   b. Adam was created in the image of God--he was the very best!
   c. God's desire was for Adam to triumph over the enemy.
   d. The approach of the enemy would alert that warrior quality and Adam would rise up in authority, knowing that he had the victory.
5. Perversion of abilities.
   a. Satan's attack:
      1) His first strategy was to knock out the radar.
         a) *"...has God indeed said...?"* **[Genesis 3:1]**.
         b) The diversion worked, the radar failed and Eve was deceived **[2 Corinthians 11:3; 1 Timothy 2:14]**.
      2) His second strategy was to defeat the warrior **[Genesis 3:6]**.
         a) Adam failed to exercise his authority over the enemy.
         b) He disobeyed God, and ate of the Tree of the Knowledge of Good and Evil.

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Creation of One-Flesh Team

From the very beginning in the Garden of Eden, God equipped the one-flesh team to fight spiritual warfare. He placed within both the man and the woman abilities that, when combined, are an unbeatable warfare team. Unfortunately, Adam and Eve failed to carry out His plans, and as a result, one-flesh warfare has been severely handicapped ever since. Most families believe that if one spouse, usually the wife, is doing spiritual warfare, that's enough. Unfortunately, that is like going to battle with half your armor and weapons. It's no wonder there are casualties. If neither of you are spiritual warriors, it's a miracle that you're still on your feet.

You have been equipped for spiritual battle as a one-flesh team and it is the purpose of this lesson to teach you how to fight as a couple, not with each other. If you are not fighting the enemy **together**, you are wasting valuable resources. If you have been fighting spiritual warfare without your spouse, this is not a time to teach your spouse how much you know. What you have learned is only part of what you need to know together. Let this be a time for the Lord to teach you both.

We Have Same Abilities Placed in Adam and Eve

The abilities for spiritual warfare that God placed in Adam and Eve still exist in us today. Because of the fall, though, the outflow of these abilities has been perverted. In Lesson 2 we learned that "helper" comes from the Hebrew root word that means "to **surround**." That same word, "helper," is used numerous times throughout the Old Testament. It is only used twice as "helper suitable," though, and both times refers to Adam's wife **[Genesis 2:18,20]**.

All other times the same word is used in the Old Testament, it is translated "help" or "aid," and refers to God in His role as a help or aid to Israel in battle. Now in that role of help in battle, God did not just swoop down and destroy the enemy. Instead He gave Israel very clever strategies that brought about victory. Sometimes Israel did not even have to fight because the strategy brought about such confusion that the enemy did themselves in. In all cases, Israel was saved from great casualties by the assistance of the Lord.

God has placed within woman a similar ability to assist in battle. We have labeled it "radar." It still exists in women today. It is that inner knowing when there is a problem brewing. It is that ability to know that one of the children is in trouble before the phone rings. It is what prompts a woman to pray for her husband at work before he comes home to tell her he's had a terrible day. The world has called this ability many things. God called it a "helper suitable" to Adam. He placed it within Eve as a detector of enemy attack. It is a "**radar**" which scans the horizon and picks up enemy activity at a distance.

God also placed a corresponding ability within Adam. He made him a **warrior**. In the heart of Adam, God placed the desire to win, to be the very best. Adam was created in the image of God, he was the very best! God's desire was for Adam to triumph over the enemy. It was God's desire that when the enemy approached, it would alert that warrior quality and Adam would rise to fight, knowing that he had the victory.

In the Garden of Eden when Satan, disguised as a serpent, entered into territory he had no right to enter, both systems failed. Satan's strategy was to first knock out the radar. That is the usual approach, even in modern warfare. Get the radar and you've blinded the opposition. His question was, *"...has God indeed said...?"* **[Genesis 3:1]**. His diversionary tactic worked, the radar failed and Eve was deceived **[2 Corinthians 11:3; 1 Timothy 2:14]**.

Following the failure of the radar, the warrior failed. He did not rise up and defeat the enemy. Instead, he disobeyed God and ate of the Tree of the Knowledge of Good and Evil **[Genesis 3:6]**.

PERSONAL EXAMPLES

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b. Effects of the Fall on the Radar (Wife).
   1) Radar fails to just pick up spiritual discernment.
      a) Now picks up everything (like snow on a radar screen).
      b) Things of the flesh (fear, suspicion, criticism, worry, and anxiety) get mixed in with spiritual discernment.
   2) Instead of encouraging her husband, nagging and aggression are often an outflow of the overload.
c. Affects of the Fall on the Warrior (Husband).
   1) Now fights to excel over men, not spiritual enemy.
      a) Competition and greed have replaced spiritual superiority.
      b) Men fight against men in sports arena and work place.
   2) Husband may tune out wife instead of listening to her, abandoning her to enemy attack.
d. Time to resurrect godly qualities.
   1) When both spouses are functioning as created, the home is impervious to enemy attack.
   2) Rise up and be what you were created to be.
   3) These qualities will need fine-tuning and sharpening.
      a) Pray together daily and learn to **separate** spiritual from carnal.
      b) Husband must help wife to discern between fleshly anxiety and spiritual alerting.
      c) Wife must call on husband when under attack and help him to rise up in battle.

Interactive

Can you think of one way the enemy has gained access to your home/ Take a few minutes now and discuss this. Pray and ask the Lord to show you how to get victory in that area.

(Time three minutes and then resume teaching)

C. Protection of God.

1. God has provided **armor** for our protection in battle.
   a. Remember daily that you have it on.
   b. It is your identity in Christ.
   b. Remind children they are wearing it.
   c. Wearing your armor means walking in the fullness of what each piece means.
2. Armor of God. **[Ephesians 6:11, 13-18]**
   a. Helmet of Salvation.
      1) Covers your **mind** and protects your thoughts.
      2) See through Jesus' eyes and hear with Jesus' ears.

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Immediately, as with everything else, these two abilities in man and woman became perverted. Instead of picking up just spiritual signals of the enemy's attack, the radar now picks up things of the flesh (fear, suspicion, criticism, worry, and anxiety). They all register with the same intensity as spiritual discernment. Nagging and aggression, often toward their husband, are the outflow of the overload. The warrior, who was created to excel over his spiritual enemy, now fights to excel over other men. Competition and greed have replaced spiritual superiority. Men fight against men to excel in the sports arena and in the work place. Often men tune out their wives and refuse to listen to their counsel, abandoning them to enemy attack.

It is time to resurrect these godly abilities in the Christian home. When the wife is functioning in the help-meet position of the "radar" and is scanning the horizon for signs of enemy activity and the "warrior" is in his place ready to attack at the first sign of the enemy, the home is impervious to enemy attack. Women, you were meant to have that inner knowing. God put that ability there. Men, you were designed to win. You were meant to be the very best over your enemy, Satan. Rise up and fight!

These abilities are going to require fine-tuning and sharpening. This is only going to happen as the two of you pray together daily and learn to **separate** the spiritual from the carnal. The more time you spend with the Spirit of God, the easier it is going to be for you to discern. You are going to need each other to complete the task. Husband, help your wife sharpen her radar skills. Pray with her to discern between fleshly anxiety and spiritual alerting. Wife, help your husband rise up as warrior for his family. Call on him when there is an attack. Support him in the battle; don't criticize him.

Interactive

Can you think of one way the enemy has gained access to your home/ Take a few minutes now and discuss this. Pray and ask the Lord to show you how to get victory in that area.

(Time three minutes and then resume teaching)

Protection of God

God is not sending you into battle unprotected. He has provided **armor** to be worn. **[Ephesians 6:11,13-18]** We receive our armor when we accept Jesus as our Lord and Savior and receive the infilling of the Holy Spirit. It is not something we have to put on daily. It is our identity in Christ. It is essential, though, to remember daily that you are wearing it and that it is never to be taken off. Make sure your children have theirs on. No soldier would go to battle uncovered. It would mean certain injury.

What does it mean to remember you are wearing your armor? You aren't physically wearing it, of course. It is your spiritual identity. Wearing your armor means walking in the fullness of what each piece means. The helmet of salvation covers our **mind** and protects our thoughts. When we wear it we see through Jesus' eyes and hear with Jesus' ears.

PERSONAL EXAMPLES

b. Breastplate of Righteousness.
   1) Covers your **heart** **[Proverbs 4:23]**.
   2) Only the righteousness of Jesus can change hearts.
c. **Loins** girded with Truth.
   1) Loins are life-giving parts.
   2) Truth of the Word gives life.
d. Feet shod with the preparation of the Gospel of Peace.
   1) Always be ready to take gospel forth.
   2) Peace undisturbed by unexpected requests from God.
e. Take up the Shield of Faith.
   1) Faith protects you against enemy's fiery **darts**.
   2) Ward off doubt and fear.
f. Take up the Sword of the Spirit.
   1) Sword = **Word** of God.
   2) You must be in Word daily.
   3) It is an offensive as well as defensive weapon.
   4) Must be in your heart and in your mouth **[Deuteronomy 30:14]**.
g. Pray always in the **spirit**.
   1) Sow to the spirit, not the flesh **[Romans 8:5]**.
   2) Keeps you in constant contact with your Commander-in-Chief for instructions.

D. Other Assets Given to Us in Battle.

1. **Authority** in Jesus' name.
   a. All authority in heaven and on earth has been given to Jesus **[Matthew 28:18]**.
   b. Asking in His name **[John 14:13 NIV]**.
   c. Binding (to forbid, prohibit, declare to be illicit) and loosing in His name **[Matthew 18:18 NIV]**.
2. There is power in the **blood** of Jesus.
   a. Blood must be shed for forgiveness of sin **[Hebrews 9:22, 26 NIV]**.
   b. The Blood of Jesus overcomes the enemy **[Revelation 12:11 NIV]**.
   c. Once we have received Jesus as Lord and Savior, the blood of Jesus is at work in our lives.
   d. Blood of Jesus was shed for people, not animals and things.
      1) As you pray, cover people with the blood for protection.
      2) Ask protection for animals and possessions because they are covered under our covenant with the Lord.
         a) God watches over and protects those in covenant with Him **[Job 1:10]**.
         b) Jesus asked the Father's protection for us **[John 17:11]**.
3. Praise.
   a. The Lord **inhabits** the praises of His people **[Psalm 22:3]**.
   b. The enemy is silenced by praise **[Psalm 8:2 NIV]**.
   c. Praise God frequently.
      1) It is a powerful weapon.
      2) He is worthy of our praise.

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The breastplate of righteousness covers our **heart**. Scripture says to guard our heart with all diligence for out of it flow the issues of life **[Proverbs 4:23]**. Only the righteousness of Jesus can change our heart and keep it from harm.

The belt of truth covers our **loins**. The loins are the life-giving parts of our body. The Word is truth and when we abide in it we walk in the fullness of eternal life.

Our feet are to be shod with the preparation of the Gospel of Peace. We have an important message to carry and many to carry it to. We must be ever ready to go in peace whenever and wherever God sends us throughout the day. It should not disrupt our peace to go on a mission for the Lord.

We are to take up the shield of faith to quench all the fiery **darts** of the enemy. If we do not abide in faith, the enemy will crush us with circumstances. We must ward off doubt and fear with our shield.

Take up the sword of the Spirit, the **Word**. We must be in the Word daily. It is an offensive as well as a defensive weapon. All of the rest of the armor protects us. If we are going to move forward, though, we must be able to attack. The Word is our sword. It must be in our heart and in our mouth **[Deut. 30:14]**.

And finally, pray in the **spirit** continuously. We must sow to the spirit, not the flesh **[Romans 8:5]**. Praying in the spirit is like our field phone. It keeps us in constant contact with the Commander-in-Chief for instructions.

Other Assets Given to Us in Battle

Other assets have been given to us in the battle with the enemy. We have the **authority** of the name of Jesus. Before His ascension Jesus said that all authority in heaven and on earth had been given unto Him **[Matthew 28:18]**. He has told us that He will do whatever we ask in His name **[John 14:13]**. He has given us authority in His name that whatever we bind [to forbid, prohibit, declare to be illicit] and loose on earth shall be bound and loosed in heaven **[Matthew 18:18]**. We who abide in Him have the authority of the Name above all names.

He has also given us the power of His **blood**. The victory over Satan was won by the shedding of Jesus' blood **[Hebrews 9:22,26; Revelation 12:11]**. Once we have received Jesus as our Lord and Savior, the power of His blood is at work in our lives. The blood of Jesus was shed for the redemption of mankind, not for things or for animals. Because we are covenant partners with God, we have the protection of the Lord over the things we possess. **Job 1:10** speaks of the hedge of protection God keeps around those who are in covenant with Him. In **John 17:11**, Jesus asked the Father for protection for us. We can call on that protection for our animals and our possessions anytime in the name of Jesus. The blood of Jesus, however, was shed just for people.

We have also been given the power of praise. The Lord **inhabits** the praises of His people **[Psalm 22:3]** and He has ordained praise to silence the enemy **[Psalm 8:2 NIV]**. Praise God frequently in your prayer time and throughout the day. It is a powerful weapon and He is worthy of our praises.

PERSONAL EXAMPLES

E. We Have the Advantage of Weapons.

1. Our Weapons.
   a. *"For the weapons of our warfare are not carnal but mighty in God for pulling down strongholds, casting down arguments and every high thing that exalts itself against the knowledge of God bringing every thought into captivity to the obedience of Christ, and being ready to punish all disobedience when your obedience is fulfilled."* **[2 Corinthians 10:4-6 NKJV]**
      1) Although we are human, we do not fight with **human** weapons.
      2) Our weapons are empowered of God and are supernatural in nature.
         a) **Deuteronomy 33:27**
         b) **Zechariah 4:6**
      3) God's plan is for us to overcome the enemy because He has overcome him.
         a) **John 16:33**
         b) **1 John 4:4**
         c) **Romans 16:20**
   b. Our victory does not depend upon our own ability.
2. Enemy's Weapons.
   a. Enemy wages war on the saints. **[Revelation 19:19]**
      1) War is continuous.
      2) He is dedicated to our destruction. **[John 10:10]**
   b. Weapons are **limited**.
   c. *"No temptation has overtaken you except such as is common to man; but God is faithful, who will not allow you to be tempted beyond what you are able, but with the temptation will also make the way of escape, that you may be able to bear it."* **[1 Corinthians.10:13 NKJV]**
      1) Enemy's weapons are common to man (carnal).
      2) They are limited in power.
      3) God has promised a way out with each one (easily defensible).
   d. Appeals to the flesh.
      1) **Romans 8:5,6**
      2) **Galatians 5:19-21**
      3) **Galatians 6:8**
   e. Creates strife and division.
      1) **James 3:16**
      2) **James 4:1-3**
3. Stay in the spirit when fighting the enemy.
   a. Our weapons are stronger in the spirit; we always win.
   b. Our enemy is craftier in the flesh; he has the upper hand there.
4. With superior weapons and the protection of God, why do we fail?

F. Vigilance.

1. Must be self-controlled and alert. **[1 Peter 5:8 NIV]**
2. As a one-flesh team, patrol your hedge daily. **[Job 1:10]**
   a. Must check for enemy entrances.
   b. Know the condition of all that God has entrusted. **[Proverbs 27:23 NIV]**
3. Two types of battle.
   a. Defensive.
      1) Regaining territory.
      2) The purpose of battle is not survival, it is **possession**.

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We Have the Advantage of Weapons

We have the advantage over the enemy when it comes to weapons. Although we are human, we do not fight with **human** weapons. *"For the weapons of our warfare are not carnal but mighty in God for pulling down strongholds, casting down arguments and every high thing that exalts itself against the knowledge of God, bringing every thought into captivity to the obedience of Christ, and being ready to punish all disobedience when your obedience is fulfilled"* **[2 Corinthians 10:4-6]**. The weapons that God has given us are empowered by Him. They are supernatural in nature **[Deuteronomy 33:27, Zechariah 4:6]**.

God's plan is for us to overcome the enemy because He has overcome him **[John 16:33, 1 John 4:4; Romans 16:20]**. Our victory does not depend on our own ability.

Although enemy forces wage war on the saints **[Revelation 19:19]** and are dedicated to our destruction **[John 10:10]**, their weapons are limited. *"No temptation has overtaken you except such as is common to man; but God is faithful, who will not allow you to be tempted beyond what you are able, but with the temptation will also make the way of escape, that you may be able to bear it."* **[1 Corinthians 10:13 NKJV]** This scripture assures us that the weapons of the enemy are carnal [common to man], **limited** in power, and that with each attack we are assured an escape if we rely on the Lord. The enemy's weapons always appeal to our flesh **[Romans 8:5,6; Gal 5:19-21 and 6:8]**. His weapons create strife and division **[James 3:16 and 4:1-3]**. Stay in the spirit when fighting the enemy. We will always defeat him if we stay in the spirit. Our weapons are stronger there. We will always lose with the enemy if we get in the flesh. He has greater experience with the flesh than we do.

If our weapons are more powerful than the enemy's, why then do we fall victim to enemy attack?

Vigilance

For one thing, we must be vigilant. **1 Peter 5:8** says, *"Be self-controlled and alert. Your enemy the devil prowls around like a lion looking for someone to devour"* (NIV). As a one-flesh couple, we must patrol our hedge daily **[Job 1:10]**. Check to see if there are any holes in it to give the enemy entrance. Heed the warning of **Proverbs 27:23**, *"Be sure you know the condition of your flocks, give careful attention to your herds"* (NIV). Do you seek the Lord daily as one-flesh for your spouse and children? Do you ask the Lord for discernment regarding enemy activities? Husband and wife should take some specific time weekly to cover all individual and family activities. Radar, get cranked up and, warrior, be on the alert.

There are two types of battles we must fight, defensive and offensive. For those skirmishes that we are already in the midst of, a defensive battle is necessary. Use the weapons God has given to drive out the enemy and regain the territory. This is critical. We once heard it said, "The purpose of battle is not survival, it is **possession**." Even our defensive battles should claim territory.

PERSONAL EXAMPLES

b. Learn to fight an **offensive** **battle**.
   1) Spy out the Land **[Numbers 13:17]**.
   2) Intercede to know the enemy's plans ahead of time.

4. Recognizing the enemy **[1 John 4:1 KJV]**.
   a. **Test** the spirits.
   b. Check out what is coming your way.

G. Enemy Identification.

1. Enemy is not our:
   a. Spouse.
   b. Children.
   c. Brothers and sisters in the Lord/Boss/Etc.
2. The enemy has highly organized forces opposing the army of God.
   a. *"For we wrestle not against flesh and blood, but against principalities, against powers, against the rulers of the darkness of this world, against spiritual wickedness in high places"* **[Ephesians 6:12 KJV]**
      1) Principalities.
         a) Greek = arche.
         b) Means "chief ranking."
         c) Those in highest authority in Satan's forces.
      2) Powers.
         a) Greek = exousia.
         b) Means "delegated authority" or "jurisdiction."
         c) Demonic forces given power over certain portions of the earth.
      3) Rulers.
         a) Greek = kosmokrator.
         b) Means "ruler in this world."
         c) Demons assigned to influence world rulers.
      4) Spiritual wickedness.
         a) Greek = poneria.
         b) Means "depravity".
         c) Lowest ranking and most numerous of demonic forces.
   b. Ask the Holy Spirit for discernment when you wage spiritual warfare.
      1) Is it spiritual wickedness or are you up against one of the rulers or powers?
      2) Is it something just affecting your family or are you battling a ruling spirit over your part of the nation?
      3) Get specific by the Holy Spirit's direction and target the correct source of demonic activity.

H. One-Flesh Team Warfare.

1. Don't allow the enemy to divide the two of you.
   a. Your unity is the key to successful spiritual warfare.
   b. Ask the Holy Spirit to teach you how to flow together.
   c. Your strength is **multiplied**.
2. Synergistic power. *"Five of you shall chase a hundred, and a hundred of you shall put ten thousand to flight; your enemies shall fall before you by the sword"* **[Leviticus 26:8]**.
   a. Your power increases exponentially.
   b. It is well worth the time and effort it takes to discover the synergistic power of spiritual warfare.

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It is just as critical, though, to learn to fight an **offensive** battle. *"Spy out the land"* that lies ahead **[Numbers 13:17]**. Don't just pray for today, go on ahead in prayer to cover future events. For example, are you interceding for protection for your children? Are you praying about business transactions? Don't wait until you're in the midst of a problem and pray your way out. Seek the counsel of God before you ever get to that point.

An offensive battle is so much easier to fight. You will have the upper hand when you intercede in order to know the enemy's plans ahead of time. Learn to recognize and to know your enemy. Learn to **test** the spirits. *"Beloved, believe not every spirit, but try the spirits whether they are of God"* **[1 John 4:1 KJV]**. We have been given the spiritual ability to detect the enemy.

Enemy Identification

We need to know what we are fighting. Satan and his forces are good at diversionary tactics and many times they convince us that our enemy is our spouse, our children, our boss, or our brothers and sisters in Christ. This keeps us busy fighting each other and gives the enemy free reign in our lives.

When fighting the enemy, many times we "shotgun" our prayers when we should have the exact target identified and hit it directly. **Ephesians 6:12** thoroughly identifies and ranks the enemy forces for us.

First there are the "principalities," from the Greek word *"arche,"* which means "chief ranking." These are the highest ranking of enemy forces.

The next, "powers," comes from the Greek word *"exousia,"* meaning "delegated authority" or "jurisdiction." They are in charge of a certain portion of the earth.

Then we have "rulers" from the Greek word *"kosmokrator"* or "ruler in this world. These are demons assigned to influence world rulers.

And finally, "spiritual wickedness," coming from the Greek *"poneria,"* meaning "depravity," is the lowest ranking, but the most numerous of Satanic forces.

When we are in warfare we need to ask the Holy Spirit for discernment. Are we fighting the effect of spiritual wickedness or are we up against one of the rulers or powers? Many times we are battling something we think just affects our family when in fact it is a ruling spirit over our country or portion of the country and is influencing all families around us. Begin to get specific in your prayer time. Allow the Holy Spirit to paint the bull's eye so that your prayers are directed toward the target.

One-Flesh Team Warfare

Begin approaching spiritual warfare as a powerful one-flesh team. Your strength is **multiplied** and results are achieved much more quickly. Do not allow the enemy to divide the two of you. Your unity is the key to successful spiritual warfare for your home and family. Ask the Holy Spirit to begin teaching you how to flow together as one in warfare. Remember, your power is multiplied exponentially when you work together **[Leviticus 26:8]**. The results you will achieve are well worth the time and effort it will take to discover the power of synergistic spiritual warfare.

PERSONAL EXAMPLES

Life Application - Let's make it real

1. Begin to see your home as a fort, fortified and protected against enemy attack. Think of some of the ways the enemy gains access inside that fort.

What can you do as a one-flesh team to prevent that entrance?

2. As you remind yourselves daily that you are wearing the armor of God, use the following checklist to reinforce the purpose of each piece of equipment.

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	MON	TUES	WED	THUR	FRI	SAT	SUN
HELMET							
BREASTPLATE							
BELT							
SHOES							
SWORD							
SHIELD							
PRAYER							

3. As part of your offensive warfare, once a week husband and wife should "patrol your hedge" and cover in prayer both the individual and family activities for the coming week. As you do that this week, record here what discernment the Holy Spirit gives you regarding enemy activity.

ACTIVITY	DISCERNMENT

How did you respond to the discernment of the Holy Spirit?

On the following pages you will find "incident reports" on which to record both offensive and defensive warfare encounters with the enemy. On each one record what the conflict involved; what enemy source you identified; and what action you took, including the weapons you used. This will aid you in keeping track of your spiritual warfare. Were you surprised by the attack? Did you have prior warning? Had the enemy attacked in this way before? Did you identify the hole in your hedge that allowed enemy entrance?

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INCIDENT REPORT

DATE:

DESCRIPTION OF INCIDENT:

ENEMY IDENTIFIED:

ACTION TAKEN (INCLUDE DESCRIPTION OF WEAPONS USED):

WHAT YOU LEARNED AS A ONE-FLESH TEAM FROM THIS INCIDENT:

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INCIDENT REPORT

DATE:

DESCRIPTION OF INCIDENT:

ENEMY IDENTIFIED:

ACTION TAKEN (INCLUDE DESCRIPTION OF WEAPONS USED):

WHAT YOU LEARNED AS A ONE-FLESH TEAM FROM THIS INCIDENT:

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INCIDENT REPORT

DATE:

DESCRIPTION OF INCIDENT:

ENEMY IDENTIFIED:

ACTION TAKEN (INCLUDE DESCRIPTION OF WEAPONS USED):

WHAT YOU LEARNED AS A ONE-FLESH TEAM FROM THIS INCIDENT:

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Week 11

The Power of Transformation

WEEKLY PRAYER FOCUS

When the Coaching Team Meets to Pray

WEEK 11 - THE POWER OF TRANSFORMATION

GOAL: To aid couples in coordinating all of the tools they have received in Married for Life to continue growing in their marriage as God intends, to express the importance of ridding their marriage of hidden sin, and to give them a blueprint upon which they can build their powerhouse home.

INSTRUCTION: At the close of the lesson make sure you return the couples to the vision of the powerhouse homes that God is calling forth. Remind them of what they started out to accomplish

PRAYER FOCUS: Continue to hold up the Graduation Night. Pray for God's perfect will for each couple regarding their next step. Pray that your couples are forming new patterns of generosity in their financial giving.

Coaching Team:

Personal Prayer Needs _____

_____

_____

_____

_____

Ministry Prayer Needs _____

_____

_____

_____

_____

_____

Notes from Prayer Time:

Praise Reports:

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WEEKLY COACHING TIPS

Graduation

WELCOME

Make sure guests are greeted and made to feel welcome.

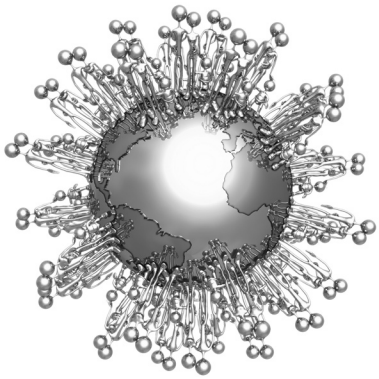
PRAYER

Open with a short prayer.

PRAISE AND WORSHIP

This should be simple and just a couple songs. Be sensitive to your audience.

VISION OF ***2=1***



Suggested sharing: Strong homes make a strong community. Families today face complex problems that often keep them from developing strong homes. ***2=1's*** mission is to help couples build a healthy marriage through teachng and coaching so that their family can be strong. We want to help you have a strong, healthy marriage and family so that you can fulfill your destiny.

The Married for Life course is not a magical answer. Attending a class requires that a couple be willing to work on their relationship daily. It is not always easy but we believe that the truths contained in this course will transform any marriage no matter how "good" or "bad" it is to begin with.

2=1 Coaching Couples are ministering to marriages and families around the world, in over 90 nations and 41 languages.

COUPLES SHARE THEIR STORIES

Have your couples share what has happened in their relationship as a result of the class.

CLASS PROTOCOL

Explain how the MFL course works: the course length and content, what a couple can expect each week, what commitment is required, etc.

OPPORTUNITY TO GIVE

Give couples an opportunity to contribute to the international outreach of 2=1. Their contributions make it possible to reach more marriages and families around the world.

QUESTIONS AND ANSWERS

Give your audience an opportunity to ask questions.

MINISTRY

Take time to minister to any couples requesting help.

REGISTRATION

Conclude the meeting, break for refreshments, and open the registration table for those couples wishing to register. Make sure that each couple registering gets a receipt and a copy of "Why Are You Married?".

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A. Homes Of Power.

1. God gave a vision of millions of twinkling lights around the world.
    a. Powerhouse Christian homes, one on every block of every city of every nation.
    b. God wants to use us to change our **neighborhoods**, our churches, our communities.
    c. We must yield to the inner work of the Holy Spirit in our lives.
    d. We must understand how His power is to flow out of us.
2. "The light that shines the farthest shines the brightest at home."
    a. There must be no darkness between us for that light to shine its brightest to others **[Romans 13:12]**.
    b. The Holy Spirit works within us, transforming our hearts, and builds our character.
    c. We confess our sins
        1) Make sure there is no **darkness** between us.
        2) The light and power of God shine forth in our lives and from our homes.
3. For our lives and our homes to reflect the power God has given us,
    a. We must be willing to grow and change as He directs.
    b. This lesson will cover several aspects of that growth and change.

B. Examine our life patterns—the way we live.

1. Define life patterns
    a. Ways of thinking and acting shaped within us throughout our life.
    b. Sometimes we form our own.
    c. Sometimes they are handed down through generations.
2. Pattern is sometimes difficult to see.
    a. They need to be pointed out to us.
    b. Do you know what this says?



    c. In order to see, we must see light against the dark background.
    d. Once we have recognized what is written, we have no problem seeing it again.
    e. Life patterns are the same way
        1) **1 John 1:5** that God is **light** and in Him is no darkness at all.
        2) We need to begin seeing things as God sees them.
3. God's Word is the blueprint.
    a. We must compare our lives to the Word.
        1) Life patterns that match up are godly.
            a) Recognize these—often you are not aware.
            b) Know the Biblical principles you are following.
            c) Share them with other marriages.
        2) Life patterns conforming to God's Word are godly.
            a) Being aware of what God's Word says helps us recognize ungodly patterns **[1 John 2:20,21]**.
            b) Scriptural principles are tools to change ungodly life patterns.
    b. See if ungodly life patterns are generational.

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Homes Of Power

Years ago God gave a vision of millions of twinkling lights around the world, powerhouse Christian homes, one on every block of every city of every nation. God wants to use us to change our **neighborhoods**, our churches, our communities. To walk in that kind of power we must be yielded to the inner work of the Holy Spirit in our lives and understand how His power is to flow out of us.

Someone once said, "The light that shines the farthest shines the brightest at home." There must be no darkness between us for that light to shine its brightest to others **[Romans 13:12]**. As the Holy Spirit works within us, He transforms our hearts and builds our character. As we confess our sins and make sure there is no **darkness** between us, the light and power of God shine forth in our lives and from our homes. For our lives and our homes to reflect the power God has given us, we must be willing to grow and change as He directs. This lesson will cover several aspects of that growth and change.

Life Patterns

First, we must become aware of the way we live. Life patterns are ways of thinking and acting that have been shaped within us throughout our life. Sometimes we have formed our own and at other times they have been handed down from generation to generation. Sometimes patterns in our lives are hard to see. They are so much a part of us that we fail to recognize them until someone points them out. What do you see written here?



In order to see it, you must read light against dark. Once you realize what it says, you have no problem recognizing it again. Life patterns are the same way. We are told in **1 John 1:5** that God is **light** and in Him is no darkness at all. We need to begin seeing things as God sees them.

God's Word is the blueprint that shows us how to live. We must constantly compare our lives to His Word. All life patterns that match up with God's desires for us are godly. Make sure you recognize those and don't just concentrate on the negative. Many times couples have been living godly principles but have not been aware of it. If this is your case, you now know the Biblical principles that you have followed and you can share these principles with other marriages.

Any life pattern contrary to God's plan for us is ungodly. As we become more and more aware of what God's Word says, we recognize ungodly patterns more readily **[1 John 2:20,21]**. Scriptural principles in the Word of God are tools that will help change ungodly life patterns.

As you begin to see ungodly life patterns in your life, check if they are generational. An example of a generational pattern of deceit was found in Abraham and his descendants. Abraham lied about Sarah being his sister instead of his wife. Then Isaac, his son, lied about his wife being his sister. Then Isaac's son, Jacob, deceived his father in order to obtain his brother's blessing. Jacob's sons, in turn, sold their brother Joseph into slavery and claimed he had been killed. Ask the Holy Spirit to help you identify

PERSONAL EXAMPLES

1) Example: Abraham lied about Sarah being his sister instead of his wife. Isaac, his son, lied about his wife being his sister. Isaac's son, Jacob, deceived his father in order to obtain his brother's blessing. Jacob's sons, in turn, sold their brother Joseph into slavery and claimed he had been killed.

2) Ask the Holy Spirit to help you identify ungodly generational influences.

a) Take **authority** over those influences in Jesus' name.

b) Break their hold on your family **[Lev 26:40-42; 1 Peter 1:18,19]**.

Interactive

Take a few minutes now and see if you recognize any patterns in your generational lineage. Ask the Lord to help you to continue to identify those influences.

(Time three minutes and then resume the lesson)

C. Repentance

1. We are to be the light of the world **[Matthew 5:14 and 16]**.
   a. To shine brightly we must have no hidden **sin** in our lives **[Ephesians 5:8-11].**
      1) It causes us to put our light under a basket **[Matthew 5:15]**.
      2) Sin is contrary to our relationship with God **[Romans 6:11]**.
      3) Jesus redeemed our marriages back to what Adam and Eve had.
   b. In order to shine, we must **repent** (turn away from) all sin in our lives.
      1) *"If we confess our sins, He is faithful and just to forgive us our sins and to cleanse us from all unrighteousness"* **[1 John 1:9]**.
      2) Repentance breaks the cycle of sin patterns.
2. Repent of ongoing sin.
   a. Includes all hidden sin, and any private sin that no one knows about.
   b. Areas you just can't seem to get victory **[Mark 4:22]**.
   c. His grace enables us to overcome areas of sin in our lives.
3. Repent of all past sin that you are justifying or have chosen to ignore.
   a. Highly sensitive areas that we fear others may discover.
   b. God is not going to miraculously take sin out of our lives.
   c. He gives us strength to resist the enemy when we submit ourselves to Him **[James 4:7]**.
4. Repent of sin God has convicted you of during the past weeks.
   a. If we defend our sin, it keeps its hold over us.
   b. God wants us free **[Galatians 5:1]**.
   c. Allow Him to help you deal with it.
5. Freedom is exposing any hidden sin between spouses **[James 5:16].**
   a. When we hide sin from our spouse, we cannot be naked and unashamed.
   b. It affects our spouse, our family, and other members of the Body of Christ.
   c. We may be hesitant due to fear of wounding our spouse.
      1) Your spouse was wounded when the sin was committed.
      2) Nothing one spouse can do that does not affect the other.
         a) There is no "private" sin any more.
         b) All sin between spouses be confessed and forgiven.

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any ungodly generational influences that may be in operation. Take **authority** over those influences in Jesus' name and break their hold on your family **[Lev 26:40-42; 1 Peter 1:18,19]**.

Interactive

Take a few minutes now and see if you recognize any patterns in your generational lineage. Ask the Lord to help you to continue to identify those influences.

(Time three minutes and then resume the lesson)

Repentance

We are to be the light of the world **[Matthew 5:14 and 16]**. Jesus is to shine through us so that the world can see Him in us. For our homes to shine brightly to others, we have no hidden **sin** in our own lives **[Ephesians 5:8-11]**. If there is sin (darkness) in our lives, it causes us to put our light under a basket **[Matthew 5:15]**. Sin is contrary to our relationship with God **[Romans 6:11]**. Remember that Jesus redeemed our marriages back to what Adam and Eve had in their marriage. We do not have to live in the pattern of sinful man.

In order for His light to clearly shine, we must **repent** (turn away from) all sin in our lives *"If we confess our sins, He is faithful and just to forgive us our sins and to cleanse us from all unrighteousness"* **[1 John 1:9]**. Repentance breaks the cycle of sin patterns.

Repent from all ongoing sin. This includes all hidden sin, and any private sin that no one knows about or areas you just can't seem to get victory **[Mark 4:22]**. It is His grace at work within us that enables us to overcome areas of sin in our lives.

Repent of all past sin that you are justifying or have chosen to ignore. These are usually highly sensitive areas that we fear others may discover. God is not going to miraculously take sin out of our lives, but He is going to give us the strength to resist the enemy when we submit ourselves to Him **[James 4:7]**.

Repent of anything that God has convicted you of during the past weeks. If we choose to defend our sin, it will keep its hold on us. God wants us to walk totally free in every area of our lives **[Galatians 5:1]**. If He has shown you something during the past weeks, allow Him to help you deal with it.

The next step in getting completely free is to expose any hidden sin between spouses **[James 5:16]**. When we are hiding sin from our spouse, we cannot be naked and unashamed before each other. It affects our spouse, our family, and other members of the Body of Christ. You may hesitate to disclose sin because you fear it will wound your spouse, but, in reality, your spouse was wounded when the sin was committed. There is nothing one spouse can do that does not affect the other. We are one. There is no "private" sin any more. It is imperative that all sin between spouses be confessed and forgiven.

d. Do not dump your confession of sin on your spouse.
   1) Pray for God's **timing**.
   2) Pray for your spouse's heart to be prepared to receive.
   3) Be led by the Holy Spirit.
e. Do not try to pry it out of your spouse.
   1) Allow Jesus to break down the dividing wall between you **[Ephesians 2:14,15]**.

6. The purpose of confessing sin and praying for one another is to be **healed [James 5:16]**.
   a. Once confessed, allow the Holy Spirit time for comfort and healing.
   b. ***Both*** spouses must be led by the Holy Spirit.
      1) Confessing spouse feels relieved to "get it off their chest."
         a) Just the beginning of the healing process.
         b) To sin you had to harden your heart—to heal you need to soften your heart.
         c) Allow emotions and crying.
         d) Emotions a necessary part of healing.
         e) Do not reject your spouse.
      2) If you are hearing your spouse's confession, give Holy Spirit time to heal your heart.
         a) Don't wallow in self-pity or manipulate with emotions.
         b) Forgive: remember, it's a **decision**, not a feeling.
   c. Both spouses need to forgive relatives who have perpetuated generational sin.
   d. Healing is faster when hearts are open and honest.
7. Unite together over your point of wounding.
   a. Sin has two-sided consequences. (Example: Adultery: Sinner faces temptation, spouse faces rejection.)
      1) Share when you are facing temptation.
      2) Do not take offense, but protect your spouse in the spirit.
   b. Allow spouse to express when troubled by rejection.
      1) Do not criticize or preach; lock your shields together over the point of woundng.
      2) Don't allow the devil to **divide** and conquer.
8. Be quick to repent, no matter how small it seems.
   a. Be open and honest with each other, transparent before each other.
      1) God forgives us quickly when we repent.
      2) Live a life of quick repentance and forgiveness.
9. Obedience is key to establishing and maintaining godly life patterns.
      1) The faster we obey His direction, the more clearly we will hear Him.
      2) When we miss His direction, we need to repent and receive His forgiveness.
      3) God doesn't have a Plan B.
         a) When we repent, He turns His new direction for us into Plan A.
         b) He is 100% for us even if we have missed the mark in the past.

D. The Work of the Holy Spirit.

1. *"Nevertheless I tell you the truth. It is to your advantage that I go away; for if I do not go away, the Helper (the Holy Spirit) will not come to you; but if I depart, I will send Him to you"* **[John 16:7]**.

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Do not just dump your confession on your spouse. Pray for God's **timing**. Pray for your spouse's heart to be prepared to receive. Be led by the Holy Spirit. He will tell you when and how to confess your sin to each other. Do not try to pry it out of your spouse either. It is Jesus who is breaking down the dividing wall between you and making you one **[Ephesians 2:14,15]**. Allow Him to do the work.

James 5:16 gives the reason for confessing sin and praying for one another, *"...so that you may be* **healed**." Once you have confessed your sin, allow the Holy Spirit time for comforting and healing. ***Both*** spouses must be led by the Holy Spirit in order for healing to be completed.

The one confessing sin usually feels relieved to "get it off their chest," but it is just the beginning of the healing process. You had to harden your heart against your spouse to sin against him or her. Your time of healing is a heart-softening time. Allow emotions. They are a necessary part of healing. Do not reject your spouse for crying or sharing deep emotion.

If you are the spouse hearing the confession of sin, allow the Holy Spirit time to complete the healing of your heart. Do not wallow in self-pity or use emotions as manipulation. Forgiveness is key to healing. Remember that forgiveness is not an emotion, it is a **decision**. Choose to forgive your spouse. Choose to forgive relatives who have perpetuated generational sin. Keep your heart open and honest before God, and your healing will be accomplished much faster.

As you both begin to heal, stand united together over the point of wounding. Every sin has two-sided consequences. For example, if adultery was the sin, both spouses must be able to express when the enemy is trying to attack again. If your spouse was in adultery, allow him or her to share with you when lust is a temptation. Do not take offense, but lock your shields together and protect your spouse in the spirit. If you were the one in adultery, allow your spouse to express when he or she is troubled by rejection. Do not criticize or preach; lock your shields together over the point of wounding and protect your spouse. Remember, it was an attack against your one-flesh. It still is. Don't allow the devil to **divide** and conquer.

Be quick to repent when you sin, no matter how small it seems. A traffic ticket can become a major source of trouble if hidden. Be open and honest with each other, transparent before each other, naked and unashamed. God forgives us quickly when we repent. As spouses, we do not have greater rights than God. Repentance and forgiveness should be quick.

Obedience is key to establishing and maintaining godly life patterns. The faster we obey His direction, the more clearly we will hear Him. When we miss His direction and do our own thing, we need to repent and receive His forgiveness. God doesn't have a Plan B. When we repent of our sin, He always turns His new direction for us into Plan A. He is 100% for us even if we have missed the mark in the past.

The Work of the Holy Spirit

Before He returned to His Father, Jesus told His disciples, *"Nevertheless I tell you the truth. It is to your advantage that I go away; for if I do not go away, the Helper (the Holy Spirit) will not come to you; but if I depart, I will send Him to you"* **[John 16:7]**.

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2. Holy Spirit is a distinct personality of the Godhead.
    a. Receive Him when we are born-again **[John 20:21].**
    b. Are filled with power when we are baptized in Him **[Acts 1:8]**.
    c. Sealed with Him **[Eph. 1:13].**
    d. He guarantees our inheritance **[Eph. 1:14]**.
    e. He indwells us **[1 Cor. 6:19; 2 Tim. 1:14]**,
    f. He teaches us all things **[John 14:26]**,
    g. He regenerates and renews us **[Titus 3:5]**.
3. Constant battle within us between our flesh (wants its own way) and Holy Spirit (wants to produce spiritual **fruit**).
    a. Like us, Jesus was tempted in 3 areas **[1 John 2:16]**.
    b. As Jesus was filled with the Holy Spirit, He was empowered to resist temptation.
    c. Likewise, the Holy Spirit empowers us to resist temptation.
    d. His power transforms our hearts and produces mature spiritual fruit in our lives.
        1) *"But the fruit of the Spirit is love, joy, peace, patience, kindness, goodness, faithfulness, gentleness and self-control. Against such things there is no law."* **[Galatians 5:22-23NIV]**.
        2) Our maturity is measured by the degree to which we have **yielded** to the work of the Holy Spirit within.
            a) We do not have to struggle to produce fruit.
            b) Simply obey as he deals with us.
4. Marriage is the best earthly relationship for character development.
    a. Often look elsewhere to improve our relationships.
    b. Need to look with the Holy Spirit's help at our own **heart**.
    c. Our spouse helps us see our character weaknesses.
        1) We run from things in our relationship that the Holy Spirit can best use to mature us.
        2) Easy to walk with the Holy Spirit in casual relationships.
        3) Our relationship with our spouse exposes the true fruit of the Holy Spirit in our lives.
        4) We must yield our reactions and desires to the Holy Spirit for transformation; willpower cannot do it.
        5) The Holy Spirit, our comforter and helper desires to work with us.

E. Moving in the Power of the Holy Spirit

1. The Holy Spirit then wants to work through us in power.
    a. *"But you shall receive power when the Holy Spirit has come upon you; and you shall be witnesses to Me in Jerusalem, and in all Judea and Samaria, and to the end of the earth"* **[Acts 1:8].**
    b. For our Homes to reach out to the world--we need the **power** of the Holy Spirit.
    c. Signs of the Holy Spirit
        1) *"These signs shall follow those who believe. In my name they will cast out demons, they will speak with new tongues, ...they will lay hands on the sick and they will recover"* **[Mark 16:15-20]**.
        2) As a believer these signs should follow you
    d. Gifts of the Spirit

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The Holy Spirit is not a thing, He is a distinct personality of the Godhead. We receive the Holy Spirit when we are born-again **[John 20:21]** and are filled with power when we are baptized in Him **[Acts 1:8]**.

We were sealed with Him **[Eph. 1:13]** and He is the guarantee of our inheritance **[Eph. 1:14]**.

He indwells us **[1 Cor. 6:19; 2 Tim. 1:14]**, teaches us all things **[John 14:26]**, and regenerates and renews us **[Titus 3:5]**.

A constant battle wars within us between our flesh that wants its own way, and the Holy Spirit working to produce spiritual **fruit**. *"For all that is in the world—the lust of the flesh, the lust of the eyes, and the pride of life—is not of the Father but is of the world"* **[1 John 2:16]**.

Jesus was tempted in all three of these areas when He returned from the wilderness filled with the Holy Spirit. The same Holy Spirit that empowered Jesus to resist the desires of the flesh, empowers us in the very same way.

The power of the Holy Spirit within us transforms our hearts and produces spiritual fruit in our lives.

"But the fruit of the Spirit is love, joy, peace, patience, kindness, goodness, faithfulness, gentleness and self-control. Against such things there is no law." **[Galatians 5:22-23NIV]**. The goal of the Holy Spirit is to produce mature spiritual fruit within us. We know that in nature mature, ripe fruit is sweeter and more desirable than immature fruit.

The same is true in the spiritual realm. Our maturity is measured by the degree to which we have **yielded** to the work of the Spirit within us. We do not have to struggle to produce the fruit of the Spirit any more than an apple tree has to struggle to produce apples. We just need to obey as He deals with our hearts.

Marriage affords us the best relationship on earth for character development. Often as husband and wife we look to someone or something that will improve our marital relationship, yet the Lord consistently tells us that we must each look to our own **heart**.

Our spouse can, like no one, help us see character weaknesses in our lives. The very circumstances that we seek to run from are what the Holy Spirit is using to mature His fruit within us. It is easy to walk in the fruit of the Spirit for short periods of time with casual relationships, those whom we do not see very often.

If the fruit of the Spirit is not developed in our lives, though, it becomes apparent when we relate to the one who knows us best, our spouse. We must yield our fleshly reactions and desires and allow the Holy Spirit to transform our hearts and minds. There is no way sheer willpower can do this. It is a supernatural work of our Comforter and Helper, the Holy Spirit.

Moving in the Power of the Holy Spirit

Not only does the Holy Spirit desire to work within us, but He wants to also move through us in power and might. Jesus said, *"But you shall receive power when the Holy Spirit has come upon you; and you shall be witnesses to Me in Jerusalem, and in all Judea and Samaria, and to the end of the earth"* **[Acts 1:8].** In order for our homes to be a point of outreach to the world, we need the **power** of the Holy Spirit.

PERSONAL EXAMPLES

1) *"But the manifestation of the Spirit is given to each one for the profit of all: for to one is given the word of wisdom through the Spirit, to another the word of knowledge through the same Spirit, to another faith by the same Spirit, to another gifts of healings by the same Spirit, to another the working of miracles, to another prophecy, to another discerning of spirits, to another different kinds of tongues, to another the interpretation of tongues. But one and the same Spirit works all these things, distributing to each one individually as He wills"* **[1 Corinthians 12:7-11]**.

2) These gifts of the Holy Spirit provide supernatural ability to believers.

3) Our homes should be a non-threatening place to **encourage** moving in the power of the Spirit.

e. Holy Spirit gives guidance and encouragement

1) Record His words to you.

2) Expect healing and miracles in your home.

a) Not just "special" people of God.

b) Not just in a "religious" setting.

c) In your home through you and your family.

3) Often couples flow in gifts **together**.

4) Other time one flows in gift with spouse confirming.

5) The more you pray together, the more you experience the gifts flowing through you together.

F. Walking in His power.

1. **2 Corinthians 4:5,6** describes how our homes must be.
   a. *"It is not in ourselves that we boast, but in Jesus Christ."*
   b. Jesus shines His light through us, so that we might bring the glory of God to others.
   c. That is the whole point of discovering the power.
2. Seek the Word daily.
   a. Word provides way from darkness to light. **[Psalm 18:28; Job 12:22]**.
   b. Changing our lives is a lifetime project of the Word **[2 Timothy 3:16]**.
   c. Live the biblical principles you have received over the past weeks.
      1) **[Philippians 3:12-17]**.
      2) If still difficult, go back to the lesson and continue to work on the principle.
   d. Pray with and for your children
      1) Teach that God confirms His Word with signs and wonders **[Hebrews 2:4]**.
      2) Expect God to powerfully move in your family.
      3) You have discovered the power of God--now learn to share it.

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In **Mark 16:15-20**, we are told that, *"these signs shall follow those who believe. In my name they will cast out demons, they will speak with new tongues, ...they will lay hands on the sick and they will recover."* Do you believe? These signs should follow you then, not because of who you are, but because of who God is. If you are a child of God, it should be just as natural for you to flow in the power of the Spirit as it is for a fish to swim and a bird to fly **[2 Peter 1:3-4]**.

The nine gifts of the Spirit are found in **1 Corinthians 12:7-11**. *"But the manifestation of the Spirit is given to each one for the profit of all: for to one is given the word of wisdom through the Spirit, to another the word of knowledge through the same Spirit, to another faith by the same Spirit, to another gifts of healings by the same Spirit, to another the working of miracles, to another prophecy, to another discerning of spirits, to another different kinds of tongues, to another the interpretation of tongues. But one and the same Spirit works all these things, distributing to each one individually as He wills."*

These gifts of the Holy Spirit provide supernatural ability to believers. Begin to anticipate the power of God flowing through you.

Our homes offer a non-threatening place in which we may **encourage** each other as husband and wife to move in the power of the Spirit.

The Holy Spirit will give you guidance and encouragement. Keep a record of the words He gives you. Begin to expect healing and miracles right in your own home! They are not gifts reserved for "special" people of God. Far too often we have believed the gifts to be spectacular feats performed only in church or some other "religious" setting by somebody else. They are to manifest on a routine basis in our family lives also.

Often the Spirit will flow through you as a couple in the gifts **together**. Even when only one spouse operates in a gift, the other one is often given confirmation. As you spend more time in prayer together, and as you yield more and more to the work of the Spirit within you, you will begin to experience flowing more in the gifts together.

Walking in His Power

2 Corinthians 4:5,6 describes how our homes must be. *"It is not in ourselves that we boast, but in Jesus Christ."* Jesus shines His light through us, so that we might bring the knowledge of the glory of God to others. That is the whole point of discovering the power.

Seek God's Word daily for His desires for each of you and for your family. The Word sets the goal for us and provides the way for us to go from darkness to light **[Psalm 18:28; Job 12:22]**. Changing our lives to totally line up with the Word of God is a lifetime project **[2 Timothy 3:16]**.

It is important that you live each of the Biblical principles that you have received over the past weeks **[Philippians 3:12-17]**. If one or more of them is difficult for you, go back over that week and continue to work on it.

Pray together with your children. Teach them that God confirms His Word with signs and wonders **[Hebrews 2:4]**. Expect God to move powerfully in your family. You have not only discovered the power of God, but you are learning how to share it with others.

PERSONAL EXAMPLES

Life Application - Let's make it real

Before You Do Anything Else: If there is hidden sin in your life that you need to confess to your spouse, begin praying right now for the right timing in the Lord. This prayer need not be with your spouse right now. You should, however, give each other permission to confess sin as the Lord leads. Resolve right now to forgive when that sin is confessed. Set the stage for God to do a complete work between you, that there may be no darkness in your relationship. Then you can stand as Adam and Eve did, naked and unashamed before each other.

When one spouse confesses hidden sin to the other, take the necessary time for God to complete the healing. Allow the tears that are necessary for healing. Remember, Satan has already stolen from you and wounded your relationship. Don't give him further ground with strife and rejection of each other. Lock your shields together over the point of wounding and help protect each other against further attack. Do not let self-righteousness or self-pity take hold. This is a one-flesh problem—deal with it as such. Forgive each other as God has forgiven you. Do not place yourselves above God by refusing to forgive. Remember also that every sin has consequences for both spouses. Allow God to do a complete healing work in both of you. If hidden sexual sin has been confessed, go back to The Power of Spiritual Intimacy and make sure you cover all that is necessary for freedom and healing.

Once hidden sin has been exposed and healing has begun, see this as an opportunity to begin again with a clean slate. Old sin is forgiven and forgotten. Start anew in Jesus, building new life patterns from His Word.

"Do not call to mind the former things,
or ponder things of the past.
Behold I will do something new
now it will spring forth.
Will you not be aware of it?
I will make even a roadway in the
wilderness, rivers in the desert."
Isaiah 43:18,19

Ungodly life patterns create wildernesses and deserts in our marriages, areas that are dry and unfruitful. These are places where we have used the world's blueprint instead of the blueprint of the Word. God desires that something new spring forth in our lives. Through His Word He will make the roadway in the wilderness and the river in the desert of our marriage.

1. What are some life patterns the Holy Spirit has revealed to you that are operating in your own lives? Are they godly or ungodly? Give scripture to support your decision.

LIFE PATTERN	GODLY	UNGODLY	SCRIPTURE

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2. Now look at the life patterns that you have marked as ungodly. (If you don't have any, you're not being totally honest with yourselves.) What is God's pattern from His Word that would create a godly pattern for you? What would that godly pattern be?

SCRIPTURAL PATTERN FROM WORD	GODLY LIFE PATTERN CREATED

3. Now look at the godly patterns you have listed. (If you don't have any, you're not being totally honest with yourselves.) Praise the Lord that He has led you in these patterns, even if you have been unaware of it. Are there other godly patterns you want to establish?

4. Are there ungodly patterns that you see in your children that are a direct result of your actions? If so, share with them what you have learned and lead them in repentance.

5. If God has shown you that there are generational influences in operation, take authority over them in Jesus' name.

"Father, we thank you for showing us the generational patterns caused by these influences. We forgive any relatives who have wounded us because of these influences. We forgive each other for the times we have offended and hurt each other because of these influences. We release all who have offended us. Now in the mighty name of Jesus we take authority over the following generational influences. _____ _____(write them in here and name them out loud). We cancel these influences over us and over our children and on down through the generations. We repent of having judged the actions of relatives under these influences. We repent for the ungodly patterns we have operated in under these influences and we receive Your forgiveness and the cleansing of the blood of Jesus. Teach us now from Your Word the godly pattern You would have us walk in. Amen."

The Fruit of the Spirit

From the day we are born-again, the Holy Spirit begins developing the fruit of the Spirit within us. As He works, some character qualities are developed faster than others. Listed below are the nine character qualities which comprise the fruit of the Spirit.

Love—agape, God's unconditional love, not based on feelings **[1 John 3:16]**.

Joy—deeper than happiness, it is not dependant upon circumstances **[John 15:11]**.

Peace—more than absence of strife, it is security, safety and tranquility **[John 14:27]**.

Patience—endurance, steadfastness **[James 1:4]**.

Kindness—gentleness, integrity **[2 Samuel 22:36]**.

Goodness—uprightness of heart and life **[Romans 15:14]**.

Faithfulness—fidelity, one who can be relied upon, covenant keeping **[Psalm 119:90]**.

Gentleness—strength under Godly control **[Psalm 18:35]**.

Self-control—mastery of desires and passions **[Proverbs 25:28]**.

1. In the space below, record which of these character qualities you feel are the most matured in your life and give an example of how you saw this demonstrated recently.

HUSBAND

Character Quality	Example

WIFE

Character Quality	Example

2. Now list the character qualities that you feel are the least developed in your life. Scripture tells us, *"Walk in the Spirit, and you shall not fulfill the lust of the flesh. For the flesh lusts against the Spirit, and the Spirit against the flesh; and these are contrary to one another, so that you do not do the things that you wish"* **[Galatians 5:16,17]**. Beside each character quality below, list a way in which you can walk in the Spirit and not fulfill the desires of your flesh.

HUSBAND

Character Quality	Way of Walking in the Spirit and Denying My Flesh

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WIFE

Character Quality	Way of Walking in the Spirit and Denying My Flesh

3. Sometimes it is easier for others to see the development of spiritual fruit within us. Take time now to share with your spouse a character quality that you have seen developing within him or her as the Holy Spirit has worked in his or her life.

Moving in Power

1. **1 Corinthians 12:7** says, *"…to each one the manifestation of the Spirit is given for the common good"* (NIV). "To each one" means all who have received Jesus Christ as their Lord and Savior. No one is left out. Do you know the Holy Spirit desires to use you in the gifts to meet the needs of people around you? Be open to the Holy Spirit working through you in any gift that He chooses. Be obedient to His prompting and keep the need of the person or situation in mind. All too often we focus on self and wonder "how will I look" or "what will they think of me." Just be obedient to the Holy Spirit, Whose desire it is to meet a need and let go of all other concerns. Be open and teachable and willing to be used and the Holy Spirit will do the rest.

Our lives may not seem as spectacular as those we read about in scripture, but if we begin to take closer notice, we may see the gifts of the Spirit operating in our lives more than we had realized. Have either of you moved in the gifts of the Spirit? If so, which ones? What needs were met?

2. The Holy Spirit often desires to use us together as husband and wife operating in the gifts. Very often one spouse will get a witness in his or her spirit when the other spouse is about to move in a gift. Has this ever happened to you? Have you moved in the gifts together?

3. Our homes are one of the most important places in which we will observe the gifts in operation. Has anyone in your family been used of the Holy Spirit in a gift in your home? What need was met?

4. As your prayer time together increases in depth, you will begin to see the flow of the Holy Spirit manifesting more and more. If you are willing for the power of God to flow through you in your areas of influence, you will be surprised how He is going to flow through you.

Beginning this week, record every time you observe a gift in operation in your home, with your friends, at church, or wherever it occurs. Don't become discouraged if you don't see a large number at first; just become aware of them when you do see them.

GIFTS IN OPERATION	WHERE OBSERVED	NEED THAT WAS MET

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Week 12

The Power of One

WEEKLY PRAYER FOCUS

When the Coaching Team Meets to Pray

WEEK 12 - THE POWER OF ONE

GOAL: To challenge couples to give out of what they have received, to help them begin thinking about God's assignment for them.

INSTRUCTION: Present the lesson and challenge the couples that God has a plan for them. Encourage even the hurting couples to seek Him for it. Encourage couples to complete this week's Life Application by Graduation Night**. If you are planning anything special for them, tell them how to prepare.**

PRAYER FOCUS: Pray for each couple to hear their assignment clearly. Bind strife and every work of the enemy that would seek to keep them from hearing from God. Pray for couples to receive fully what the Lord has for them during the final meeting time of ministry.

Coaching Team:

Personal Prayer Needs _____

_____

_____

_____

_____

Ministry Prayer Needs _____

_____

_____

_____

_____

Notes from Prayer Time:

Praise Reports:

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WEEKLY COACHING TIPS

What Now?

If you would like to have a special follow-up evening to pray over your couples after they have completed the Life Application for this week, let them know now. Some Coaching Couples have a dinner, others do something special such as a foot-washing. Some pray over their couples in agreement with what God has shown them. Some just have couples share what the Lord spoke to them as they prayed about their call together. It is up to you.

As you approach the end of your class, you may find that many couples want to continue meeting together. There are several options to consider.

1. ***Periodic meetings with the class members***
   Continue to meet together as a group on a periodic basis. Dinners are a great way to touch base again. Couples may want to include their children. If so, consider a picnic or camp out or other activity that children would enjoy.

2. ***Meet together with alumni from other classes***
   You may want to get together with other alumni in citywide meetings. This affords an opportunity to meet other couples and broadens the scope of interaction.

3. ***Have statewide meetings periodically***
   This enables couples to meet others from around the state and even from other areas. These might be considered quarterly within your area.

4. ***Utilize other 2=1 materials and form discussion groups***
   Couples can purchase CDs, DVDs, and other teaching materials from ***2=1*** and begin their own discussion groups. This is a great way to reach out into their neighborhoods and families.

5. ***Couples who were born-again in the class and who have no home church, may want to consider joining a home church.***
   This will afford them the same close-knit atmosphere they have become accustomed to in the class and they may even continue on with other couples who were born-again during the class. There are house churches developing in neighborhoods across the nation.

A. God's Plan for Your Marriage.

1. God's Word never fails.
   a. The tools you have received will accomplish miraculous change in your marriage when applied correctly.
   b. God has not given you all this so that only your marriage be blessed.
      1) He has deposited much in you that could help others.
      2) It is His desire that you reach out and bless **others** **[John 15:16]**.
2. Bear Fruit and Multiply.
   a. Three times in Genesis 1, God speaks of bearing fruit with seed in it.
      1) **Genesis 1:11**; **Genesis 1:12**; **Genesis 1:29**.
   b. Two other times He speaks of bearing fruit and multiplying.
      1) **Genesis 1:22**; **Genesis 1:28**.
   c. God's plan from the beginning of creation is that we produce fruit with the seed of **reproducibility** in it.
      1) Fruit we produce is not only for our own lives but also for the lives of others into whom we sow.
      2) Fruit with seed in it will enable them to sow also.
3. The Three Seasons.
   a. *"This year you will eat what grows by itself, and the second year what springs from that. But in the third year sow and reap, plant vineyards and eat their fruit"* **[Isaiah 37:30]**.
   b. The First Season.
      1) The beginning of the Christian walk.
      2) We eat *"what grows by itself."*
      3) Self-focused season in which our goal is to receive spiritual feeding.
      4) As with a new-born baby, God intends for others to care for us and feed us from the Word.
      5) We receive what comes our way without much effort to seek specific feeding.
   c. The Second Season.
      1) We eat *"what springs from that."*
      2) A bit more selective, we begin seeking the Lord diligently regarding what church to attend and what teachings to receive.
      3) Still somewhat self-directed but may reach out to others.
      4) Can be compared to gleaning a field; there is plenty to eat but we must put forth some **effort** to receive it.
   d. The Third Season.
      1) We must *"sow and reap, plant vineyards and eat their fruit."*
      2) No longer is our feeding based solely on the labor of others.
      3) No longer are we able to passively expect others to care for us.
      4) We must now sow and reap in order to be fed.
   e. If fail to recognize the third season's requirements:
      1) Will make such comments as, "This pastor just doesn't feed me the way he used to," or "Christianity just seems boring to me."
         a) Pastor or anyone never again will feed us as they did in the first and second seasons.
         b) Now feeding depends on our own sowing and reaping.

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God's Plan for Your Marriage

God has richly blessed you these past twelve weeks with treasures from His Word to strengthen and solidify your marriage. His Word never fails. The tools He has given you will accomplish miraculous change in your marriage when you apply them as He directs.

You have not received all this, though, that only your marriage be blessed. He has deposited much in you that could help **others**. He has had a plan for your marriage from the day you were joined together and it is His will that your marriage, strong in Him, would reach out to others **[John 15:16]**. Scripture bears this out.

Three times in **Genesis 1**, God speaks of bearing fruit with seed in it **[Genesis 1:11,12 and 29]**. Two other times He speaks of bearing fruit and multiplying **[Genesis 1:22 and 28]**. From the beginning of creation this has been His plan. Each of us is to produce fruit with the seed of **reproducibility** in it. If the fruit we bear has seed in it, and if we sow that seed into the lives of others, they too will be able to produce fruit with seed in it to sow into the lives of others.

In **Isaiah 37:30**, God gave a word to King Hezekiah. *"This year you will eat what grows by itself, and the second year what springs from that. But in the third year sow and reap, plant vineyards and eat their fruit"* (NIV). This scripture contains within it some very important principles for Christian living.

In the beginning of our Christian walk, the first season, we spiritually eat *"what grows by itself."* This is a very self-centered season in which our focus is to receive feeding. Just as with a new-born baby, God intends for others to care for us and make sure we are fed from the Word of God. We do not give much thought to what church we should attend or what type of teaching or preaching we should absorb. Basically we receive anything that comes our way, without much effort on our own to seek specific feeding.

When the second season in our Christian walk arrives we eat *"what springs up from that."* In other words, this season is a bit more selective. During this time we settle into a home church, if we have not done so already, and begin to seek the Lord more diligently regarding what meetings to attend and what teachings to receive. This season is still somewhat self-directed, however, we may begin to reach out to others. The second season can be compared to gleaning a field after the harvesters have passed through. There is plenty to eat but we must put forth some **effort** to receive it.

The arrival of the third season, though, signals a rather drastic change. According to scripture we are to *"sow and reap, plant vineyards and eat their fruit."* No longer is our feeding based solely on the labor of others. No longer can we sit back passively and expect others to take care of us. Now we must sow and reap in order to be fed.

If people fail to recognize the start of this season and its requirements, they will begin to make comments such as, "This pastor just doesn't feed me the way he used to," or "Christianity just seems boring to me." The truth of the matter is, our pastor, or anyone else for that matter, will never again feed us the way he did in the first and second season of our walk. Our feeding now depends upon our own sowing and reaping.

PERSONAL EXAMPLES

2) We are required to *"plant vineyards;"* that is, produce more fruit than we can personally consume so we can give to others.

3) We do get to *"eat their fruit"* but others, not ourselves, are to become our focus.

f. If one refuses to sow and reap:

1) Will spiritually starve and eventually may fall away from the faith.

2) Will become a beggar at the banquet table of others.

a) Spiritual beggars go from person to person draining each of their resources.

b) They are always angry with the previous feeder who never quite met their needs.

c) They will tell you that no one else has been able to help them and you are God's answer for them.

d) A few months at your table and they will leave for another one, having exhausted you and your patience.

4. What Season are You in Now?

a. If you are in the First or Second Season:

1) God has planned them for you as a special time of **receiving**.

2) Receive the fullness of what God has for you now and store your spiritual seed for the coming season.

b. If you are in the Third Season:

1) The time has come for you to sow and reap and give out from what God has given you.

2) Are you bored with Christianity and having trouble finding teachings that bless you?

a) You have entered a season where in order to be blessed you must bless others.

b) This does not mean that you will never again be fed by other's teachings.

c) You will be blessed by them again as you give out of the **abundance** you have received **[Matthew 10:8; Luke 6:38]**.

3) Are you eager to give out from what God has given you but just aren't sure how to do it?

a) The Lord will give you direction as you seek Him.

b) He wants you to sow and reap even more than you do.

c. We are a fat church.

1) Our first and second seasons are filled with abundant ministry and blessings.

2) Do we enter the third season with a desire to feed others or to continue to feed ourselves?

d. What season are you in now? If the third, it's time to give out!

5. Just as God blessed Adam and Eve and gave them an assignment **[Genesis 1:28]** He has a specific **plan** for you as a one-flesh team and for your marriage **[Jeremiah 29:11]**.

a. It was assigned the day you were married.

b. It is God's will that your marriage be strong so you reach out in His name.

c. When God created Adam and Eve and gave them to each other, He immediately gave them an assignment to accomplish.

1) God also has an assignment for you.

a) In your local church or within your community.

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Just as in the natural situation described in **Isaiah 37**, you receive seed for sowing during the first two seasons. When your third season comes, you must begin to sow that seed into the lives of others in order to reap a harvest. The third season requires that we *"plant vineyards."* A vineyard, by its very nature, produces too much fruit for us to consume alone. Yes, we are to *"eat their fruit,"* but a vineyard will also produce fruit to give to others. By God's design self should no longer be our focus in the third season. God's intention is that the needs of others should now become the focus of our sowing and reaping.

If we fail to recognize this shift in God's purpose, one of two things will happen. A person refusing to sow and reap will eventually starve to death spiritually and fall away from the faith or, recognizing the need to sow and reap in order to eat but refusing to do so, he will become a beggar at the banquet table of others. Spiritual beggars go from person to person, draining them dry of all resources and then continue on to the next table. Spiritual beggars are always angry with the previous feeder who never met their needs and really did not do them justice. When you welcome a spiritual beggar to your table, you will be told that no one else has been able to help them but you, somehow, are God's answer for them. Just give them a few months at your table and when they have exhausted you and your patience they will leave for someone else. No matter how much you have done for them, it will never be enough. The reason? They are now in a season where they must sow and reap in order to be satisfied.

What season are you as a couple in now? Is it the first? Is it the second? There is nothing wrong with these seasons. If you are in one of them, enjoy this time of **receiving**. God has planned them for you and you should be blessed as you walk through them. Receive the fullness of what God has for you now and store your spiritual seed well for the coming season.

Are you in the third season? Has the time come for you to sow and reap and give out of what the Lord has poured into you? Are you bored with Christianity and can't seem to find anyone whose teaching blesses and inspires you anymore? This may be a symptom that you have entered into that time of planting vineyards and giving out into the lives of others. To be sure, this does not mean that you will never again be blessed by your pastor's sermons or by teachings you will hear. It simply means that the way to be blessed by these again is to give out of the **abundance** you have received **[Matthew 10:8; Luke 6:38]**. On the other hand, you may be eager to give out from the abundance that God has poured into you but are just not sure how to do it. God does not design a plan without specific steps to see that it is accomplished. He wants your third season to be productive even more than you do. Begin to seek Him for direction and He will show you how to sow and reap for the benefit of others.

We are a fat church! Our first and second seasons are filled to overflowing with ministry and blessings. We eat well and grow quickly, but do we then enter into the third season with a desire to feed others or to continue to feed ourselves? Which season are you in now? If it is the third season, it is time to give out of the abundance you have received.

Just as God blessed Adam and Eve and gave them an assignment together **[Genesis 1:28]**, He has a specific **plan** for you as a one-flesh team and for your marriage **[Jeremiah 29:11]**. It was assigned the day you were married. It is God's will that your marriage be strong so you can reach out in His name. When God created Adam and Eve and gave them to each other, He immediately gave them their assignment to accomplish.

PERSONAL EXAMPLES

b) Within a ministry.

2) Fulfilling your assignment is important:

a) To God.

b) To others.

c) To yourselves.

d) You are called according to His purpose **[Romans 8:28]**.

3) You may already know what it is or may still be seeking His will.

4) You need to walk in the fullness of one-flesh to accomplish your assignment.

5) Your home should be the **powerhouse** that God described in the vision of ***2=1***.

B. Preparation for the Assignment.

1. If you believe you are in your first or second season and are not functioning in fullness of one-flesh consider continuing through another Married for Life home class.
   a. Submitting to Him together, enables Him to mold us and blend us as He desires **[Romans 8:26-29]**.
   b. Scriptural principles will be **reinforced**, enabling you to walk in greater unity and strength.
   c. Attending a different class gives the opportunity to experience more than one leadership couple and teaching style.
   d. Even if you have applied yourselves well, often only surface work is completed in a marriage the first time in Married for Life.
2. Many couples need a structure in which to work.
   a. Married for Life home groups provide structure and support.
   b. Whether you continue in another group or not, allow the Lord to continue doing a deeper and deeper work in your marriage.
   c. As you as a couple grow and strengthen as one, you will be better equipped to reach out to others.

C. Determining your call [Ephesians 2:10].

1. Seek the Lord for His call on your lives.
2. Ask yourselves some questions:
   a. Where is your burden?
      1) Young people? or Older people?
      2) Singles? Or Marrieds?
   b. Burden to:
      1) Heal?
      2) Strengthen?
   c. Do you function better: Nurturing, one-to-one relationship? Teaching larger groups?
   d. Does your heart cry out to: Retrieve the lost? Strengthen the saved?
   e. Do you have a burden for children?
   f. What is your geographical burden?
      1) Church? Neighborhood?
      2) City? State?
      3) A portion of this country? Another country?

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God also has an assignment for you. It may be within your local church, within your community or within a ministry. It is important to God that you fulfill your call. It is His specific third season assignment for you. It is important to others that you fulfill your call. You are the ones assigned to minister to them. And it is important to you that you fulfill your call. True fulfillment in the Lord comes from being right in the center of His will. You have been called according to His purpose **[Romans 8:28]**.

You may already know what your assignment is or you may still be seeking God. You may still be in your first or second season and be far too tender in the process of healing to even be thinking of reaching out, but God is holding your assignment until you are ready. No matter what the case, He intends for you to walk in the fullness of one-flesh as you accept that call from Him. Your home is to be that strong, **powerhouse** home that God described in the vision of ***2=1***. It is to be an oasis of peace to the lost, a beacon to those seeking answers. It is God's desire that you and your family operate in the fullness of power that He has designed for your home. It is His desire that you sow and reap and plant vineyards for a hungry, dying world.

Preparation for the Assignment

If you do not believe you are in the third season yet, we recommend that you continue with Married for Life again. As we submit to Him together, we enable Him to mold us and blend us as He desires **[Romans 8:26-29]**. The scriptural principles that you have learned during these first few weeks will be **reinforced** and become more a part of your life, enabling you to walk in greater unity and strength. You will obtain more spiritual food for yourselves and more "seed" for sowing when your third season arrives. Many couples attend more than one Married for Life class, experiencing a variety of leadership couples and teaching styles. Even if you have applied yourselves well, often only a surface work is accomplished the first time through a Married for Life class. Many couples find it difficult to continue concentrating on what God wants to do in their marriage without a structure in which to work. A Married for Life class provides that structure and support. Whether you decide to continue on with another Married for Life class or not, though, allow the Lord to continue doing a deeper and deeper work in your marriage. As you are strengthened and grow in Jesus as one, you will be better equipped to reach out to others.

Determining your call [Ephesians 2:10]

Perhaps you sense you are in that third season and are aware of the wealth that God has deposited within you but you are not sure what your specific assignment is. Seek God for His call on your lives **[Ephesians 2:10]** and then begin to ask yourselves some questions.

Where is your burden? Do you feel drawn toward young people? Old people? Singles? Married? Do you have a burden to heal or a burden to strengthen?

Do you function better in a nurturing, one-on-one relationship or are you more comfortable teaching larger groups?

Does your heart cry out for the lost and do you see them everywhere you go?

Do you have a greater burden to see those that already know Jesus grow stronger in His Word? Do you desire to see children know Jesus to the fullest and have them grounded in His Word? What is your geographical burden - your church? your neighborhood? your city? your state? a section of the country? another country?

PERSONAL EXAMPLES

3. Usually the **desire** of your heart is what you have been called to do.
   a. Remember you are called as one-flesh.
      1) God will give each spouse **specifics** of the call.
      2) Blend the specifics together for the total call.
   b. Initially burdens may be based on your own need for ministry.
      1) Allow God to minister to you and heal you.
      2) As you are healed, your burden may change.
      3) His call on your one-flesh team will become more and more fine-tuned.
   c. It is important to seek Him together as one-flesh.
4. Seek God for instructions for carrying out your assignment.
   a. He will teach you how to fulfill your call as **one**.
   b. One spouse may already be ministering and waiting for the other to "come along."
      1) Instructions may be different now as the Lord trains you as one.
      2) Be sensitive to the Holy Spirit.

D. Maturing Together/Example of the Plant.

1. **Roots** of plant must deepen in direct proportion to upward growth **[Isaiah 37:31]**.
2. Your prayer and Word time must increase as you grow in ministry together.
   a. Ministry must flow out of your relationship with God and each other.
   b. As your involvement in your assignment increases, there will be a temptation to decrease your prayer and Word time.
   c. You must discipline yourselves to spend MORE time in these activities.
3. If you outgrow your spiritual root system, your marriage will suffer.

E. Attacks Against One-flesh Ministry.

1. Enemy will send distractions.
   a. We must overcome them.
   b. **Proverbs 12:24 (NIV)**.
      1) Diligence brings rule in area of assignment.
      2) Laziness brings captivity to the desires of the enemy.
   c. **Proverbs 22:29 (NIV)**.
      1) You are called to rule and reign with Jesus.
      2) Become **diligent** by being schooled by the Holy Spirit.
2. Being secure in your assignment and instructions will prevent enemy from deterring you.
   a. Be single-minded.
   b. Don't allow the enemy to separate you from one another.
      1) This will be his constant goal.
      2) You are wise as serpents and gentle as doves **[Matthew 10:16]**.

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You will be surprised how the very **desire** of your heart is what you have been called to do. What if one of you is burdened and the other is not? Remember, you are seeking your one-flesh assignment. Whatever God is calling you to do, He will give each spouse **specifics** of that assignment. When you blend the specifics together, you will have the total assignment. For instance, maybe one of you has a great burden to minister to children. Perhaps the other spouse has never felt called to do that but has an equally great burden to go to the mission field. Instead of concentrating on each of your separate desires, begin to seek the Lord together as to His plan. It could well be that He plans for you to minister to children in other countries. One burden does not negate the other. See how God would blend them.

Very often, as we seek God's specific assignment for us, we discover that the burdens we have felt stem from our own need for ministry in a given area. As we allow the Lord to minister to us and heal us, the burden of our heart may very well change. His call on our lives becomes more and more fine-tuned. This is why it is so important for both spouses to be seeking God and hearing from Him.

Once you know what you are called to do as a one-flesh team, make sure that you wait on the Lord for instructions. He is going to teach you to fulfill your call as **one**. Maybe one of you has already been ministering, waiting on your spouse to "come along." God intends to train you now as one-flesh and the instructions will be different than they have been in the past. Be sensitive to the direction of His Spirit.

Maturing Together/Example of the Plant

Remember also that the **roots** of a plant must deepen in direct proportion to the upward growth of the plant **[Isaiah 37:31]**. As you grow in your ministry assignment it is essential that your prayer and Word time deepen accordingly. You cannot expect to accomplish mighty exploits for God with a puny root system. Your ministry must always flow out of your relationship with God and with each other. As activities increase there will be a tendency to spend less time in prayer and the Word because of time constraints. **It is imperative that you discipline yourselves to spend more time in prayer and in the word as the temptation comes to** decrease **them**. If you outgrow your root system, your marriage will suffer the consequences.

Knowing that you are in your third season and knowing what you are called to do, is not enough. There will be many subtle attacks sent against you to keep you from accomplishing that which you are called to do. Distractions will always be there. You must learn to overcome them. **Proverbs 12:24** says, *"Diligent hands will rule, but laziness ends in slave labor"* (NIV).

Attacks Against One-flesh Ministry

The enemy desires to thwart your call, to keep you from accomplishing what God has designed for you to do. Diligence brings rule in the area of assignment. Laziness brings captivity to the desires of the enemy. **Proverbs 22:29 (NIV)** declares, *"Do you see a man skilled in his work? He will serve before kings; he will not serve before obscure men."* You are called to rule and reign with Jesus. He desires that you be *"skilled in your work,"* regarding your assignment from Him.

The only way to become **diligent** is be schooled by the Holy Spirit. You must develop a close relationship with Him and allow Him to direct and guide you. The ability to hear His voice comes from spending quality time with Him, in His presence, praying

F. Evaluation.

1. It is good to periodically stop and evaluate where your one-flesh team is headed.
   a. Need to set Spirit-led goals.
   b. Seek God for His direction in your marriage.
      1) What is your assignment?
      2) What is your next step?
      3) What does God have for you as a couple?
2. God has a one-flesh assignment for you.
   a. ***2=1*** offers opportunity to minister to marriages.
   b. In the back of your manual you will find a description of ministry opportunities and requirements.
   c. God bless you both as you continue on from this point with Him.

Congratulations! You have discovered the power that God gives when two become one. Stay united and use it to change your home and your neighborhood.

Interactive

We are going to take a few minutes now for you to fill in the exit evaluation sheet on the next page of your manual. When you are done, please place it in the envelope provided and turn it in to us. This evaluation will help us to know how to pray in agreement with you.

(Wait for all couples to finish)

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and listening. When you are secure in His call and in His instructions, the distractions the enemy sends your way will not deter you. You will be single-minded in your response to Him. The enemy's greatest tactic against you will be to separate you from one another. His most subtle attacks are designed to divide you. No matter how much you mature together, this tactic will never change. Remember, you are wise as serpents and gentle as doves **[Matthew 10:16]**. You are not each other's enemy. You are both essential for the fulfillment of your ministry. **Do not allow the enemy to divide you!**

Evaluation

It is a good discipline to develop a periodic evaluation of where you are, where you have come from, and where you are headed. You need to set Spirit-led goals, to seek God for each new direction in your life. Do you know what God has for you as a couple? Do you know your assignment? Do you know your next step?

The life application for this lesson will provide you with a similar evaluation for yourselves.

If you are interested in ministering to marriages and families with ***2=1***, a description of ministry opportunities and requirements can be found in the back of the couples' manual.

Congratulations! You have discovered the power that God gives when two become one. Stay united and use it to change your home and your neighborhood.

Interactive

We are going to take a few minutes now for you to fill in the exit evaluation sheet on the next page of your manual. When you are done, please place it in the envelope provided and turn it in to us. This evaluation will help us to know how to pray in agreement with you.

(Wait for all couples to finish)

PERSONAL EXAMPLES

Life Application - Let's make it real

It is always good for us to realize how far God has brought us. Setting markers along our way helps us to remember where we were and appreciate where we are now. Record below how each of the twelve weeks of your Married for Life group have ministered to specific areas of your marriage.

The Power of Covenant _____

_____

_____

The Power of 2=1 _____

_____

_____

The Power of Synergism _____

_____

_____

The Power of Sowing and Reaping_____

_____

_____

The Power of Forgiveness _____

_____

_____

The Power of Faith _____

_____

_____

The Power of Spiritual Intimacy _____

_____

_____

The Power of Agreement _____

_____

_____

The Power of Physical Intimacy _____

_____

_____

The Power of Spiritual Warfare_____

_____

_____

The Power of Transformation _____

_____

_____

_____

The Power of One _____

_____

_____

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1. Which areas are the most difficult for you and present the greatest challenge for improvement?

What are you doing to work on these areas as one-flesh?

2. Discuss as a couple what season you believe you are in now. In your own personal walk with the Lord you may vary in growth and development but this question is regarding you as a one-flesh team. Are you still in a season of self-focus and primarily receiving or have you moved into the third season? If you are in the first or second season, how do you see God using what you are now receiving?

If you have entered into the third season, how are you now sowing and reaping and planting vineyards?

3. In order to consistently move forward in our one-flesh relationship we need to set specific goals and work toward them. Without goals we have no way of measuring our progress. Someone once said, “If you aim for nothing, you will probably hit it.” In the remainder of this homework, set two personal goals (two each for husband and wife), two one-flesh goals, and two goals related to your call as one-flesh. Following each goal set a one-month, three-month, six-month, and nine-month objective that will help you meet that goal in one year’s time. By meeting short-term objectives, the goals will be accomplished on a timely basis.

Personal goals **(Wife)**

Goal 1: _____

_____

Goal 2: _____

_____

Now state what you will do by one month from now, three months from now, six months from now, and nine months from now to meet each of these goals.

Wife

Goal 1: _____

One month _____

_____

_____

Three months_____

_____

_____

Six months _____

_____

_____

_____

Nine months_____

_____

Goal 2: _____

One month _____

_____

_____

Three months_____

_____

_____

Six months _____

_____

_____

Nine months_____

_____

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Personal goals **(Husband)**

Goal 1: _____

_____

Goal 2: _____

_____

Now state what you will do by one month from now, three months from now, six months from now, and nine months from now to meet each of these goals.

Husband

Goal 1: _____

One month _____

_____

_____

Three months_____

_____

_____

Six months _____

_____

_____

Nine months_____

_____

Goal 2: _____

One month _____

_____

_____

Three months_____

_____

_____

Six months _____

_____

_____

Nine months_____

_____

One-flesh

Goal 1: _____

One month _____

_____

_____

Three months_____

_____

_____

Six months _____

_____

_____

Nine months_____

_____

_____

Goal 2: _____

One month _____

_____

_____

Three months_____

_____

_____

Six months _____

_____

_____

Nine months_____

_____

_____

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Goals related to your assignment

Goal 1: _____

One month _____

_____

_____

Three months_____

_____

_____

Six months _____

_____

_____

Nine months_____

_____

Goal 2: _____

One month _____

_____

_____

Three months_____

_____

_____

Six months _____

_____

_____

Nine months_____

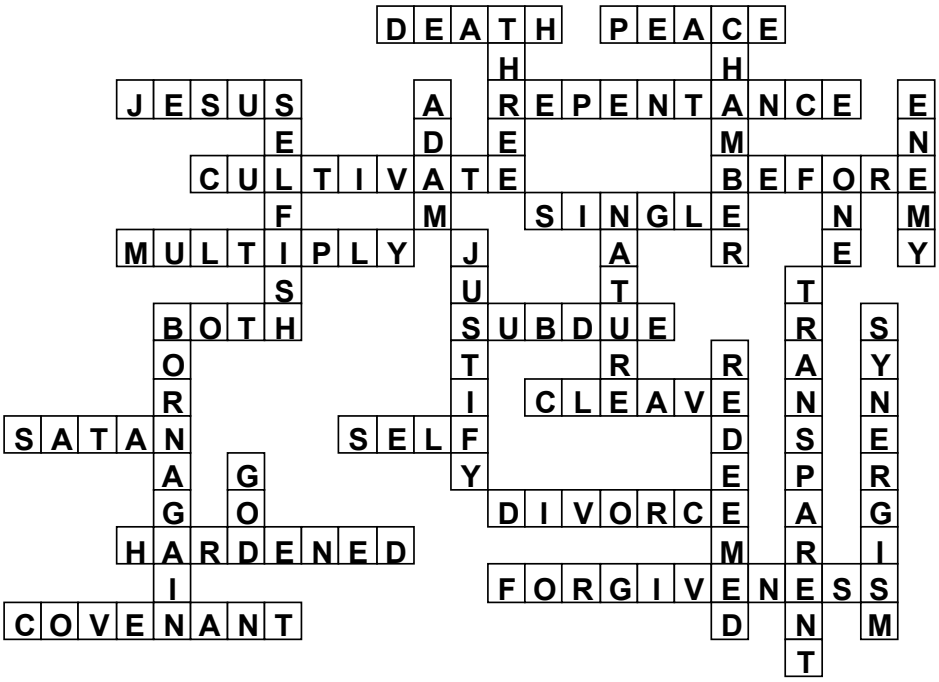
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Be diligent in meeting these goals. All of us need structure in which to grow. Let this be your guideline as the Spirit leads you on in your growth together. Remember, this is just the beginning of the rest of your life together. Allow Jesus to work in you and through you to make the very most of it.

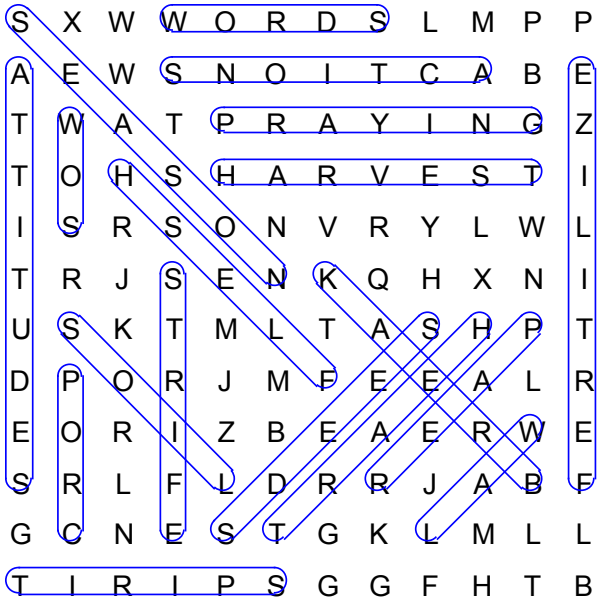
God will always give you what you are willing to give away.

Puzzle Solutions

Crossword Puzzle Page 40



Word Search Page 84



Cryptogram Page 96

When you forgive, you in no way change the past - but you sure do change the future--
Bernard Meltzer

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(To be completed by the Coaches in Training and mailed with the report to the Home Office.)

COACHES IN TRAINING SELF-EVALUATION

COACHES IN TRAINING: STATE: _____

ADDRESS: GROUP #: _____

NAME OF COACHING COUPLE:

****

Describe your marriage when you began the Married for Life class.

What changes have been made in your life as a result of being in the Married for Life class?

In what areas of coaching do you feel qualified?

In what areas of coaching do you feel inadequate?

List the strengths and weaknesses of your training as your perceive them.

Briefly share your vision for your ministry now that you are ready to begin a Married for Life class of your own. What does ***2=1*** coaching mean to you?

What would you ask of your leadership, both locally and in the national office, before you begin a group of your own?

Anticipated Class Start Date: _____

(To be completed by the Coaching Couple and mailed with your report to the Home Office)

COACHING COUPLE'S GROUP EVALUATION

COACHING COUPLE: STATE _____

ADDRESS: GROUP # _____

Briefly describe each couple as they complete your class. Are they tracking well as one-flesh? Are they born-again and baptized in the Holy Spirit? Are they hurting? Did they reach out to receive all that is available to them? Do they need to attend another class? Have you talked with them about it? Any other observations you would like to share.

Couple 1:

Couple 2:

Couple 3:

Couple 4:

Couple 5:

Coaches in Training:

Evaluate how you feel you are doing in the following areas.

Teaching:

Keeping the meeting on track:

Coaching your Coaches in Training:

Receiving the financial giving of class members:

What blessed you most about this class?

How can your Coaching Team be of greater help to you?

What comments or suggestions would you like to share with us concerning your class, the lessons, your own development as Coaches, your team support system, etc.?

Anticipated Start Date of Next Class: _____

Suggestions for Life Application Discussions

The purpose of the discussion each week is to discover what is happening in the lives of the couples as a result of the lesson and the life application. It is not so much a time of seeing what answers they gave for specific questions as it is getting the bigger picture about what is happening in their lives. Here are some suggestions for your discussion times. These are **just suggestions** if you are having trouble with questions of your own.

Week 1, The Power of Covenant

Did any of you look up your wedding vows? If so, what did you discover you said? Do any of those words have new meaning in light of last week's lesson?

How was it going through the Bible studying together?

What does covenant mean to you personally now?

Anything dramatic happen this week as a result of what you learned? (Hopefully this will lead into a discussion of anyone getting born again or canceling a divorce, etc.)

Week 2, The Power of 2=1

Did you get any new revelation out of last week's lesson? How has this changed your relationship?

Have you ever thought of yourselves as one before? Any new insights?

Last week's lesson may have been a little tough for you if you were married before. Do you want to share how it has impacted you?

If divorce has been a word you have used in the past, do you plan to use it again?

Week 3, The Power of Synergism

What was your biggest revelation this week?

What responsibilities have you taken on or given up as a result of what you are learning?

What did you think about the example of the gears? Do you feel like you are meshing?

Did anything you learned this week help you feel freer in your role of husband or wife?

Week 4, The Power of Sowing and Reaping

Did you see any patterns of sowing and reaping in your marriage over the years?

What do you see in your children that reflects sowing and reaping?

Which is easier for you to recognize, the harvest or what you are sowing?

Are you having any trouble focusing mostly on the bad crops? Can you see good seeds you have sown as well?

Week 5, The Power of Forgiveness

Anything that was particularly tough for you to face this week?

Did you discover any bitterness or long-term unforgiveness that you hadn't seen before?

Were you able to help each other forgive others?

Did you realize you had taken up offenses for your spouse or children?

Week 6, The Power of Faith

Did faith become more real or more practical to you this week? If so, how?

Is there any one area where you feel you really need to develop faith?

Share about your faith vision for your spouse. Was it tough to develop it or did you enjoy it?

How about your faith vision together for your marriage and family?

Week 7, The Power of Spiritual Intimacy

How are you doing praying together?

Are you having any difficulty separating out personal concerns from joint concerns?

What types of things have you heard from the Lord?

Have you asked for the Baptism of the Holy Spirit? What happened?

Week 8, The Power of Agreement

Do you have something specific that you are praying to come into agreement concerning?

Do you have any examples of something in the past that you did without agreement and are still working on unraveling/

How can agreement bring protection in your relationship?

Do you need any help with praying in the spirit?

Week 9, The Power of Physical Intimacy

Has wounding from your past affected your physical intimacy?

How did what you learned last week help bring healing?

Realizing that physical intimacy doesn't start in the bedroom, do you feel free to share any of the things the Lord is prompting you to change in your life?

If your realize there are things in your life that are hindering your physical intimacy, we are here to help you resolve those issues. Let us know if you want help.

Week 10, The Power of Spiritual Warfare

How do you feel about the concepts of radar and warrior?

Do you have a recent "incident report" to share?

Have you experienced personally the increase in power when you fight spiritual warfare together?

Can you think of examples from your own life of both offensive and defensive battles?

Week 11, The Power of Transformation

What life pattern has become really clear to you this week?

Can you share one character quality you are focusing on developing right now?

If you feel you just dumped hidden sin on your spouse instead of praying for God's timing and preparation, we are here to help the two of you deal with the consequences.

Do you see generational patterns in your family that you want to stop with you?

Week 12, The Power of One (If you get together before your Graduation Night)

Do you have some idea of the assignment God has given you?

If not, how are you working together to discover it?

If so, what do you believe your next step is?

How can we pray for you as this time together is ending?

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Forms Section

Here's how to fill them out, whether you are using online forms or mailing them in.

Keep your evaluations simple and to the point. What is happening in each couple's life? Are they making progress? What follow-up is needed?

Send the finances with the report. Write a cash replacement check for any cash you keep. Make sure you designate "cash replacement" in the memo.

If you are using electronic forms, you will need to make a hard copy and send it with the finances to the Home Office. You can email all copies though.

MARRIED FOR LIFE - WEEK #1 IMPACT REPORT

(Please Print, Press Hard & Use A Black Pen)

CITY: City where Coaching Couple lives STATE/PROVINCE: REGION:

Indicate the time the class began and ended

MEETING DATE: Date on which the class met TIME BEGAN: TIME ENDED:

COACHES: CLASS ID#:

CITs: ID#

Report on What Happened In Weekly Meeting of the Coaching Team:

Report on the meeting between the Leadership Team

Date: _____

Time Began: _____

CLASS MEMBERS

Have each couple complete their information.

Attended: X H

Name *Ben and Sonia Jones*

Address *101 Main St*

City *Anytown* State *CO*

Zip *80013*

Phone *303 555-2134*

Check#
Fee
Rec'd. New $ *50* Alumni $

Attended: H

Name

Address

City State

Zip

Phone

Check#
Fee
Rec'd. New $ Alumni $

Attended: H W

Name

Address

City State

Zip

Phone

Check#
Fee
Rec'd. New $ Alumni $

Attended: H W

Name

Address

City State

Zip

Phone

Check#
Fee
Rec'd. New $ Alumni $

Attended: H

Name

Address

City State

Zip

Phone

Check#
Fee
Rec'd. New $ Alumni $

REGISTRATION FEES ENCLOSED

Registrations Total Enclosed

FOR OFFICE USE

Date Batch#

Indicate on checks if the amount is for Giving, Purchase or Cash Replacement. Make sure the amount of CASH giving is written on giving envelopes.

INCOME	Checks	Cash	TOTAL
Contributions:	Fill in appropriate amount of money in each category. Then total		$
Other:			$
Less Stamp's Expense ONLY ($12.00)			

FOR OFFICE USE ONLY

Date:

Batch #: Line#:

Items:

For National Office use

Counted By: Coaching Couple's Signature
CITs' Signature

Signature of one spouse from each of the leadership couples who counted the financial giving

Who prayed over the giving? Indicate who prayed

Snail Mail: White copy to National Office with giving Pink/Gold copies to your leaders (they mail a copy to Printed in USA

Electronic Mail: Print a copy and send it to the National Office with giving Email one copy to your City/Area Directors and one to your State Directors

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Week #1 Impact Form

The Coaching Team completes the Week #1 Impact form following the first class meeting.

Mail: Mail the white copy and the funds to the National Office the day following the meeting. Mail the yellow and pink copies to your Coaching Team Leaders.

Electronic Forms: Make a hard copy of the form and snail mail it along with the funds to the National Office. Email a copy of the form to your Team Leaders.

Collecting Data

Have each couple complete their names, addresses, and registration information. The way they write their names here will be how they will appear on their graduation certificates.

Counting Funds

After each meeting two people count the funds (one from each Coaching Couple). Total the amount of cash and checks received. Please DO NOT MAIL CASH.

Cash received should be converted to either a personal check or a money order before it is mailed. Be sure to mark ***"cash replacement"*** on the check or money order so that you will not receive personal credit for giving that money.

The giving envelopes should be mailed along with the weekly report so that those giving cash can receive proper tax credit. Mail the funds with the white copy of the weekly report to the National Office. Mail the rest of the copies in the envelope(s) provided according to the instructions on the bottom of the form or email them if you are using electronic forms.

MARRIED FOR LIFE WEEKLY IMPACT REPORT©

(Please print, use black ink, and press hard)

CITY: City where Coaching Couple lives STATE/PROVINCE: _____ REGION: _____

Indicate total number of couples present

MEETING DATE: Date on which the class met Total Couples Present _____ Class Began _____ Ended _____

Indicate the time the class began and ended

COACHES: CLASS ID#:

CIT: ID#:

Report Of What Happened In The Weekly Meeting Of The Leadership Team

Report on the meeting between the Leadership Team

Date _____

Time Began _____

Time Ended _____

Please put an "X" in the appropriate weekly box and circle the appropriate course Follow the directions given

☐ Week 1 MFL PFL OFL	☐ Week 5 MFL PFL OFL	☐ Week 9 MFL PFL
☐ Week 2 MFL PFL OFL	☐ Week 6 MFL PFL OFL	☐ Week 10 MFL
☐ Week 3 MFL PFL OFL	☐ Week 7 MFL PFL OFL	☐ Week 11 MFL
☐ Week 4 MFL PFL OFL	☒ Week 8 (MFL) PFL OFL	☐ Week 12 MFL

Please check appropriate boxes for each couple including leadership team

Names	Applying Lessons	Doing Life Application	Need Follow Up	Comments/Prayer Requests	Absent	Present	Dropped
Fill in name of each couple. Check appropriate boxes and write comments as needed	☐ H ☐ W	☐ H ☐ W	☐				
	☐ H ☐ W	☐ H ☐ W	☐				
EXAMPLES *John and Sarah Smith*	☒ H ☒ W	☒ H ☐ W	☒	*Having a difficult time working through forgiveness*			
Ben and Sonia Jones	☒ H ☒ W	☒ H ☒ W	☐	*Amazing progress. Applying principles*			
	☐ H ☐ W	☐ H ☐ W	☐				
	☐ H ☐ W	☐ H ☐ W	☐				
	☐ H ☐ W	☐ H ☐ W	☐				
	☐ H ☐ W	☐ H ☐ W	☐				
	☐ H ☐ W	☐ H ☐ W	☐				
	☐ H ☐ W	☐ H ☐ W	☐				
	☐ H ☐ W	☐ H ☐ W	☐				

Indicate on checks if the amount is for Giving, Purchase or Cash Replacement. Make sure the amount of CASH giving is written on giving envelopes.

INCOME	Checks	Cash	Credit Card	TOTAL
Contributions	Fill in appropriate amount of money in each category. Then total.			
Sales				
Registrations				
Other				
			Total Funds Enclosed:	

ACCOUNTING DEPARTMENT

Date:

Batch#:

Items:

Notes

For National Office use

Giving counted by: CC Signature: CIT Signature: Signature of one spouse from each of the leadership couples who counted the financial giving

Who prayed over the giving? Indicate who prayed

Snail Mail: White copy to National Office with giving Pink/Gold copies to your leaders (they mail a copy to the State Directors)

Electronic Mail: Print a copy and send it to the National Office with giving Email one copy to your City/Area Directors and one to your State Directors

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Weekly Impact Form

The Coaching Team completes the Weekly Impact form each week following the class meeting.

Mail: Mail the white copy and the funds to the National Office the day following the meeting. Mail the yellow and pink copies to your Team Leaders.

Electronic Forms: Make a hard copy of the form and snail mail it along with the funds to the National Office. Email a copy of the form to your Team Leaders.

Counting Funds

After each meeting two people count the funds (one from each Coaching Couple). Total the amount of cash and checks received. Please DO NOT MAIL CASH.

Cash received should be converted to either a personal check or a money order before it is mailed. Be sure to mark ***"cash replacement"*** on the check or money order so that you will not receive personal credit for giving that money.

The giving envelopes should be mailed along with the weekly report so that those giving cash can receive proper tax credit. Mail the funds with the white copy of the weekly report to the National Office. Mail the rest of the copies in the envelope(s) provided according to the instructions on the bottom of the form or email them if you are using electronic forms.

2=1 GRADUATION REPORT Course_____

(PLEASE PRINT, PRESS HARD AND USE A BLACK PEN)

*CITY:*_____ *STATE:*_____ *REGION:*_____

*GRADUATION DATE:*_____

COACHING COUPLE _____ *LEAD ID#* _____

Complete each section.

*COACHES IN TRAINING*_____

If more than one group is involved in this Outreach please put other CC ID #'s here _____

LOCATION OF MEETING _____

*TOTAL NUMBER OF COUPLES*_____ *HOW MANY WERE FROM* ***2=1*** *GROUPS?*_____

NUMBER OF COUPLES WHO PRE-REGISTERED AT THIS MEETING _____

TIME MEETING BEGAN _____ *TIME MEETING ENDED* _____

COUPLES ASSIGNED TO ASSIST

*GREETERS*_____

*GUEST LIST*_____

*REFRESHMENTS*_____

HIGHLIGHTS OF MEETING

EXAMPLE:

Each couple shared what God had done for them during the class. Not a dry eye in the house! The Jones' testimony was particularly touching since they had been divorced for four years and are now going to be remarried. Their children came with them to the graduation and shared what it is like in their home now that "mom and dad love each other again."

Smith's pastor attended and wants to get classes going for couples in his church. Thompsons will follow up with him to arrange a training. We had a ceremony to give out the certificates and John Cain played the flute while his wife Mary Lee performed an interpretive dance. It was powerful!

Please have couples INDICATE on their checks or envelopes if the amount is for GIVING

Indicate on checks if the amount is for Giving, Purchase or Cash Replacement. Make sure the amount of CASH giving is

INCOME	*Checks*	*Cash*	*TOTAL*	*FOR OFFICE USE ONLY*
Giving:	Fill in appropriate amount of money in each category. Then total.			*Date:*
Other:				*Batch #:*
Invoice#:				*Items:*
				For National Office use

Signature of one spouse from each of the leadership couples who counted the financial giving

Counted By: *Coaching Cpl. Signature*
Coaches in Training Signature

Who prayed over the giving? Indicate who prayed

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Graduation Report Form

The Coaching Team completes the Graduation Report form following the class graduation.

Mail: Mail the white copy and the funds to the National Office the day following the meeting. Mail the yellow and pink copies to your Team Leaders.

Electronic Forms: Make a hard copy of the form and snail mail it along with the funds to the National Office. Email a copy of the form to your Team Leaders.

Share the Details: Fill in the information requested in each section. Some examples are included.

Counting Funds

After each meeting two people count the funds (one from each leadership couple). Total the amount of cash and checks received. Please DO NOT MAIL CASH.

Cash received should be converted to either a personal check or a money order before it is mailed. Be sure to mark ***"cash replacement"*** on the check or money order so that you will not receive personal credit for giving that money.

The giving envelopes should be mailed along with the weekly report so that those giving cash can receive proper tax credit. Mail the funds with the white copy of the weekly report to the National Office. Mail the rest of the copies in the envelope(s) provided according to the instructions on the bottom of the form or email them if you are using electronic forms.

GUEST LIST

Ministry

(Please Print & Use A Black Pen)

CITY: _____ *STATE:* _____ *REGION:*

MEETING DATE: _____

COACHING COUPLE _____

COACHES IN TRAINING _____ *ID#*

PLEASE PRINT!!!!!!!

LAST NAME FIRST NAMES (Husband & Wife)	MAILING ADDRESS CITY/STATE/ZIP	PHONE INCLUDE AREA CODE EMAIL

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Guest List

This is to be filled out by guests to any ***2=1*** event.

Collecting Data: Have guests fill in their information on this form.

Mail: Mail this completed form to the Home Office for input into the database.